No Shoes, No Service

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Mature

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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by [redacted]

Summary

Adora's job as a front of house to a busy club, post college, is not what she wanted. Well, not all she wanted. She has friends, steady work, a few classes.... but what else? What does she have to aim for, now her college life is done?

A former friend with an axe to grind, a future she doesn't know how to chase. What do you do when everything seems to want to derail you.

Notes

A trial for a short AU I'm working on. Should probably be about 2-3 chapters, more of a "testing the water" if there's interest, I might expand. Was thinking I could do a single run, but want to see thoughts on this little extract first!

Chapter 1

Fridays were always busy. You had the "just in for a swift one" crowd; the "Oh god what a week" crowd; and the ever-present "Let's get wasted!" crowd. The levels of belligerence across said groups was *never* predictable. Some frat-boys could be the most polite and patient group, whilst a hedge-fund up-and-comer would try to headbutt someone. No joke, she'd seen a girl do that once to Huntara. It hadn't ended well for the girl. To tell the truth, *The Brightmoon* didn't tend to attract too many of the hardened drinkers until later in the evening, when the dance floor got opened and then got *busy*. Most of the evening it was just a bar like any other. Nice ambience, low lighting, decently laid out booths, tables and side-bars. Plush, pastel interiors. It was a place to drink and relax, not really to get utterly destroyed Until they opened the Runestone, their downstairs bar at 9, which gave them more options to entertain.

But they also had a limit, so here she was. Front of house. And technically evening security manager.

Adora blew a frond of hair from her eyes and glared at the clipboard. She didn't *dislike* her job, not exactly. It's just the muted music coming from inside and the woman in front of her claiming to "*know the owner*" were vying to fry her last nerve. She'd had to skip the gym today and her part time classes were being messed around. And rent was due. And. And. And.

Working nights whilst trying to live a full day was *draining*. Working towards that qualification in Business Management and Project Management, whilst trying to keep up with the gym, whilst *also* trying to keep up with being a functional human being was starting to take a toll. Not that she was being much of a functional human outside of work. Her friends had started to comment on her absence, her zeal in focus. She'd made a note to take some time to try and work out how to balance things, maybe just a break or something. Try and hit the scene again. Except *that* thought made her heart ache in a way

she didn't want to really investigate. In her mind she had to believe it was worth it. She'd left college with a mostly good degree in Physical therapy. She wanted to start her own business, run classes... but she thought she needed some *business acumen* or something. Angela had spoken about it. But mainly she'd needed money. So, this job. Get the cash. Invest in more qualifications. Eventually bite the bullet and start actually *building her brand* as Glimmer said. She wasn't *scared* of that. Not at all. Not just throwing everything into that dream and seeing where it went. No. The idea of having no idea of how it could turn out was not terrifying and like an endless void of worry. Not. At. All.

So, for now, she focused on something she could control. That she knew she was good at.

Her eyes flicked up and the woman in front of her faltered as Adora's grey-blue's focused on her. To her right, Adora could hear Huntara chuckle. Huntara was the "muscle" at the front. Or rather she was the *visible* muscle. She was a good foot taller than Adora, who wasn't exactly short herself. Except Huntara wore a waistcoat and white shirt with the sleeves rolled up, revealing tattooed, purple skin. Adora, on the other hand, wore a faded red Blazer and white dress pants. Her clothing wasn't baggy, but it helped make her look *less* threatening than the pony-tailed *warrior* of a woman next to her.

The woman in front of her tried again, goat eyes shifting left and right as she adjusted the loose vest top and mini-skirt she'd decided to wear out. A good decision, considering how warm it was. Adora didn't let herself get *too* interested in the girl's form. Not on duty plus this one had a *really* bleating voice, "Look, Angella know's me, we go wayyyyy back."

"Ohhhh, old Mystacor buddies, eh? Class of...what, 89?"

"Oh, uh, yeah, yeah totally!"

"Except your DOB says... You were born in 82. Damn, good going hitting a masters degree at *seven*."

"I um, my people, we uh, mature fast...and...and this is profiling!"

"Ma'am, get back in line please. We'd love your custom, but if you want VIP entrance, front up and talk to the check in desk, once you *reach the front of the line*. *NEXT!"*

The woman spluttered and looked like she was about to argue. Adora had returned her gaze back to her clipboard, but then refocused on the girl and cocked her head. She gave a shake of her head and the goat-girl swallowed, then backed off. Adora watched her traipse back to the end of the line, then flicked back to the clipboard. She tapped her pen at it and hummed. Not many for the VIP booths, no familiar names either.

"So, didn't want that one's number?"

Adora sighed and looked at Huntara, "No, thank you. Feels...weird to do that. Like, bribery? Nah, nope, nuh UH."

Huntara shrugged, "Law of the jungle, Dora. Sometimes you gotta *eat* to survive,"

Adora snorted and shook her head at her coworker's eyebrow waggle. Her earpiece buzzed, notifying her she could let some more of the slowly growing crowd in. She put the clipboard under one arm and fished her clicker counter out of her pocket, then stepped forward and removed the velvet rope barrier in front of the queue. She counted through ten more and then clicked the rope shut again. The new group at the front gave mock hisses of disappointment and she flashed them a half smirk, "Patience. You're *nearly* there."

The group, a few lizards and a suited lamb-woman grinned and nodded. The girl leaned forward, "So, uh, is the *buff* cocktail guy in tonight?"

Adora's brow crinkled, "Mermista?"

"Uh, she's"...

Adora snorted, a little too quickly, shaking her head to hide her blush, "Naaaaaah, jokes! Uh, you mean Bow? Yeah he's in the basement bar, dance floor tonight."

The girl squeed and one of the lizards rumbled something at her, grinning. She shoved his arm, "Yeah, so what? I'd like him to mix me up something *good*. Swizzle stick!"

Adora shook her head and looked at the board. The girl was going to be out of luck. Bow had three loves - cocktail making, his Mechanical Engineering degree and a certain, faintly oblivious room-mate of theirs. Frankly, Adora had been shocked Glimmer hadn't worked it out yet. But then again she *was* juggling the fact that Angela wanted her to take the club at some point at the same time as wanting Glimmer to complete a rather demanding business degree. Plus additional classes on the side. Maybe some networking events. And whatever else the current owner of *Brightmoon* thought might help her daughter succeed in the future.

Frankly, watching Glimmer was an exercise in exhaustion. So, when even I need emotional hints attached to a tank shell and fired at me - Adora had spotted the CLEAR crush she had been *very* confused about why her normally observant bestie hadn't. Until she saw Glimmer near collapse after a full day and Bow had just *helped*. And not pushed anything.. She wondered whether Bow had been, as some called it, "Friend Zoned" for now. That, or Glimmer thought he was gay. Or Ace. Or whatever. Adora had decided that was a minefield she did *not* need.

Her idle thoughts were distracted by another buzz in her ear from the girl manning the cloakroom desk and reception, Starla. She was a new hire but very good at the whole customer service thing. Once the crowd got past Adora and Huntara's usual double act the change with a smiling bombshell of a woman and a relaxing ambience made them just *melt*.

She clicked the group through and watched as the lamb-girl practically bounced through the open double doors into the bar's

reception. She noticed the group take the steps down to the *Runestone* straight after checking their coats. *Oh dear.* Mused Adora, *she's gonna run up a tab trying to get Bow's attention* .

The nekgroup she didnt even bother clicking in, grinning as Netossa and Spinnerella approached the rope, "Why are you *queuing* ?Y ou know youre on the automatic entry list. ust walk up!"

Spinerella smiled gently, "W e could, but it just seems.overbearing."

Netossa huffed and rolled her eyes, "T ake advantage now and then, darling!Angella doesnt mind, heck *she set it up* ."

Spinerella looked at her companion, "Y es darling. But if we didnt qeue, you wouldnt have told me all about your day before going straight to the bar-snacks."

The pair mock glared at each other and Adora waved them through with a comment of "Get a booth you two"…

t was nearly eleven when *problems* started. A rowdy bachelor party wanted in and they wanted *special treatment* .

"C'mon honey . Look, m, like sure we can work something out. How about lincentivise you"?

The best man (An ironic title if ever there was one) was a bulky man wearing his shirt undone to his navel. His blonde hair was slicked back and he had the air of a man who got what he wanted. Exept he wasnt qite upright and his eyes were faintly glazed from the drinks he'd clearly had before arriving. Behind him, one of the bachelor group members whooped as the groom bent over double to start hacking and coughing.

Adora ignored the man and pointedly stared at the groom, who seemed to be trying not to vomit. She then looked back at the best man, "Nope. Not have my paycheqe hit because Ilet someone in

who was about to spray and pray everywhere. Got other patrons to think about."

"Hey , we're comin' in. This place, it' s not a proper night without finishing in the Brightmoon! C'mon, he'll be fine."

A wet whimper came from behind the best man. Adora snorted and shook her head, "No, not tonight."

The man's demeanour changed and he stepped up into her space, "We're comin' in, and no jumped up sales girl is gonna stop us. So, just tell the bar to give us a nice booth, some drinks and I'll overlook how ru-"

Adora held up a hand as Huntara stepped over. It was the hand holding the clipboard. The best man's gaze flicked to the big woman, then back to Adora. She set her face into a flat, expressionless stare, "Back away , sir. We don't tolerate *rudeness* to our staff."

"Or what, you'll set your dog of a girlfriend on me?"

Huntara whistled slowly, then took the clipboard away from Adora's hand. The blond smiled then and moved. One leg slid in between the man's. She jabbed his shoulder with her right palm, then hooked her leg back. Her other hand shot out and grabbed his shirt collar as he stumbled backwards and he found himself at a forty-five degree angle, being held, one armed, by the doorwoman.

Adora cocked her head, "Just for that, you and your friends are now barred. Rethink your choices." She let him go and he fell back into the arms of one of his compatriots. They sprawled onto the road. He tried to stand, snarling.

"I'm gonna fu-"

His sentence was halted as the groom chose that moment to follow through with his whimpers. The best man shrieked and the whole group hightailed it into the evening, cursing, the groom slumped over

someone's shoulders and the best man retching as he ran. Adora winced. Huntara guffawed.

"Aw man, that...that's poetic. And Dr , you missed your calling, *Superhero* ."

Adora shook her head and gave a wry smile, "Defeater of drunks and vanquisher of vomiters?"

"The hero we deserve," chuckled Huntara.

The crowd had pushed back against the wall but now ambled forward. Adora retrieved her clipboard and turned back to the group. Her eyes narrowed as she realised she recognised the faces. A tall woman with her red tail swishing nervously behind her. A lizard trying not to make eye contact. A dreadlocked girl. And a nervy guy trying to hide behind the lizard. Adora twitched.

"Lonnie?" The dreadlocked girl smiled, but it looked awkward, "Out on the town? And where's"…

A slight, athletic girl pushed her way past the group and stood in front of them, a hand on a cocked hip. Behind her, the whole line seemed to be complaining - she'd clearly just barged through everyone.. Her voice cut through the night air like a razor blade. It ragged over nerves Adora had pushed away. Her confidence, her focus. All wavered.

" *Hey* Adora."

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

> The past is a painful place, but it helps to think. But seeing it up close, watching it as it hooks its claws? Not so much fun.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The Fright Zone was a *dive*. A real grunge bar, frequented by leather jacketed bikers, goth kids and everything in between. The music was too loud and the alcohol choice was split between brown and strong or grey and stronger. They didn't *do* drink menus - you had a whisky, a vodka or, if you were pacing yourself, a rack of beer.

It was noise condensed into an *atmosphere*.

And it was one of the best bars in Thaymor. The former owner, Hordak, had known what the clientele wanted and he delivered. Hard drink, no nonsense. Straight to business. And *zero* tolerance for violence inside.

Not to say there wasn't violence. It just got *stopped*.

Adora had loved it. Loved. It. Which was why she'd been ecstatic that Catra had dragged her out to the interview. She'd been living with Catra for a few months, both of them settling into their courses at Mystacor College. Catra was doing an elective in Political Science with an art course on the side. And Adora was getting up to speed with her Physical therapy course, doing some side modules in science and a couple of anatomy modules to reinforce her baseline course.

Catra had been supporting herself by working the bar and had persuaded Adora to try it out. They'd been a few times to burn off

steam - it was just the right place to thrash to some heavy music, to drown away the stress.

Adora had been hired the same day, worked at the bar the day after that and just *clicked* .

She'd been there into her second year , Catra and her making a hell of a double act. Playing up the flirting, sliding drinks, bantering with the other members of staff. Scorpia and Octavia were on door duty, Rogelio ran the music, while Kyle and Lonnie were the usual evening staff during the week. They all just *worked* .

And then it had all gone *wrong* . Because, according to Catra, *Adora left them* .

As if that was enough to break a friendship. Or a working relationship. As if she'd had a choice. But it had been hard, she'd dropped off the grid and then..well.

Here they were.

Her old friends and coworkers stared past Catra, trying to avoid Adora's eyes. The blond sighed and massaged the bridge of her nose, "Catra. Not sticking to the Scorpion Hills part of town tonight?"

Catra's smile didn't quite reach her eyes, "What, we're not allowed to try new places?"

"You've *tried* Brightmoon three times."

"Yeah, well, you don't make it easy . Feel like we're being discriminated against. Maybe you don't think we're *good* enough"…

"If you hate me so much, why are you bothering?" Adora was tired of this. Over the past two months, Catra had come by, heckling at first, then trying to get in. All whilst wearing some ridiculous getup. Spandex onesie. Some crop-top and booty-short combo. And now… now she was in a red *suit* . To be fair, each of those combos had

clicked something in Adora's brain that made her go *bzz* and would necessitated several cold showers later at home. Which was another problem, related to the aforementioned *Adora left us* attitude. One that had never been broached.

Catra just grinned, "Well, it's a challenge. And you know me and challenges."

Adora gave the girl a glassy eyed look, "Do I?" Her voice was so monotone that Catra flinched faintly. Adora gave her the once over, "Good effort. No shoes though. Can't let you in. *Health and safety*."

Catra snorted, "Really? You know I don't wear…"

"No shoes. No service. Not my rules, club rules. I can't get fired because you decide your claws disagree with floor tiles and you fall on your ass. Break that tail of yours in a not-fun way,"

Kyle snickered but shushed when Catra spun to glare at him. Rogelio stepped forward slightly and Catra simmered down, then looked at Scorpia, "Hey, babe, got those spares? You know, for the water?"

Scorpia blushed and nodded, "Sure thing Wildcat, just in my clutch… uh…here we go." a pair of sandals was produced, "So, yeah, also got socks if you get cold and…"

"Shoes are fine, babe. You're the best Scorp," Catra blew the girl a kiss after taking the shoes. Adora twitched and felt something crackle in her. Not physical. But something throbbed. An old wound. She watched as Catra slipped on the sandals, those blue-gold eyes never leaving hers. The girl straightened and gave a one-shouldered shrug, "Satisfied?"

The blond breathed out and closed her eyes. She had to swallow and she felt Huntara move slightly closer. Her eyes flickered open and she caught Catra's faintly peeved look at the purple-skinned warrior. Adora's smile was thin, her faint voice managing a "Not enough."…

Catra's ears flicked and her expression became faintly confused, only for a moment. Adora stepped forward and unhooked the rope. Catra blinked, "Uh"…

"Welcome to Brightmoon, bar downstairs is doing two for one on select cocktails, dance floor is open. Please check your bags and coats inside. Have a fantastic evening, we aim to please," Adora's smile was a half smirk, but her eyes were cold. Catra was pushed inside as an enthusiastic Scorpia bundled her up, claws clacking with excitement. The blond didn't turn to watch them go inside, but froze as Lonnie stopped next to her. The girl searched Adora's expression.

"We, uh…We miss you Adora…just…this is so…fucked up."

Adora gave her a look and her smile became sad, "Yeah, maybe. But you guys…go along with it."

Lonnie grimaced, "We're just… trying to help her and…"…

Adora nodded quickly then reached out and tentatively patted Lonnie on the arm, "Hey, yeah I uh…I know. Shit timing, always the way. Hope you guys have a good night. Burn off some steam. Tell Bow you're um…tell him you're *friends* of mine. He'll shoot you a free round."

Lonnie smiled and suddenly lunged to give Adora a hug, "Don't… don't be a stranger. We don't all have Catra's zero-to-what-the-hey now attitude, k? Coffee. Shout me. Number's the same. I… uh unblocked you. Done with this BS."

Adora relaxed and nodded, "Sounds great. Text me a reminder, probably gonna just…become best friends with the floor later."

Lonnie laughed, nodded and went inside, following her crew. Huntara watched her go and frowned at Adora, "What was *that*?

Adora inhaled and shook her head, "Not a topic for conversation *right now*. Anyway… *NEXT!"*

She switched with Justina, one of Angela's other security team members, at 1 AM. The main bar was quiet, but most had shifted downstairs for the dance floor and cocktails. Adora headed through to the back rooms and went to her locker. The employee "lounge" was actually quite spacious and had a full couch and leather armchair setup, as well as a row of lockers that looked more like wood-frame wardrobes than something out of a gym. She had planned to wait for Bow to get off so they could head back together but suddenly she felt so *tired* .

She decided she was going to head back. She'd need to let Bow know, of course. She shifted out of her red jacket and blouse, then pulled on her white t-shirt She wore a sports bra pretty much constantly - security work meant you needed to be "tied down" a bit and not have to worry about things digging in.

She had her purple waistcoat with a popped collar, which she pulled on instead. It was her "relaxed wear" even if Bow said it made her look far more formal. Once she was happy her locker had all her work-gear and spare clothes stashed, she locked up and headed for the utility stairs to the basement. She passed the stores and nodded at a few of the late night staff who were setting up to clear the decks when the place locked up at 3 am. She pushed her way out through the door behind the bar and saw Bow with his ever-present audience of men and women, staring as he rattled through a series of complex concoctions. Behind him, on the bar rear-counter, a machine buzzed as it went through some motions of its own. Bow threw the mixer in the air, spun and flicked a switch on the machine, then caught the descending cocktail jar and shook it again once more. He unclipped the lid and, quick as a flash, poured out three glasses of green ice. A flash and each had a straw expertly placed into them.

Then he spun again and scooped a glass off a shelf, threaded it under the machine which suddenly *dinged* . A caramel concoction emerged into a spiral and he placed it next to the three green drinks, "Three Whispering W oods and one Apple Brandy Caramel."

Adora smirked and shook her head. She was about to make her way towards Bow when she caught sight of the Fright Zone crew . Rogelio was prodding Kyle, who seemed to be passed out on the table. Lonnie was dancing solo and Scorpia was...With Catra. Who seemed a bit bored by her half hearted moves. Adora shook her head and moved towards Bow, "Hey , uh, gonna go early. Got a submission tomorrow and said I'd call in with my tutors. Think Ineed to crash."

Bow glanced over his shoulder, face concerned, "Y ou ok Adora?"

"Just...had some near stuf f upstairs. Nasty guy with attitude and some...old stuf f. No biggie, just gonna, yknow , head on out, cowboy!"

He blinked, "Y eah, uh, that's not a phrase *anyone* uses Adora. Is this to do with your...friends?"

He gestured none-too-subtly past his still-adoring-audience to the Fright Zoners. Adora looked over on reflex and saw Catra had noticed her.

And suddenly things *shifted* . Catra's dancing became a lot more invested. She backed up against Scorpia and reached up to cup the woman's face. She brought the surprised woman's head down and *licked* the side of her face. Scorpia blushed as Catra whispered to her.

Adora froze. Bow glanced between the display and his friend and nodded slowly, "Y eah. Think you need to head out. This...this looks like it could get not fun."

She refocused onto Bow and her smile was brittle, "Bow , nothing to worry about. Catra is a grown woman, we used to live together, nothing major and now...now she hates me."

"So why'd you let her *in* ?"

"Because company policy doesn't say I can't."

"I *does* say you can use your discretion"…

Adora heaved a shuddering sigh, and moved so she was leaning with her back to the dance floor, "Y eah but that's only for drunks and troublemakers"…

"And someone who clearly is not exactly...being subtle?" Bow made an expression that would have *sounded* like "eeeeeeeeh" if he'd spoken. Adora scoffed.

"She' s *allowed* to have...Girlfriends. I'm not judging and...well, water under the bridge. We were roomates, not... that. I'm bigger than that. Anyway...um, yeah...so gonna just...go."

There was the slap of a palm on the bar and Adora glanced back. She jumped away from the bar at Catra' s sudden presence. The girl didn't look drunk, but she ran a tongue over her fangs as she glared at Adora. Scorpia hovered behind her, looking flushed. She waved a claw at Adora, "Uh, hey Adora...sorry...didn't get a chance to, uh… say hi"…

She forced a smile onto her face and nodded at the girl, "Hey Scorpia...no worries, glad you guys are...enjoying. Getting what you need and all that. Can't hang, really sorry , gotta run," She gave a short nod and patted Bow on the shoulder, then leaned in, "Be nice...They're just venting."

"Y eah, we need to talk about that. Cos you *never* really talked"…

"Gotta run,"

Catra's drawled words made Adora pause, "What? Running away *again* Princess? I need to get me some sort of pool goin'."

Adora clenched her fists. She wanted to turn. To spit fire at the *insufferable* girl. The *selfish* way she was acting. Tears came unbidden but she drew a breath and turned slowly. She kept her gaze on Scorpia who looked suddenly troubled, "I do hope you guys enjoy. It does good to get a change, I know. We get all sorts, pretty good screening at the door. But... just... don't go home with someone who hasn't earned it, y'know?"

She gave a brittle smile and fled with as much dignity she could muster at a fast walk.

The trudge back to her shared apartment was a blur. Cars hurtled by, casting the late evening in amber relief. The park was dark and foreboding to her right, the faint light of the finance district visible beyond. The apartment was in the Erebon borough of Thaymor. Not bad, low crime rate and a decent rent rate. Much better than when she lived with Catra, down in the Hive Kingdom district. They'd gone from student digs to a shared apartment but rent had been astronomical. Another chalk on the *why I left* column.

It didn't hurt that Angela owned the building too. So, she got a subsidised rate. Which she desperately needed.

Adora paused under a street-light and gathered her thoughts. Catra had stirred up *feelings*. And Adora didn't do well with anything deeper than immediate amusement or irritation. The past two years had been hard. First things had gone wrong with University - her grades had slipped as her bar work took over her life. Partying, drinking, just losing herself to it. Then she'd had the news that her

Foster mother, Mara, had started displaying symptoms again. That had torn her up. She'd gone to visit and ended up staying in Plumeria for a few months. Her tutors had given her a brief pass, but then started demanding returns or they'd fail her modules.

She'd gone back to University as it seemed the disease had been stabilised. But then she'd had the issue of rent. So she'd done more shifts at the bar to cover it. And when she tried to work, Catra had bombarded her with annoyed messages about being a *killjoy* . Then Catra had had some sort of issue with her own mom. Well, step-mom, who was an unpleasant piece of work;Adora had met her twice and she'd been disarmingly sweet, even of fering to help Adora with her studies, as she worked at the University. She'd pretty much belittled Catra in front of Adora and gotten *weirdly* invested in Adora's progress. Adora had been aware, but so engrossed in work and panicking about money and courses she hadn't quite parsed it.

So, that happened, then there was the *issue* with the bar. Namely, after her return to work, she'd found out Hordak had been skimming from the register. She'd only noticed as she helped with the books at times, part of her learning experience to help her setup after Uni. She'd told Catra who'd just *shrugged* . It'd worried Adora - Hordak was a fairly quiet guy , ran a tight ship in the bar. But he was prone to outbursts if the customers got too rowdy. Never with staff. But it had worried her enough to not raise anything.

Adora hadn't felt confident in it but her decision was made for her when her foster mother had had a sudden resurgence and died.

She'd dropped everything. Just broke and ran. There were funeral arrangements, plans, settling of assets. And then she'd found out her foster mother had *debts* . Unpaid bank loans, mortgage in arrears. She'd been funnelling her cash to keep Adora in university . To keep her secure. Except it'd backfired as suddenly Adora was now liable. So, she'd cancelled her University course, had to end her rent agreement and tried to salvage what she could in the middle of rural Etheria. And to cap it all, her phone had then been cut off.

She'd basically gone off grid for 4 months. Right at the end of the academic year. Right during exams. During which time Catra had to deal with her apartment complex kicking her out, her step mom verbally assaulting her in the street and Hordak being indicted for fraud.

Long and the short of it - Adora had, from everyone else's perspective, vanished, had to use all her assets to cover debts she didn't know were out there and all she had to show for it was a crummy t-shirt.

She sighed and leaned against the street light and ran a hand over her face. Why was she zeroing in on these memories? Triggered somehow? Just five minutes in the company of her best friend... her former best friend just had her reeling.

She remembered. Her return to Thaymor had allowed her to do a refresher course at the University and they'd let her sit her exams due to *exceptional circumstances*. And, apparently, a good word from *Catra's step mom.* She'd gotten back on track. She'd done night classes, volunteered for extra credit, helped out all over town. Everything. When she found time, she'd tried to reconnect with Catra, but got a single text saying *You left*. And then she realised Catra had blocked her number. She'd gone to the Fright Zone only to find it boarded up with a CLOSED sign on it. Admittedly, that had been close to two thirds during the last academic year. And she had no idea where Catra lived. The step-mom was not helpful, actively discouraging any form of contact *for Adora's sake. And for Catra, who didn't want to see her*.

Of course, there'd been new classes and she'd met Bow and Glimmer after landing a job at Brightmoon. But still, she'd not been able to reconnect with any of her former friends. They'd just cut her out. It was weird, just *all* of them.

And then, after graduation, with her basically being full time at Brightmoon, Catra had waltzed back into her life. Cat-calling

(literally), mocking, sneering. Flirting. She wasn't sure. And the Fright Zone had re-opened. Under New Management, apparently.

It had been a rollercoaster of two years. Death, debt, disillusionment. She'd prioritised her academic studies and just... forgotten. All she knew was that she was *exhausted*. She shook her head, banishing the memories for the time being. Plenty to dwell on in the present rather than dredging up *pain*. She walked past the park, down the emptying roads to the complex that housed their snug apartment. She didn't take the lift, instead going for a jog up the stairs to maintain her cardio.

Adora rattled her keys in the lock and stumbled into the apartment. Her mind wasn't letting her really settle - right now she was wondering *why*. Not any specific why, just the why of the *whole situation*. Catra *hated* her. It was in her body language, her words. It was *deep*. And she didn't really know why. Anger she could understand. Disappointment. But it'd been over a year since she'd been off grid. Even with all the drama, with all the knocks, she couldn't get *why*.

If she'd had a chance to talk to Catra, maybe they could have cleared the air. But it never seemed the right time. Or the right place. The girl seemed to just want to be angry at her. And maybe Adora deserved some of that - she'd gone and not exactly rushed back after it'd been "sorted". She'd thrown herself into rebuilding... what? Not her friendships, her old ones at last. Part of her had felt embarrassed and she'd just *left* it. She'd never been good at relying on people. Fun, yes, opening up? Not so much. And then they'd all had her blocked and... well. She'd had to knuckle down to make up for lost time. It became secondary.

The door clicked shut behind her and she looked around the snug space. It was done up in pastels. To be honest it felt like walking into Brightmoon all over again. The living room was mostly plush bean-bags set around a large TV. There was an upper mezzanine with a reading nook. The kitchen was small and functional, with a bathroom off to one side and their bedrooms down a side corridor.

She noticed that Glimmer was home - the haphazard stacks of paperwork on the dining table were one clue. The snoring girl on one of the beanbags was another. Adora huffed, walked over and hauled the beanbag out from under the purple-haired girl. She smirked at the bleary " *whaaaa?* " whine from the floor.

"Glim, bed. Now . Bow will get a popped vein if he finds you sleeping here."

Glimmer glared up at her then blinked, "He' s..uh he' s not home? What time is it?"

"1:45. Ileft early ."

Glimmer sat up immediately, concern written across her face, "Everything ok?"

"Y eah, of course!T ired, real tired. Couple of idiots on shift"…

"Dnt believe you. diots usually make you happy . Gives you excuse to vent. We know how you like punching out your problems. Dnt deny it."

Adora gave a tight lipped smile and ran a hand through her poof at the front of her hair piece, "Nothing major , just.dealing with some history today. ll pass. People change and just made me.sad."

"W ell that's not cryptic and of course will in no way result in Bow and lasking for *deets* at a later date."

"Y ou and Bow, later date?Hmmmmm.."Adora arched an eyebrow . Her attempt at subtly went over Glimmer's tired head.

"Y eah, no stone unturned!s it Plumeria stuf f?"

"Uh.um.no, Fright Zone."..

"Oh that' s cool!Mom has me doing a competitor study , right here!" Adora watched as a suddenly animated Glimmer bustled over to the

table and fished a piece of paper from the pile. She waved it at Adora, who just blinked and tried to lean away.

"OOOooo...And so? What?"

"You know, closed down, Hordak got prosecuted, it all got thrown out. Anyway, they're back and doing *amazingly*. Real rebound. All the review sites are lit UP! So, mom wants to know what their crazy secret is. We're doing ok, we've got our own offering."

Adora took the paper. It was a brief analysis on market trends, purchasing agreements and...Wait *what*?

She looked at Glimmer, who was gesticulating excitedly as she listed potential options for Brightmoon to *stay relevant* and *appeal to wider cultural niches*. Adora reached over and tugged the girl's ear.

"Owowowow *WHAT?*"

Adora jabbed the paper, "Is this *right*?"

Glimmer looked at the paper, then back at Adora, "Uh. I think so. Yeah, New owner, purchased the rights and licenses through some fund companies but, yeah. Catra A. M. Weaver. New owner. Or co-owner with an unnamed party. Exciting huh?"

Adora blinked, then fell back onto one of the beanbags with an exaggerated groan. Wasn't today just *peachy.*

Chapter End Notes

> This one I'm not 100% happy with. Bit of exposition, a bit of introspective history. I'm working towards something! gotta get the tasty angst in first, before the reveal.
>
> Let me know if you think the structure isn't quite there or if it doesn't flow. I want to avoid too many "infodumps" but this seemed to work in my head at least!

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

No rest for the wicked. Or the driven. Or the mad.

Sometimes revisiting old memories just brings up old wounds. But it can be worth it to find out the truth of things

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The alarm went off at 7. What would have been about two or three hours sleep had actually been around five and her body was confused by all that *rest* . Her last doctors appointment had been the medical professional nearly shouting at her that she needed more rest, regularly, not flat out exhaustion on weekends to make up a deficit. She usually managed three to four during weekdays and then a solid eighteen over weekends. The odd day during the week she might even stretch to five hours. And she did make up for it with regular power naps in breaks between study, gym and work.

But now she felt like warmed up oatmeal: sludgy, not particularly colourful and likely to leave you wanting a decent coffee.

Adora tried to push off her mattress but instead overbalanced and thudded onto the wood floor. There was a pause then the door to her room rattled and Bow poked his head around the frame.

"Hey , Adora, what was that OH MYG- Are you ok? Have you broken anything are"…

Adora held up her right forearm and waved from her face planted position, one leg still tangled in her sheet, "My body has… *betrayed meeeeee.* "

"Adora…we've spoken about this. You need a *break*."

"Now you are betraying meeeee."

Bow *tsked* and moved into the room. He helped Adora off the floor and sat on the bed next to her, "This isn't normal Adora. The doctors told you, you can only handle your stress if you're resting. We can do without you being the gatekeeper for a couple of days. And you *need* to re-arrange your diary."

Glimmer's face poked around the door frame and she snorted, "Yeah, she won't listen."

Adora shook her head groggily, "Bots, still got payments. Can't *don't*. I mean, look at Catra…barely outta college and has a *bar*. Me? I got… *liabilities*. Nowhere near getting setup. Gotta show *I can do this*."

Her roommate frowned at her, then at Bow, then stepped into the room and crouched in front of Adora. She took her friend's hands and cocked her head, "Show who?"

The blond took a shuddering breath and shook her head. She could feel her throat constrict and blinked her eyes to stop the tears. She forced her breathing to regulate. *Don't cry. Don't be weak. Don't be a burden. Gotta do this.* "Everyone."

Glimmer's lip trembled, "Adora, you don't need to prove *anything* to us. To me, Bow, to my mom. And if you *insist*, then you definitely won't prove anything if you end up with carpet burns or floor polish all over your face."

Adora blinked and chuckled, which turned into a hiccoughing sob. She nodded, "Yeah. I guess. Alright can…can you guys"…

She felt Bow squeeze her arm, "Yeah. Let's get that planner, let's sort out your *life*."

He got up and dashed from the room, vibrating with excitement. Adora, meanwhile turned her faintly woozy gaze to Glimmer and frowned, "Why you up? Both of you? Shouldn't you still be, y'know asleep?"

Glimmer met her gaze then blushed, "W e uh.. we stayed up to, uh, talk. Um, Bow got in at, like four thirty and, well no point going to sleep and"…

Adora nodded as she blinked her eyes. She rolled her head around and felt the stiffness in her neck, "Cool, so, fuckin' yeah"?

"Adora!"

"What, like, I am an adult. I know that these things happen. And I know you, ugh, wait til I'm not around… S'cool. But you both look… dressed."

Her roommate gave a half shrug, "No point going back to sleep"…

Adora arched an eyebrow, "And you tell me about taking it easy"…

"W ell, we will be sleeping later.

"UH HUH."

"Shut uuuup Adora!" Glimmer smiled, "Though if we're being frank, I really *really* want to just fall over cos that man he"…

Adora released Glimmer's hands and clamped them over her ears, "NNNNope! Nopenopenopenope," Glimmer grinned at her then began mouthing words really obviously, then mimed a finger going through and O. And then stood and began gyrating, whilst grinning. Bow re-entered looked between the two of them and huffed.

"Glim, could you please not talk about the.. activity we were… ahem"…

His girlfriend looked at him and smirked, "Activity? What, do we get wristbands? Oooo. I like the idea of… *wrist.bands…* "

Bow blinked and his skin flushed. He clutched the binder to his chest, then fixed on Adora, "So, hey , goodtimetogooveryourschedule?"

Adora nodded vigorously and Glimmer cackled, then turned to the door, "I'll go make cof fee. Back in a bit."

Bow slumped back onto the bed and grinned as he watched his girlfriend leave. It was a smile that made Adora ache in a place she thought was dead in her chest. For some reason, Catra dancing with Scorpia flickered into her mind and she winced. Bow looked at her, "Did you have anything to drink?"

"I'm hydrated, Bow. Just tired. And not hungover . So, let's. let' s see if we can work magic. But I cant promise I'll. be able to regulate everything straight out the gate."

Bow patted her shoulder, then opened up the binder. It was their apartment's calendar, one she'd been "forced" into partaking in - it listed where they were, which shifts they had, any additional courses, meetings etc. Bow maintained it, Glimmer begrudgingly took part and Adora had just gotten on with it.

Glimmer returned and, between the three of them, they made a valiant effort at rejigging some shifts and rearranged some study time that Adora had put in. They also insisted she cut down on *some* of her gym time. Some of the routine was inflexible - online or face-to-face courses at the local community college for her further learning; the actual nights she had to put in at the bar; the mandatory gym sessions as part of her work experience modules and maintenance of her therapy qualification. Mostly , they forced in actual blocks of study time, rather than the haphazard, unfocused and overzealous approach she had. Overall, it did look like she'd get a few more hours in. And somehow, that felt *wrong* to Adora.

That if she wasn't at breaking point, wasn't pushing herself, that she wasn't doing it *right.*

They ate breakfast and then the day *began* . As it was a Saturday that meant *gym* for Adora. Then a chance to catch up on that sweet sweet sleep. Back in her room. she yanked on a set of tight white joggers, a sports bra and her sleeveless white hoodie, then set out.

She started off with a run and aimed for the local park. The morning was cool and crisp and managed to clear some of her lingering internal voices. On a grass verge under one of the pine trees that dotted the picturesque, manicured space, she stretched out her limbs and flexed her joints. Then she plugged her ear pods in and set off. Adora pushed herself, ramping up her speed after her first lap. On her fourth she felt her leg muscles begin to scream. So she upped her pace again.

On her fifth lap she realised she was being an idiot and slowed then limped across the grassy expanse at the centre of the park. Nearby , families were out for early morning walks with strollers;cyclists pottered along the wide paths. Adora bent and leaned against her thighs, heaving breaths. She shook her head and realised the voices hadn't gone. They'd just been *quieter.* And she'd just run to blot them.

But one thing just sat in her head. That look Catra had given her . A look filled with such *hate* . It chilled her , made her ache. Because she didn't know *why* . Why had leaving hurt Catra *that* much? She hadn't explained, hadn't had a chance. But then again Catra, whilst fun, didn't often notice stuff that wasn't about *her* .

Adora sighed and yanked her damp hair out of her face. With a sigh, she set off for the gym, to punish herself a *little* more.

Two hours later, after a circuit set that had men larger than her whimpering and several of the others dazed, she was walking slowly back to the apartment. She'd indulged in a *long* shower. The heat had helped temper the ache in her muscles. The exertion had

helped, the music and the drone of the instructor keeping the voices, those doubts in her head at bay.

As she walked, her thoughts drifted again. The money she still owed; the repayment plans she'd managed to put in place;the savings she still was trying to squirrel away . She thought of Glimmer, already being lined up to take the Throne, as it were. About Bow who was still conflicted on whether he wanted to become a full time engineer or just sling shots for now . Everyone she knew had *goal* . An aim. And objective. It gave them purpose. Glimmer complained about hers, but when Adora had said she could just do her own thing, the girl had panicked. And Adora had realised she wanted, *really* wanted, to run the bar. But to do so on her *own* terms. Not have it just given to her . And Angela supported that.

What would you want me to do Mara? You wanted me to pursue my dream, but what is that even? What do I want, really?

That was the crux of it. She went through life, did good work, did her job *well* . But she felt hollow. The last time she hadn't had been when she was…

Her feet stopped and she looked around. Her distracted wandering had taken her off course. Normally her auto-pilot just drifted her back to *Brightmoon* or the apartment. It was pretty reliable. Except now she was stood outside of *The Fright Zone* . She stared at the old-style tavern sign which stuck out from the side of the building. It showed a red-eyed skull with a red, wing like pattern behind it. This jarred with the purple neon sign across the front of the bar itself, naming the place. The windows along the front of the bar were blacked out, with the whole frontage looking like a strange amalgam of traditional vintage bar smashed together with neo-industrial fittings. Wood framed windows meshed with piping that jutted out and ran along the overhanging lintel. Glass that looked bubbled and blow, interlaced with steel mesh. And a set of dark oak double doors with steel pull handles. Some of the benches outside were occupied and Adora noticed that the place was open for the late morning drinkers in expectation of post-lunch drinks.

Part of her wanted to walk away, to just go home and crash. Her brain was running on post-exercise adrenaline and sleep deprivation from a long, stressful week and an unpleasantly emotional evening.

But she hadn't been inside the bar in almost two years.

She set her jaw, pivoted on her heel and pushed the heavy black door open. At this time of day there was no real need for a security doorman. That was for the rush hour.

Inside she felt her breath hitch. It hadn't changed *at all*. Some of the stools were new, but the table layouts were pretty similar. Some raised tables, with the poles for *fully clothed dancers* were still in place. The lighting was low and a few fans spun lazily overhead. She could see the door that led to another bar-room, the one with pool tables and other distractions. There was the stairwell that led up to another bar and the ones down that went to the VIP rooms for *private parties*.

Indoors there were only a few drinkers - a large lion-man in a leather jacket nursed a pint in a corner, whilst a pair of goat-men talked quietly at one of the raised tables. The benches along the walls, with the little drink tables set along them, were empty. Clearly Saturday wasn't *that* rushed.

Adora went to the bar and swung onto a stool, the movement practiced and achingly familiar. She smirked as she recognised Jake behind the bar, back to her. He turned then goggled at her, "Uh… ummm."

She waved at him and grinned. It was mean, but it was nice to spook someone else for a change, "Hey Jake. You guys still do... ah yeah, the *brown sauce*. Half please, plus some water. Still parched."

He stared at her then nodded suddenly and jerked to get her drinks, "That's...uh...that's 3 chits"…

She nodded and slid a card across the bar, "Setup a tab. Fancy just drinking this back in, yknow . *Old times sake.* "

Her heart was thumping. Catra could turn up any moment. Unlikely, the girl slept *late* after nights out. *Scorpia maybe* ? What would she say to Scorpia? Would she ask her anything? But she squashed those lines of thought. She watched Kyle as he watched her . He seemed rooted to the spot, frozen with her card in his hand, eyes flicking between her and the register. She maintained eye contact and lifted her beer, then tilted her head back along with the glass.

It was bitter , like any decent ale. But it had that faint grease flavour all the drinks in here managed to accumulate. It wasn't *nice* . But it wasn't *bad* . And it had *memory* . The drink slid down easily as she worked her throat. A bit out practice - she didn't drink often, but old habits died hard. Hell, she'd had to take on the odd challenge in here, punters trying to get freebies, or just mocking the girls. And she'd held her own. Except against Rogelio. *No one* dared a drinking game with Rogelio.

She necked the water and nodded at Kyle, "You just gonna stare at it, or can I get that back?"

He blinked again then ran the order through the register and handed the card back with a nod, "Just tell me when, uh.. When you want to close the tab..and if you, uh"…

"Yeah, I'll have a *pint* now. And another water."

He nodded, served her, then tried to busy himself behind the bar, avoiding her eyes. She swivelled on the stool and looked around. It was still pretty empty, the goat-men now having an impromptu makeout session. That was cute. The lion man was now slumped on his table, snoring faintly. She turned back to Kyle who flicked his gaze away . He'd clearly been staring. She frowned.

"So, why'd you block me, Kyle?"

He froze from checking the fridge behind the bar and slowly looked up. He flinched under her impassive stare. She took another sip of the beer and winced. Probably *not* a great idea drinking whilst exhausted and having not eaten anything post exercise. But she'd power through. She always did.

"Uh..well, I was..I was angry you aba...aba...you left us."

Her smile twitched, "I abandoned you did I? I left a fucking job, Kyle. Because my mom died."

He froze and stared at her, "W ...what?"

"Oh, did she not say that? Eh, I didn't tell her much so maybe she didn't know. Her mom..sorry, *step mom*.. She knew. University board and everything."

Kyle looked green, "Oh gosh, oh..I..I'm sorry Adora, I didn't, we didn't.."..

Adora just shrugged. But inside she was *roiling*. Catra knew, she knew Mara'd been on her last legs, after the whole relapse and her first absence. She'd know that Adora had to go in an emergency. And she hadn't *told* the guys? And she'd gotten them to *block* her? That was..fucked *up*.

She'd needed friends. Needed her *family*. And Catra had *taken* that? Kyle swallowed and she forced her smile back. And then she forced herself to unwrap her fingers from the pint glass so she could grip it without shattering it. In one motion she downed the drink. Her gaze met Kyle's again.

"Rack up another."

She sat there for an hour, making her way through at least two more pints and a row of shots. Her gaze was trained on the mirror behind the bar, her eyes fixed on herself. The rage of a year bubbled like

poison in her chest. She faintly noticed a shape taking the stool next to her.

"So, pretty girl, drinking hard on the weekend. Means she needs a good time. Let me get the next round, ok?"

Her eyes slid right. He had taken refuge at the far end of the bar. She'd noticed him use the intercom briefly and possibly texted someone else. Poor guy looked *terrified*. And that was before the stranger had sat down next to her. She regarded the man. It was a man. She didn't notice details all that much. Brown hair, stocky. A grin that he probably thought was roguish, but bordered on skeezy, on a face that was slightly too chubby.

"Not today buddy. Take a raincheck on *never*." she slurred slightly and swayed a bit as she adjusted in her seat. The man just chuckled.

"Feisty. *Nice*. Think you've had enough. Maybe I get you one for the road and we can spend the afternoon discussing how I can improve my technique?"

She felt his hand on the small of her back. And that, that was a step too far. Too many people taking *liberties*. Rearranging her life. Lying about her. Stealing her time. Loading her with burdens she didn't ask for. *Expecting* things.

She swivelled in her chair and gripped his wrist, then twisted it. The man shuddered and went wide eyed as she locked her grip and forced him off balance. Then she pressed her fingers into his wrist and tilted it back further. He stumbled to one knee and Adora cocked her head at him, "I said, raincheck on *never*."

"The *fuck* is going on here?"

Adora glanced at the door. Her lip curled into a sneer as she saw Catra, flanked by Lonnie, in the door. Her old friend seemed to suddenly clock her and blinked. She seemed off balance. The girl

was carrying a coffee and was wearing a baggy tee shirt and ripped jeans. Clearly not expecting to be *working*. Summoned? Or doing the rounds? Didn't matter.

"Uh...hey...Adora."

"*Catraaaaa*. Nice place. Shame about the customers. Handsy," Adora pushed the man's wrist away. Her breathing was ragged and she fished for her card. She handed it to Kyle and looked at him, "Close the tab. I'm done. Nice to catch up"…

Kyle didn't meet her gaze but ran the card through the register. Adora stood and wobbled on her legs faintly. She grit her teeth - now was not the time to hurl or be *woozy*. Catra, meanwhile, seemed to have regained her *oomph* and began to stalk towards her, Lonnie following cautiously.

"What are you here for *Princess*?"

That *oomph* failed as Adora stopped, stock still and turned her blue grey eyes on Catra. Even Lonnie froze. Adora's whole body was trembling. And then Adora *smiled*. It was *not* a nice expression.

"Just checking out my old haunts. Free country, Catra. Thought it'd help. I'd be happier, yknow? Like I was then. Way back then. Way way back. Catch up. See what I missed...who I missed. I missed a *lot*. Yep.."

Catra rallied, "What, money doesn't buy happiness? Living it up not good enough, you come to slum it? See what actual *work* looks like?" but she sounded unsure, holding onto some semblance of stoked anger. *Bitter*. Catra took a step back as suddenly Adora was in her face. The blond was taller than Catra by only a few inches but she *loomed*. And her barriers were down. Which meant she was *steaming*.

"My mom *died*. Catra. Fucking *dead*. And you didn't *tell* these guys? Got them to *ghost* me? What, be...be...because. Because…

because I wasn't paying you attention? The *fuck*?

"Yeah, well we saw, you moved on quick. Back in town, swanky bar, saw you for what you are after hearing fucking *nothing, Princess*. Spoilt rich girl"…

Adora blinked. Then her smile twisted again. She laughed. It was a high pitched giggle. She brought a hand to her mouth as a sob came out alongside her laugh. Tears rolled out and she blinked. She doubled over, laughing, near hysterical, then heaved a few more breaths. Her vision swam and not just from the tears. A few more breaths and she shuddered upright. Catra flinched from her gaze. When she spoke she had to focus and enunciate every word. To force herself to speak without slurring or giggling in a really unpleasant way. She saw Catra one arm half raised as if to reach out. The other holding the coffee cup close, like a shield. Her eyes looked, perhaps for the first time, really unsure. Scared. *Well, not falling for that again.*

"Not worth it, Catra. You are not. Worth. It. Because you know *nothing* bout me. You know? And I don't think you ever did. Or ever wanted to. Or ever *will.* "Adora closed her eyes and tilted her head back to swallow. She licked her lips and took a final shuddered breath, "So, actually, thank you. Thassss closure I guess. Good luck with the bar."

She stepped around the girl and nodded at Lonnie, then pushed the bar doors open. She heard Catra say something but just flipped the bird over her shoulder.

She didn't remember getting back to the apartment, she just realised she was in her bedroom. A blur of concerned faces in the street as she jogged. With trembling fingers, she touched her face and realised her cheeks were wet, still. She felt lighter but also numb. Detached. Adora flinched as her phone buzzed. She glanced down - a text from Lonnie.

U ok?

She ignored it. Time to deal with that later. It buzzed again.

We didn't know. Thought you'd made it. Then cut us loose. Sry for… all of it. Wah. Can we still do coffee?

She sighed. Wasn't their fault. Knew whose fault it was. She flopped her hand to the phone, hooked it up and typed a response.

Yeah. Idc tho.

The response was near immediate.

S cool. Get it. If its ne consolation, u got Catra spitting.

Unfortunately, it wasn't. Adora curled up on her bed and thought about crying. But she didn't have anything else left. Instead, with a sniffle, her eyes closed and she passed out.

Chapter End Notes

- FYP . I have deployed the ANGST . Buckle up kids. Because all is not as it seems here.

Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

> Insights into shared living and the concern of friends. And a new confrontation leads to some unexpected realisations and pathways.

The next week was a bit of a blur. Starting with the Sunday From Hell. Or rather the *hangover* from hell. She'd woken up Saturday evening and *cratered* hard, managing to rustle up some toast and a coffee, along with a pint of water, before trudging back to bed past a very confused Bow and Glimmer (Who had *clearly* thought she was out). They'd been *very* surprised to see her as she interrupted their makeout session on the sofa with her grumbling and half muttered curses. And, after toast, coffee and water, she'd passed out again.

She'd not responded most of Sunday, deciding that wallowing was the better part of valour. The day was spent under covers. Bow had poked his head round the door, given an *awww she listened about the resting* sounding series of noises, then left her alone. Admittedly, it wasn't unusual for her to be utterly out of it on a Sunday anyway. But not at 3 in the afternoon.

As she lay there in her fugue state, her mind wandered. She now *knew* where Catra's animosity came from. And as with Catra, it was an assumption. And about her and her own vulnerabilities.

She'd seen those at University, when they'd shared a dorm room, then an apartment. Catra had always been loud, argumentative with others. She'd listened to Adora, teased her. Always had the *best* ideas for going out. She'd helped Adora get that job. Taught her about *being*, about having that confidence.

But it always came with that price of insecurity. If Adora hung with Lonnie too long, Catra got antsy. She masked it, but she had serious

possessiveness issues. She'd hissed at any guy who got near Adora in *that* way, at least in the early stages of them room sharing. And at the time, Adora had appreciated some of it - kept the handsy types away. She was always able to mollify Catra around their mutual friends as well. Plus it was like Catra realised that, well... guys weren't really on the menu as it were.

It didn't stop Catra doing her own thing, of course - hanging with other friends. And she never tried to *stop* Adora doing stuff. Never tried to control her, not too much, but there were the insecurities. It wasn't until Adora met Catra's step mom that she *really* understood. She wasn't sure if step-mom was the right title, no dad in the picture and all, but the way Catra became this quiet, pliant *thing* around Shadow Weaver went a long way to explaining things. The need for attention, the desperate fear of rejection. Adora had seen it, partly processed it. She was a fitness freak, yes, but she wasn't *unobservant*. She saw how much Catra wanted to make her parental figure proud. And so she adapted to help Catra. Not directly confronting the clearly imbalanced behaviour in Catra's family, but viewing her friend's behaviour through a different lens. Sometimes even called her out, although she *never* referenced Shadow Weaver. Just got a bit more confident at challenging her friend in a *constructive* way.

It was a strange reflection of Adora and Mara's relationship - her foster mom's pride, her quiet support. Shadow Weaver was very different. Intimidating. *Unpleasant* in a way that got under Adora's skin. She didn't seem to have a concept of personal space. Had a strange feeling of entitlement. It explained Catra's more extreme behaviours and impulsiveness. She'd broached that topic one evening after shutting the bar and had gotten a dismissive hand wave and a glare.

"Don't think you can psychoanalyse me, Adora. I'm the one doing politics. If I pull a muscle, then you can tell me how I feel."

Adora had felt a bit stung, but had shrugged and just filed it away.

But all this was clearly Catra's abandonment issues writ large. And, Adora quietly mused to herself, she was a convenient hate sink. Especially if you couldn't hate yourself.

Monday she'd done her studies, done more research into setting up her physiotherapy business, checked her accounts and gone to *Brightmoon* to do her shift.

Tuesday she'd done her studies, went to the gym, attended a seminar and gone to *Brightmoon* to do her shift.

Wednesday she'd done her studies, updated Angela on the Friday incident with the drunk bachelor party after she was called into work early, went to the gym and gone to *Brightmoon* to do her shift

Thursday she'd submitted a case study , attended another seminar, met with a financial adviser and gone to *Brightmoon* to do her shift. And nearly broke a guy's wrist at the door when she saw him grope a girl in line. Huntara had sent her indoors because her face had looked like she was going to do *much worse* beyond a cracked arm.

Each day, Bow and Glimmer had talked to her and she responded, smiled, nodded. But by Friday morning they hauled her out of bed and sat her down in the living room. She sat in her baggy Mystacor hoodie and sweatpants, regarding her friends. They sat on the sofa opposite her with slightly horrified expressions and had leaned back a bit. She tilted her head.

"What?"

"Yeah, you..You aren't OK Adora," murmured Glimmer . Adora blinked.

"I'm fiiiiine. Psht. Fine. never better ."

"Yeah, nope," said Bow . He rested his elbows on his knees. The pair of them were still in pyjamas, him in a crop top of all things. Adora idly wondered if he was wearing one of Glimmer's teddies for a

moment. But it wasn't *sparkly* enough. Her other friend was in a purple bathrobe and was squinting at her now.

"I'm *fine* guys. Just, y'know, gettin' m'self in geeeear, yeah?" she made a jolly motion with her arms, sort of punching the air and adopting a country accent. Bow arched an eyebrow and Glimmer shook her head slowly.

The girl leaned forwards and pulled her robe tighter around herself, "You have been *weird* all week Adora. And...well, you don't *look* good. Your eye is twitching and you just seem...manic. Huntara spoke to Bow last night and"…

"Oh. OH. OH! So she...did she now?" Adora stood up paced, pointed a finger, then bit her lip. She heaved a few breaths then sat down and crossed her arms, then looked away, pouting. Bow nodded slowly.

"Yeah, like we said. *HEEEEEIRD.*"

Glimmer shuffled forward and laid a hand on Adora's knee, "Babe, just...just tell us. Otherwise we're gonna have to do the... *ugh*... Best friend squad investigation interrogation *thing*."

Bow grinned and jiggled his knees, "Oh c'mon! It's FUN! Like Seahawk always says, *ADVENTURE!*"

"NO!" that was both Adora and Glimmer turning to glare at him. They looked back at each other and a faint ghost of a smile crossed Adora's face. Glimmer softened, "There's our girl...So, please Adora. We're worried. You're not...an angry person. If it's...too hard, fine, but let us know if we can help. Otherwise Bow will get *really* annoying."

Adora glanced between them and arched an eyebrow. She noticed Glimmer's fidgeting and Bow's slight twitchy movements, "Am I... interfering in your alone times?" she smirked. Glimmer rolled her

eyes and Bow blushed, "As in..you guys..arent..because you're too worried about...moi?"

Glimmer deadpanned and Bow rubbed the back of his neck, "I mean, it's, well"...his girlfriend glared at him, then back at Adora.

"Y eah, Im not getting any because he' s worried about *the apartment dynamic* . You are *blocking me* Adora. So, for the sake of my sex drive, *please* tell me what's wrong so he doesnt do the whole best friend repair thing. Because *I 'm dying here!"*

Adora blinked then grinned, then leaned back and laughed. Her laugh hiccoughed into a whimper and she shook her head, "S...sorry..sory it' s..Ihad a *shit* Saturday. And, Iguess..Ijust wanted to focus, get into something productive."

"Nearly breaking a guy' s arm is..productive?"murmured Bow . Adora shrugged.

"He tried to cop a feel from some girl in line. She was by herself."

Glimmer's eyes hardened, "Why did you stop at the wrist?"

"Huntara stopped me. Dont want me going overboard."

Bow nodded slowly, "V iolence isnt an answer..but in this case, Ill allow it...f..that' s ok..girls?"He shrunk back at their looks, "Y eah Im gonna shut up now ."

Adora shook her head, "Seriously guys, Im flattered. Y ou shouldnt put your..well, anything, on hold if Im in a mood."

"This wasnt a mood Adora, it' s a political situation. Cross border tension,"Glimmer shook her head, "I dont think Ive ever seen you that shut down. Like, you barely listened when we spoke, barely interacted at work. t was like..bodysnatcher Adora. So, what happened on Saturday?"

She debated lying. Covering it up. But cranky Glimmer wasn't fun. Cranky, horny, *frustrated* Glimmer was even less fun. And she felt guilty for that: that they were both so worried to the point she'd, inadvertently, basically pussy blocked. Because Bow worried so damn much. And that tended to then spread to Glimmer. Unless Bow was *decisive* about the worry, then the flat just got noisy as they *worked things out* .

Adora did *very long runs* on days like that.

She heaved a sigh, "went to the Fright Zone."

Glimmer frowned, "Why?"

"Used to work there...Remember?"

"Uh ok."..

"And, well...seeing the old crew , I kinda wanted to reconnect with my past a little, maybe see why the bridges all got burned. And to see what the place looks like now."

Bow nodded understandingly, "Kinda like when I reconnected with my Dads... ?"

Adora nodded quickly , "Yeah, sort of. You had worries about you life path and they reassured you. And, well...I haven't really spoken a lot about *that* part of my life, yknow ."

They lapsed into silence. The couple exchanged a look, then stood and joined Adora on the chair . It was a squeeze as they embraced her. Glimmer rested her head atop Adora's whilst she perched on one arm rest. Bow draped her arms around the pair of them. The purple haired girl sighed and nodded then spoke.

"Wanna talk?"

Adora felt her throat tighten and she nodded slowly. With faltering breaths, she explained a bit more of her history . They knew her mom

had died, known a bit about her debts. But not the extent. And not the fallout with her former life. Or even all that much about her early years at Mystacor. She never spoke about it, because it just *hurt* too much. She went over a bit about Catra, her relationship, or lack thereof anymore. And how they'd been thick as thieves, all the way through to their sudden showdown. Bow whistled low.

"And this is why we don't like unhappy drunk Adora. You are a *scary* girl."

Glimmer nodded, "But kinda hot too," she saw Bow's frown, "Whaaaat? Objectively true. Also, not gonna bang Adora."

Adora shuffled uncomfortably, "Ok, cool, now this officially *weird*."

Bow and Glimmer stood, giggling. Adora couldn't help but smile, even as she wiped the dried tears on her face. She watched the couple sit down on the sofa again. They looked sympathetic. Not the pity she'd half expected.

"Babe, sounds like a shit situation. And that Catra girl... Am I allowed to hit her? Cos I WANT to hit her. She sounds so...so...".

"Catra?"

Glimmer blinked as Adora shrugged at her own contribution. But then Glimmer nodded, "Yeah. I don't know why, but that does fit."

They lapsed into a comfortable silence, the tension having been suitably bled. Bow stretched and winced, then leaned back on the sofa. He eyed Adora thoughtfully, "Ok. Bad episode. Traumatic memories. Question is, Adora, what do you want? I mean, what do you wanna do? Sounds like you've cleared the air with some of them at least."

Adora tilted her head back and blew a strand of hair out of her face, "It's complicated. I don't know. Part of me just wants to forget

everything . Another wants to set Catra straight. But Idont see how either is doable. Especially as she, well.owns the bar ."

Glimmer frowned and nodded, "So.same Catra?"

Adora qirked an eyebrow , "Y ou know many Catra's?"

Her friend shrugged, "Y eah, means mom and Iwill see her at the licensee meetings. Or networking events."

"Bars have those?" Adora frowned. Glimmer snorted and nodded.

"Y eah. Supplier arrangements, brewery hosted events, wine evenings. All about getting good deals, maybe sharing promotional events together, talking about which customers are barred, which staff are blacklisted."

Adora frowned, "That seems.unfair ."

Glimmer shrugged, "Y ou give people a chance. But somebody skims from a register, you want to let others know. So that even if they hire them, they can keep an eye. t' s trust. Professional courtesy."

Adora sagged, "And she was at Brightmoon on Friday.wonder if she was just checking out the competition"…

Her friends shared a look and shrugged, but Bow spoke, "What' s she gonna do? Cant steal, cant exactly lift our ideas. t' s not a war, not industrial espionage. We sell drinks, Adora. The Fright Zone has a set *style* . At most we're competing for the club crowd after hours."

Glimmer nodded, "I think it' s.you. And Ihave a feeling she wont let this lie. Not if you've, yknow , gone and busted up her little perfect lie."

Adora frowned and shook her head. Catra would act out, get angry and jealous. She *knew* that. But something about the whole thing irked her. She could see why Catra was upset;she didnt think it was the *right* opinion. Didnt think it was a fair one, either . But she could

see why her old friend had been and could be angry. But that thing about her being *rich* ? That had been out of left field. t was also irrational - how many wealthy people worked as *bouncers* ?

Bow cocked his head, "Y ou dont think shell try something?"

Adora shrugged, "Not maj r? I mean i dont know . She was weird on Friday right? That wasnt. wasnt j ust me?" She watched Bow' s expression and he looked uncomfortable.

"Looking back on it. she was trying *waaaaaay* too hard. At the time, well, j ust thought it was being drunk. But as soon as you left she kinda went a bit q uiet. I mean, still laughing, loud.. Maybe a bit obnoi ous?"

"Ugh, Catra is the *worst* ," muttered Glimmer , "And Ihavent even *met* her properly yet."

Adora smiled faintly, "Q uiet?"

"Y eah like. she wasnt going overboard? That girl she was with looked a bit confused but they left not too long after you, maybe half an hour? She dragged all of them out of there."

He shrugged and Adora j ust nodded, then pulled her hands down her face, "Listen, thanks guys.. Y eah I got lost in that. But! Istuck to that new schedule. and, I promise, Il be fine. And Il talk to you if it gets too much. j ust. felt like it was *really* over. No closure and then the worst kind?"

Bow smiled and nodded, "Hey we get it. And yeah, maybe she needs it too. And maybe you guys can work it out at some point, once she stops being.".

"A raging hell beast?" supplied his girlfriend.

"Glimmer!" Adora looked af fronted then sighed, "She' s. not that bad. I. maybe there' s more to it"…

"Adora, she got your entire social group to *block you out* when you needed them. That is *not* a healthy person."

Glimmer fixed her with a penetrating stare and Adora held up her hands, "Fine, fine. I won't go back there. But I do need to get *some* more sleep before doing shift tonight."

"You, uh...sure that's wise? I mean mom won't mind you taking a personal day"...

"It's ok Glim. This has helped. A lot. And I do need the cash, remember."

Glimmer and Bow nodded. Adora glanced between then and narrowed her eyes, "Do you...do you need me to go? Cos of, yknow/"? The pair exchanged glances then looked at Adora, their postures rigid. The blond sighed and slumped her head back on the chair, "*Fiiiine*. Let me shower and I'll hit the gym. But let me get *out the door* ok"?

She tried to move fast. But she didn't manage to make it out of the front door before she heard the first squeal from her friend's bedroom…

She hit the gym *hard*. Not that she'd been slacking the previous few days, but those had been more going through the motions. Autopilot. Now, now that she was *awake*, properly; her minor misstep done.

As she kept telling herself.

The treadmills had barely challenged her. The ergo-machines had brought out a bit of a sweat. The weights had her growling but still the energy was there, unsated. So, she found herself in front of the

punching bag. She jabbed at it, rocking the heavy bag on its chain as she moved around it. She'd taken up boxing when she'd joined the *Fight Zone* . Never seriously, or competitively. But she'd learned how to throw a punch so she wouldn't crack her own knuckles. She'd dabbled in self defence - you needed to for the qualifications to even *be* a bouncer. She wasn't a belt, or had any formal "Grand Master" style titles. But she knew how to move, how to twist and take advantage of an opponent's weight, how to duck and weave.

Her fists slammed into the bag and it rocked back. Again. And again. And again. She realised, suddenly, that her grunts of exertion had turned into a cry of rage as her last punch sent the bag swinging wildly away. She caught it as it spun back to her and leaned forwards to rest her forehead against the cracked leather. She took another shuddered breath.

She hadn't told her friends *everything* about Catra. About how they used to be. Just that they were close. Great friends. Room mates. *Besties* .

But that didn't come close to the complex feelings that had been there. That she'd never broached with her friend, because Catra was always so… *alive* . Adora felt happy just being in her orbit and why ruin that? She'd seen Catra flirt and chat up all manner of people. But, strangely, the girl had never settled. Adora had assumed she'd done *things* with others. She vanished some evenings and Adora just pushed that little spark of hurt. It was fine for Catra to go off, but Adora got a full on pouty mess of a roommate if she chatted to anyone. She tried to *hide* it. But Adora noticed. Catra brushed it off, always, going for aloof. Adora just thought she had that worry of being left alone at parties or on nights out. She had the same fear, after all. Despite Catra's gung ho attitude to getting Adora *hooked up* with someone. It was so confusing, trying to keep up with the girl at times.

But at times Adora wondered, had lain awake in their dorm room, whether there was *something* .

Of course, any ideas of following up on that had vanished after Mara's passing. After so many months of being in each other's lives, in each other's pockets. Hiding out when the police came to break up a house party, hanging other new kids in the University grounds, just staying up *talking* when they weren't on shift at the bar. Their bond had formed fast and it had felt unshakeable. Catra had been so *keen* so eager to get *away* from Thaymor after University. *A chance at freedom,* she'd said, *no rules, Adora. No one holding us back.*

A beautiful wish.

But now she had her new dreams. A steady job. Day in, day out. Move onwards, clear the slate.

She felt the presence behind her and glance over then reared back slightly. She blinked as she looked up into Scorpia's face. The woman did *not* look happy.

"Uh...hey...Scorpia."

"Don't *hey Scorpia* me. Nothing...then we see you at Brightmoon and then...what did you say to her?"

Adora blinked. This wasn't bashful, awkward Scorpia from the club. This was the Scorpia she'd only seen when *shit got real*. Usually with aggressive punters at the *Fright Zone*. But whilst that attitude worked on drunk idiots with too much testosterone, it didn't work on *crabby* Adora. She turned from the bag and inhaled. The sour smell of sweat and recycled air filled her nostrils.

"What are you doing here, Scorpia? *You* following me?"

"What, no, I mean, I came to train and...well what are *you* doing here? Hmm?"

Adora eyed the big woman. She was more heavily built than Adora, well proportioned. But Adora noticed from the way the woman's tail was swaying that she was agitated. She bit back her normal retort

and rolled her neck, "T raining. And what did Isay..oh to Catra?" she shrugged, "ust..putting an end to things, Iguess."

She realised she sounded remorseful. But also a bit bitter. Scorpia leaned forward and prodded her with a claw. Adora stiffened and slapped it away, glaring as Scorpia put on a frown, "Y ou said *something* . She's been..of f. And it's not fair on her after..well, i wanted to give you the benefit of the doubt, and all that, it's why we went to the bar and then you didnt even *talk...* "

Adora twitched, "Y ou all… *all* of you..ut me out."

"Y ou left!"

Adora sqared up to her , "My mom *died* . Why do Ihave to keep *telling* people this?Like Ihave to justify that?Like Ihave to justify having to deal with the fact she was fine then she was *dead* . And then Iwas left with..with"…

"Y eah yeah all that money."Scorpia said it dismissively but something in her eyes, something in the way she said it sounded off, like she wasnt *quite* convinced. Adora spread her hands, and growled.

"What. Fucking. Money"?

Scorpia blinked and looked uncertain all of a sudden, "Um..well… Catra said"…

"d she? *Did she* ?W ell, d be really *fucking* interested in knowing about my surprise windfall, Scorpia. d have *helped* with the..Y ou know what, you havent *earned* the right to know. *None* of you did. *None* of you were there."

"Y ou..you didnt ask!"

Adora snarled, her temper flaring suddenly. The week of being wound *so tight* unravelled, "had no PHONE!Ihad no MONEY!"

What, Ishould have *hitch hiked* back from Plumeria? With bailif fs and debt collectors just tearing chunks? After Ihad to auction my *moms stuff* , her *house?* "Scorpia reeled backwards like she'd been punched. Her claws came up in front of her face. Adora advanced on her, "Y eah, Catra tried that line. The money one. So Itold her what Im gonna tell *you* . You know nothing. All this reaching out as if Im at fault? Go. Fuck. Y ourselves."

Her energy fizzled out and she slumped. She glanced up. Scorpia was half reaching out, half frozen. Adora looked at her and saw genuine confusion and guilt there. She shook her head, just *beaten* . She'd thought she was fine, but the knife was sunk *deep* clearly. She pushed past Scorpia who just stood there, rooted to the spot.

She didn't bother with the changing room, just collected her hoodie from the floor and yanked it over her crop top. Then she just headed home, wanting to be somewhere safe, somewhere secure. She didn't stop trembling until the apartment door clicked shut behind her . The place was quiet - Bow and Glimmer either having some sort of time out before round *whatever the hell they were up to* or they'd left for the afternoon.

Adora leaned against her knees and took a few faltering breaths. Oddly, she felt a bit *cleaner* now, more awake and less burdened. She'd actually expressed something, maybe sliced away another layer of the lies around her. And, weirdly, it felt ok. She didn't like hurting people, didn't like arguing. But something about Scorpia' s expression gave her bittersweet satisfaction.

It did leave the weird feeling of *why* Catra was spreading a rumour about her being rich. She'd thought that earlier . It was a good way to get the rift in between her old friends. But the way Catra had spat the words. Adora frowned.

She *believed* the words.

And you didn't believe your own lies, did you? *Don't think you can psychoanalyse me, Adora.* Catra's words came back to her. She

grimaced.

No, she wasn't trying to... much. But had Catra had such a breakdown, she'd made something up to justify it? No, Catra wasn't that mentally fragile. Angry, yes, moody, *hell yes* . But she was too cynical to lie to herself about that. Motivations, maybe. But something like that, well...she'd have to have really layered it on to convince herself.

But it didn't feel *right* .

She checked the time - one o'clock. She had a few hours before she had to be at the bar. She had a little more time to burn. And for some reason her tirade at Scorpia *hadn't* made her go into her shell, made her shut down. It had, actually , stirred something. Maybe it was the confusion on her former friend's face. Maybe it was the words, *Catra's been off* . Maybe it was a lot of things.

She wanted to *know* . To understand. She could ignore the past or… interrogate it.

Best friend squad investigation and interrogation time...without two thirds of it, of course. She didn't want to go overkill.

Adora rooted around in the pocket of her hoodie and fished out her phone. She opened her contacts and found who she was looking for.

Hey, feel like that coffee? Got time to burn. My treat. Want to clear the air. An hour? Just wanna check something.

She walked into her room, stripped off and headed for the shower. Before she got in, she checked her messages and grinned.

Lonnie:yeah, b gr8. Got a break to take. 2?

Adora nodded, then rattled off the address of a coffee shop. Smiling, she put the phone down and headed for the shower. It was nice to not be reacting for once.

And maybe, just maybe, she'd get some actual answers.

Chapter 5

Chapter Summary

> Some fences need mending. Some fences get talked about getting mended. A few little revelations. And some more confusion.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The coffee shop just off of the garden District was a quiet place. It was set back a little from the main street, alongside some antique shops and the sort of small boutique businesses that sold crystals, handmade clothes and very niche books. Adora loved it - it reminded her of growing up in Plumeria. Rustic, that was the word. The whole street was like a mini-village amidst the high rises of Thaymor.

It didn't hurt that the owner of the coffee shop, Perfuma, was from Plumeria as well, so knew how to get the ambience down *pat* .

Adora had picked it because she found the chain coffee places to be *too* busy. There was no chance to really sit, or to collect your thoughts. She came here to unwind, rare as that was. She hadn't been by for a while though, such was her spiral into her routine recently.

The first thing to hit her was the scent of vanilla as she pushed the door open. It washed over her , mixed with the faint hints of cinnamon and nutmeg, which meant that Perfuma was baking. Or rather, some of her staff were baking.

The second thing to hit her was Perfuma, who'd turned after placing a cup of coffee onto a small table next to one of the booths. As soon as she saw Adora she squealed and swept her up into a hug, "ADORA! Oh we've *missed* you here. How have you beeeeeen?"

Perfuma was wearing her usual long, floral dress and had her curly blond hair done up into braids. Large wooden bracelets jangled on her wrists as she grasped Adora's shoulders and held her at arms length, eyes peering at her carefully.

"Hey Perfuma. yeah busy . ust, yknow , meting a friend here."

"W ell, that's good! Happy to host, though your aura seems a bit dim today. I know. well, Glimmer said you'd had a tiring few weeks. Did you try those meditation techniqes we went through?"

Adora gave a crooked smile, "No, not yet. I will, I promise. ust… been a bit overwhelming and I usually just crash after work."

Perfuma frowned, but nodded, her face then breaking into another huge smile, "W ell ok then. Let me know if you want to talk, of course. t' s what I'm here for ."

"I thought you were here to sell cof fee."

"That' s a nice side effect. People talk more when they have something to occupy themselves. And what better thing than an energising kick of caffeine, or some herbal tea to take the edge off. Are you having your usual?"

"Uh, yeah. not sure what Lonni ell have"…

"W ell, I'll get yours and just let me know what she wants. Have a seat!"

Adora navigated her way to a pair of plush chairs and sank into one. The decor of the place was like a library, with mismatched bookshelves around the edges, interspersed with wooden benches and tables, along with mismatched chairs. There was a second floor to the shop, accessible via a carved wooden staircase. Upstairs was definitely a library, with the shelves jutting out like the stacks in the municipal museum. She leaned back in the chair and smiled as Perfuma carried over a latte for her. t had a decent dose of caramel

in it, to take the bitter edge off of all that milk. She had just taken a sip when the door jangled and a familiar face walked in. Adora waved from her seat and she watched as Lonnie nodded and headed over. The girl paused by the chair, as if suddenly nervous. Adora watched her for a moment, then smiled and stood. Lonnie blinked in surprise as Adora brought her in for a hug.

"Hey Lonnie. Good to see you. Thanks for coming, know it's a bit short notice."

Her old friend tensed up initially, but then relaxed and returned the hug. They stepped apart and Lonnie sagged into the chair opposite Adora. She gave a rueful grin, "Hey. missed you, girl."

The blond managed to suppress her initial, slightly bitter response - that wasn't going to help. And also, it wasn't really Lonnie's fault. Not as far as she knew. She just shrugged instead, "Yeah, weird times… just glad we can reconnect. Maybe just start rebuilding those bridges, yknow."

Perfuma wandered over and Adora made a brief introduction and Lonnie made her order. Adora watched Perfuma walk away and shook her head as she turned back to Lonnie, "You drink *jasmine tea* now?"

Lonnie shrugged and grinned, "What, it chills me, girl. And, uh. you hitting that?"

Adora nearly spat her coffee out as she lurched forward. She snickered and glanced at Lonnie, then wiped the foam off her chin, "What?"

"I mean, *damn* she's a bit skinny but, nice girl. Think she likes you too!"

Adora shook her head rapidly, "Oh no. nope. Perfuma's a friend. And she's like that with all the customers."

Lonnie arched an eyebrow, "Really? I didn't see no hand on *my* arm when she was asking how we doin'. That girl has got a *crush* . And you, you just got no idea."

Adora leaned her head back and grinned. It was like being back at the bar again, the banter just *came* back, "Look, just because you got hit on *all the time* doesn't mean all of us are lady attractors."

"Oh so you finally worked out which side of the fence to land on, that's good," Lonnie's arched eyebrow shifted to a genuine grin, "And it's *babe magnet* . Girl, you got guns a battleship'd kill for . How you ain't being *draped* I have no idea. So, no one in the picture, at all?"

Adora took another sip and shook her head, "No time. Too much going on."

Her old friend nodded slowly and smiled as Perfuma came back with the tea. The pair lapsed into silence for a moment and Lonnie folded her arms, momentarily uncomfortable, "I get the feeling this ain't just a quiet catchup?"

Adora looked into her coffee and sighed, "Honestly? I'm kinda enjoying it being just that. But I'd be lying if I said I didn't have questions. I *do* want to reconnect, though, Lonnie. I missed you guys. I *needed* you guys."

The girl couldn't quite meet her eyes and just managed a whispered "Yeah. I know ."

Adora could feel something angry in her chest. A sort of sense that she wanted to blurt out: *that's it? That's all you can say?* But she tamped it down and managed a shuddering sigh, "I just... I want to know why, Lonnie. I don't want to have an angry exchange with each of you. I screamed at Scorpia in the gym today ... "

Lonnie looked up, wide eyed, "What, what happened? To... you… did she?"

The blond shrugged, "Apparently co-incidence. But she tried to offload at me for upsetting Catra.... And said some stuff that makes no sense to me."

Lonnie nodded slowly, "Is it.. W as it about the money?"

Adora flung her hands up and flopped back into her chair, "Y eah! Can you explain it to me, so Ican, like, work out what i did to give that impression?"

Lonnie shifted uncomfortably then gave a tentative half smile, "Kinda wish we were still talking sex. Easier ."

"Y eah you aint booty-calling your way out of this catchup, missy!" Adora gave a genuine smile of her own, then sighed, "Look, Ijust want to know where that came from. And then to understand what the hell's happened - Catra *owns* the *Fright Zone* now? How'd that happen?"

Her friend didnt answer right away . She picked up her tea and drew in a deep breath, then sipped it. She put it back on the low table and leaned forwards, elbows on knees and frowned at Adora, "Guess you want to highlights version, right?"

Adora shrugged, "Clif f notes, yeah."

"So, let' s start with the whole...money thing. W e all knew something was up with you, but you tended to..be *you* . You just worked, partied and didnt talk, Adora. No, no, dont glare, lemme get through this, then you can shout, if you want to. Anyway, so we know you have *something* going on. You went and disappeared for that family emergency that time but came back. Didnt seem too wrecked, but hey, you hid shit well."

Adora grunted begrudgingly and looked away, then waved for Lonnie to continue, "Whatever ,"

"Pshaw , right. So, like, the second time you vanished, we didn't know *what* the fuck happened. I mean, Catra got, what, four texts, something about your mom, then…nothing. She tried calling, she tried contacting student services, all that. Man, Adora, she was tearing up the campus after a month. I get you were away but… *nothing* ."

Adora bit her lip and swallowed, thickly. In her mind's eye she could see Catra, panicking. But hey, she knew why, "Huh, guess she was upset she lost her *lapdog* "…

Lonnie reared back and glared at Adora, "Hey , that's *not* fair. She was worried sick. You *left* Adora…and yeah, now I know…I know . It was for a good reason. But, c'mon, you didn't even message?"

Adora turned her gaze back to Lonnie and tried to bite back her bitterness, "I lost…everything Lonnie. Not emotionally , just literally everything. My mom…well, no money . Just a bunch of outstanding bills. And all overdue. To the point the debtors would *not* tolerate delays. So, overnight…phone got cut of f, house got auctioned, all my stuff. Hell, had to cancel my *course* to have *something* to spend."

Lonnie stared at her, her forehead knotting into a consternated expression, "No way.."…

"Y eah, yes way. And I couldn't *leave* until it'd all been sorted. I got lumped with *everything* Lonnie. No way out. Took me two months to get back on my feet. Living in a hostel, scrimping from odd jobs. I had to *beg* to see out my course when I got back. Barely managed it. And now I'm still paying stuf f off, trying to keep my head above water."

She met Lonnie's eyes and the girl flinched slightly, "Damn, girl. I… mean…you should've r-"

"How , Lonnie?" Adora' s words were quiet, but her old friend winched as if she'd been slapped, "W rite a letter? I could've. But my mom had died, I had no set home. How d'you think you'd manage?" And then i

get back, Hordak's been hauled away, my only safe space, the *bar* is gone...and you guys didn't even give me the benefit of the doubt. In fact, seems you all thought I made it and *ran away*. Which doesn't exactly sit well with your view of me."

Lonnie nodded and averted her gaze, "Yeah...yeah that's...That's fair Adora. I'm sorry we...we didn't know. And Catra told us about the money."

"We've established that. Why?"

"Because she *believes* it."

"Yeah, I get that. Why? Unless she hates me so much she's gone delusional."

Lonnie gave her a pitying look, "Damn girl. She don't *hate* you. She just got broken *badly* when you went. We're all friends, but you two...man that was another level."

Adora shifted uncomfortably, "Whatever, why does she think..."

"Not sure...but I think it's her mom. A rumour of a rumour that her mom mentioned and Catra latched onto it. Since we hadn't heard, it just...made weird sense. We all argued about it, that you weren't like that. But you'd kept your distance, kept things just *inside*. Left enough for us to wonder, y'know?"

The blond sighed and took another sip of coffee, as much as for something to occupy her hands as anything. She put the mug down and massaged her temples, "Shadow Weaver...well that makes *no* sense. I spoke to Shadow Weaver, explained what was going on. She helped me with negotiating a deferred repayment plan..."

Lonnie shrugged, "That's all I know Adora. That's the only way catra has ever mentioned finding out. You should," and here she winced, "You *need* to talk to her. Properly."

Adora snorted, "Like that' s going to happen. She *does* hate me. Whatever.whatever it was before, that' s gone. And she hurt me. She made all of you ignore me," her tone went from cracked to gentle as she offered a chastising look at Lonnie.

"Ok, Iget Adora.we all fucked up," the girl ran a hand through her dreadlocks, "What do you want me to say?"

The blond shook her head and shrugged, "Honestly.nothing. I think part of me wants to haul you all over the coals but,... what's done is done. And Ijust want to move on. W ant to be.friends again. f we can be."

Lonnie studied her and nodded, "Y eah.Id like that."

"Good. So, round two of interrogation," her Adora gave a smirk and arched an eyebrow dramatically, "What' s the deal with the bar?"

"Ooh yeah, *that* . Well, uh, yknow Hordak got his hand slapped?"

"Y eah, suspended sentence or something?"

"W ell, he still lost the lease. And, well.Catra had always moaned that it was wrong the place went down. So.she bought it."

Adora shook her head, "She doesnt *have* that kind of money… ironic Iknow"…

"I know!But uh.well, it' s her mom. She *does* have money, apparently."

Adora blinked, "Why the hell would Shadow W eaver buy a bar with Catra?I mean.they barely tolerate each other ."

Lonnie shrugged, "Late bonding?"

"Have you *met* Shadow Weaver?"

The pair shared a shudder then chuckled, "It's fucked up...but, well, Catra doesn't talk all that much except to Scorpia."

Adora looked out the window suddenly and blinked. She traced a finger around the rim of her cup and tried to suppress a twitch, "So… so uh. Ahem. That's a thing now, is it?"

Lonnie took another sip of tea and watched the blond, "It's… something. Don't know *what* though. Nothing good though."

Adora's gaze flicked back, a frown on her face, "What do you mean?"

"It's...it's complicated? Rebound? I don't know. No idea if they're an item or Scorpia's been turned into Adora 2.0, know what I'm saying?"

"Not a clue."

Lonnie sighed and deadpanned, "Y'all are useless. Anyway, *Kyle* stepped up to Catra and told her to not do anything stupid a while back."

"Hey, hey it's fine. It is. Fiiiiiiine. Catra is a grown woman, we aren't friends anymore, who she chooses to spend time doing...doing *whatever* with is *fine*. None of mah business."

"Uh huh." Lonnie kept her expression neutral and sipped her tea,

"Don't *uh huh* me."

"Uh huh."

"Oh...fuck off," Adora quirked a grin and shook her head before planting it into her hands. She pulled her psalm across her face and sat up, "So, summary, my old friend got told, maybe, by some University professor, who is her step mom, that I got rich and ran. For whatever reason. And said professor has now decided co-owning a *bar* is a good idea?"

"Yep. Oh and as a result, your old friend has now got *complicated* feelings."

"Thanks for that Lonnie," Adora commented drily, "So helpful."

"Hey, you asked," Lonnie raised her mug in a toast and grinned. Adora rolled her eyes and made a defeated noise.

"Fine, fine, my own fault. Alright, sounds weird. And thank you, Lonnie. I know it's odd, but i appreciate it. I know it cant be easy meeting me, considering what you thought."

"Yeah, well. I hate holding grudges. It's so *tiring*. Thought i better hear you out, or at least move past it. 'Cos we miss you. We *all* do. *ALL* of us."

"Subtle, Lonnie. Subtle."

"Look, just saying... maybe give her a chance. I was wrong. She's definitely wrong. We didnt *know*. That's on us. But, like I said, she doesnt know it. But she cant build the bridge, 'cos she doesnt *know* it got burned down a different way."

Adora finished her coffee and stared down into the dregs, "Maybe… But what... what if the pain.. What if we cant go back... or..." her voice was quiet. Lonnie gave a sad smile and reached over the table to grip one of Adora's hands.

"So... do something? You leave it, then yeah... nothing'll change."

Adora raised tired eyes to Lonnie. She breathed in and closed her eyes for a moment. And when she opened them again she was a little bit more tense, "Well see. Nothing I can do now. Just have to handle it when I have time."

"You're doing the close down thing, Adora. Been a while, but I recognise that look."

"I *can't* do much. It's s... it's raw Lonnie. I shouted at her. I think even with the bridge burned it's also been *mulched*. To really mess up a metaphor."

"Dammit, why you people gotta make things so hard? Just *talk*."

"It's not that simple"…

"It really *really* is."

"Look, she's spent our last interactions not *listening* and just trying to start stuff." Lonnie heaved a sigh and Adora held up a hand, "I'm officially nixing Catra talk... not because I don't... I don't *miss* her. Cos I do. But going over it now won't help. Anyway, we've gotten all the interrogation stuff done. Now I can ask nice questions. Like *who are you seeing*. And *did Kyle and Rogelio sort out their thing*."

Lonnie snorted and grinned. At once, the tension ebbed away, and the pair settled into more neutral territory. An hour passed, along with another round of tea and coffee, conversation more on job topics and how Uni had panned out course wise. Towards the end Lonnie checked her watch and groaned, "I gotta bail Adora, sorry."

"Hey, s'ok, thought you were on break. Bit long for one."

"Nah, cashed in a day of f. Owed, like, twenty. And she-who-must-not-be-named is actually not bad as bosses go. Unless you put the beers in the wrong order."

"OOOO, she still that obsessive? Or controlling?"

"Thought we weren't talking about herrrrrr?" grinned Lonnie. Adora pouted and waved her away.

"Alright, you got me. It's it's complicated. Anyway, you gotta dash?"

"Yeah, non working day, but I promised Rogelio I'd help with some stuff at his place."

Adora quirked an eyebrow, "What, big strong Jake not helping his BFF move stuff?"

"Less BFF and now BF. Mine too."

Adora blinked. Then cocked her head. Then cocked it the other way. Then nodded slowly, pursing her lips. Lonnie seemed nervous but then smirked at Adora's clear brain-hiccup. The blond paused, frowned again and shrugged, "You be you. So…how does that… work? Are you a…what is it…a hinge? Is Rojelio a hinge? Is Jake a doorstop?"

"That is not how *any* of that works, Adora. And we…we just *work*. It's a triad. All equal. Takes a bit of…Conversation. You know, *good communication*…"

"Oh for the love of…I get it! And, yes, you have a sort of, not very well made, but clearly there *point*. I'll…think about it."

"Not my BF's though, right?"

"Ew, no."

"Don't *ew* them. They're mine," Lonnie looked smug and a little bit bashful at the same time. Adora grinned.

"And well done you. I bet your schedule is just *packed* all the time."

"Like you wouldn't *believe*," she made satisfied noise and Adora snorted then shooed her.

"Go on, go, before you start drooling," Lonnie nodded and stood. Adora grabbed her wrist suddenly and stood. She wrapped the girl in a hug and just held her, "Thanks, Lonnie. It was so good to catch up."

"Same, girl. Next time I'll bring the boys."

"What, I get to be the fourth wheel while you three do some weird three way flirting?"

"Eh, bring someone. I wonder who would be a good option..?"
Adora groaned and pushed back with a smirk. Lonnie gave her a wry look, "What, bring cof fee girl. Totally what I'm implying."

"Go, shoo."

"Good to see you Adora. Say , you working tonight?"

"Uh, weekday . And I need the money ," Adora frowned, "Why?"

Lonnie gave a half shrug, "Boys might wanna go out. Maybe we'll swing by Brightmoon, say hi?"

"I won't be very sociable but. Yeah that'd be cool. I *may* be able to hook you up with cocktails, which is what you were angling for, right?"

"Y ou know me so well. Anyway , catch ya later, Adora."

Adora watched her go, then sat back down. Her eyes glazed over as she pondered her predicament.

J ust talk to her.

Was it really as easy as that? On the surface, it all seemed pretty simple - miscommunication. Easy to resolve, right? All Catra had to do was apologise. And then it'd be all great again.

Right.

Perfuma headed back over and glanced between the coffee and tea mugs, "That seems to have helped. Y our aura is brighter! Maybe no meditation needed today? So.. new girlfriend?"

Adora tried to read the expression on perfuma's face, but gave up, "Nah old friend.. reconnected."

"Oh. Good. Say , Adora, you've been coming in here a while and I was wondering, seeing as we've gotten to know each other"…

The buzz of her phone distracted Adora, and she smiled apologetically. Part of her brain was also panicking, but she hadn't noticed that bit yet. Her phone showed a message from Huntara, asking her to get in a bit earlier. She sighed, "Sorry Perfuma, gotta run. Work."

"...oh..oh that' s ok. Just, did you have an opinion?"

"Hmm? Oh, right um..sorry?"

Perfuma smiled and tilted her head to one side, "Just...Oh don't worry. Um. Pop by again?"

Adora eyed her for a moment then smiled and nodded. She stood up and fished around in her jacket, then pulled out a crisp banknote which she handed to Perfuma, "Thank you, Perfuma. Needed this today...Keep the change."

She gave the coffee girl an awkward hug then headed out, leaving a flustered and slightly confused Perfuma behind her. It was only as she was halfway to *Brightmoon* that the last conversation clicked into place. Adora froze in the street and blinked. She chewed her lip and fished out her phone for a moment, then scrolled to Perfuma's contact details. She held her finger over the *call* button momentarily.

"*No*..she wasn't..was she? *Was* she? Maybe? Naaah. Psssh."

She pocketed her phone and continued on. Only, *slightly* more confused than normal.

Chapter End Notes

I'm likely going to stretch this to seven chapters as it's knocked my plot flow a bit, all these new ideas and bits that seem to just

FTT .. And yes, Perfuma will feature a bit more going forward... in some capacity ;)

As ever, comments appreciated - if you spot a mistake or contradiction, please do flag!And any and all feedback is greatly appreciated.

Chapter 6

Chapter Summary

> A plan revealed, motivations questionable. Weakness is spotted, but lessons have already been learned.
>
> Adora learns to not just take what's thrown at her. And we get a little insight into a certain someone's parental behaviour.

It was late afternoon on a Friday, which meant the bar was doing pretty good work - people leaving their offices early for a *"scheduled meeting with important clients"* or *"just a swift one, y'know".* The excuses would be funny if it wasn't for the fact that everyone, from lowly office drone to senior partner used them. Many a time, Adora had had to stop smirking as she'd watched people from the same firm studiously ignore each other at separate booths as each group realised the other had cancelled key meetings just to get to the bar.

As it was still early there wasn't a need for door personnel. That was for when the *proper* end of day kicked off and the rest of the workforce sprinted for their alcohol relief. Then the next wave would hit later, as the theatre crowd spilled out. Then the hardened clubbers.

She walked up the short set of steps, past the cloakroom and into the main bar. It was a wide expanse, with a higher ceiling than the dance room downstairs. White columns flanked the edges, with plush booths nestled between them. High, narrow tables were spread across the rest of the room, not too crowded to be uncomfortable, but sufficient to ensure a good crowd when things got busy. Pastel drapes hung between the columns, allowing for some privacy should it be needed.

Mermista was behind the bar, stacking a few glasses. She glanced over and saw Adora and then gestured enthusiastically for her to

approach. Adora frowned but stepped up.

"Hey Mer-"

"What happened?" her colleague's drawl was urgent and her frown strangely consternated. Adora blinked.

"Huh? I mean, i'm early, not biggie"…

"No, why I mean why did I have to deal with two absolutely *werdoes* about half an hour ago *bitching* about you?"

Adora blinked, "Ok, back up Mer', what's going on?"

"Just after lunch rush, some fancy dressed lady and someone who should, like, be fronting an emo band just straight up came in and *Karen'd* me. Wanted to speak to Angela. About *you*."

Something gripped in Adora's gut and her mind flashed back over the past week - had she offended someone? Annoyed someone or denied them entry? That was fairly easy stuff to get around - they were drunk, they were causing issues. But she couldn't for the life of her remember anyone in line who matched the description. Maybe some mom upset that her daughter got refused entry? But even then… well, who knew.

"Ok… thanks for the heads up. Drawing a blank. I'm sure it's nothing."

But Huntara's slightly cryptic text asking her to *get in early*, *covering for you* now made a bit more sense. She skirted around the side of the bar and pushed open the door that led back to the kitchens and the stairs up to the office.

Beyond the decor of the bar, the rest of the building was a bit closer to a nice hotel - the upstairs was more partitioned, with a couple of rooms dedicated to storage, alongside a few offices. There was

another entrance to the upstairs bar here but Adora ignored that and headed down the corridor to Angela's main office.

As she approached the door she could see it was slightly ajar and she could hear raised voices. Or rather Huntara's raised voice, "*...llshit and you know it. She was here two weeks ago.*"…

Another voice answered, somewhat familiar but Adora couldn't place it, "*And what does that have to do with anything? We've been over this and you're just repeating what Angela has already said. If anything, it just emphasises that your employee acted in retaliation.*"…

"*What retaliation? You daughter.*"…

"*Manager,*" Adora stumbled as she neared the door. That was *Catra's* voice. A slow, easy drawl. But there was something there. Something Adora hadn't heard in a *long* time. A sullen undertone. The tone she used when she'd been cornered or was unhappy about something. Adora remembered hearing that tone when she tried to help her with studies. Or if she'd been arguing with their mutual friends. Or if…

Wait, if that was Catra, then that meant the other voice was *Shadow Weaver?*

Adora shook herself and knocked on the door. The voices stilled and then Angela coughed and spoke, "Come in."

As Adora half stepped into the room she took a moment to take in the setting. Angela's glass desk was set at the far end, with the large bay window the overlooked the park in front of the bar just behind her. A couch was set to the left of the room, with a low coffee table in front of it, strewn with various industry magazines. A pair of modern, comfortable chairs sat on the opposite side of the room. There were a couple of low bookshelves and various awards and framed newspaper cutouts on the wall, along with a pair of large portraits: one of Glimmer and one of Angela's late husband, Micah.

None of the seats, other than Angela's own, were occupied. Huntara was nearly squared up against Shadow Weaver. It was strange, seeing a woman in a waistcoat facing off against someone in a flowing red dress and domino mask. Shadow Weaver wore it to, apparently, cover some sort of scar she'd received at work, though to Adora's mind that just meant a very large papercut, seeing as the woman was mostly grading papers.

Catra, on the other hand, looked like she was trying to shrink into herself. She was leaning against the wall next to the pair of chairs, arms crossed tightly in front of her. Adora's heart skipped a beat. In spite of their rocky history she had to suppress the urge to just go and *hug* her. To crack a goofy joke. To make her smile that small, fanged grin.

Some things never faded, she knew. Which was why it was still an ache in her soul when she saw the girl she'd been best friends with, who she'd lived with. Who she'd… *That* thought made her clam up and she swallowed. Catra wasn't looking at her and seemed to be shrinking back further.

Shadow Weaver, on the other hand, turned slowly to regard her. "*Adora…*" her voice was syrupy sweet, but also faintly admonishing, "You look *well*."

Huntara glared at Shadow Weaver, then glanced at Adora with a half shrug. Angela seemed to be focused mainly on Catra for some reason. Adora took a breath, "Sorry. I can come back?"

Angela's eyes flicked to her and she frowned. Not a good sign, "You're here early, Adora."

Huntara's eyes bugged briefly and Adora swallowed, "Well, you know me. Just felt like swinging by, seeing if I can't help out somewhere before my shift. Get some extra hours, y'know, team spirit," Catra snorted and Adora gritted her teeth and continued, "Make some more *money* on overtime."

She was gratified when her old friend flinched at that a bit. *Maybe she didn't know?* Shadow Weaver turned back to Angela, "You're letting her work? After what we just told you? I'm sure the licensing authority would be very interested."..

Angela held up a hand but continued to stare at the blonde, "Adora, I've just had a fairly serious complaint levelled against you. I believe in avoiding immediate, knee jerk reactions, as you know."

Adora had to bite her tongue as she recalled the various arguments she'd been privy to between Angela and Glimmer, even now, "Of course, um..so, uh..what did I *do* exactly?"

"Of course she doesn't remember!" railed Shadow Weaver, "That's all the proof you *need* Angela."

Huntara was about to speak up but Angela interrupted her, "There was, apparently, an altercation several days ago at *The Fright Zone*. Ms Weaver here decided to come to us directly about it, rather than escalating."

Adora twitched and her gaze swung to Catra, who looked at the floor, then back to Angela, "An altercation?"

It was interesting to watch everyone's reaction to her words. Mainly because she delivered them through gritted teeth. Huntara looked worried, Angela looked surprised. Shadow Weaver just tilted her head. Catra said nothing. Adora blinked and folded her arms, the shoulders of her red jacket tightening under the strain as she tried to hold in her irritation. Angela nodded slowly, "Yes, I am given to understand you were...out of sorts. Were you there?"

Adora nodded, "Yes I was."

"She admits it!" crowed Shadow Weaver. Even Catra frowned at her outburst.

"Ms Weaver, *please*. I know you are prone to theatrics but let us hear the right of it first."

"She will just *deny* it."

"I just admitted I was there, how can I then deny it? Unless I can be in two places at once, which I clearly can't. But that would be a cool thing to do. Save me so much *time*. I mean, I get told I'm not the *brightest* but seriously... that's a bit much."

She was rambling, she was that annoyed. But her chest thrummed as Catra tried to muffle a chuckle. They shared a glance and Catra seemed to look conflicted for a moment, before she averted her gaze again. Strangely, it seemed to calm her down a bit. Shadow Weaver was staring at her, the white eyes beneath the mask looking as if she was trying to pierce her very soul.

But Adora had been to hell. She'd buried her mother and fended off grasping debt collectors, charlatans, obsequious college clerks and mysteriously and conveniently appearing "long lost family members". A middle tier college professor wasn't going to rock her world. She stared right back.

Shadow Weaver broke first, "Fine, you accept you were there. But do you deny *harassing* the staff? Making a drunken *nuisance* of yourself? Attacking one of our customers? *Assaulting* my daughter?"

Adora could see Catra cringe in her peripheral. She stared at Shadow Weaver, then at Angela, "That what she told you?" Angela just nodded, "Yeah. I had a couple of drinks. Wanted to see the old place. You know I used to work there. But I still know the staff?"

Angela nodded slowly, "That... makes sense. But still, Adora, it isn't a good look to get drunk in the middle of the day"…

Adora stared at her boss and blinked. Then she spread her arms, "You run. A. *bar*."

"Yes, but getting drunk is not the point. It's like saying all car owners must break the speed limit."...

Way to pass the blame… Adora began to suddenly sympathise with Glimmer. "I don't recall an altercation. I remember getting irritated and leaving. Unless you mean your daughter getting angry about the rather *handsy* customer who tried it on with *me* ."

Angela frowned and her gaze flickered back to Shadow Weaver, "That element did not arise in your version of events, Ms Weaver."

Adora was in a very strange place, mentally. She normally went along with authority figures if what they said was *fair* . She'd stand up for her friends at the drop of a hat. But she was usually pretty shoddy at standing her ground for herself. Or she HAD been, before Mara died. And these past few months had hardened her in a way that meant her old friends might not recognise her.

"I am not surprised she neglected to tell you. *Ms Weaver* seems to do that a lot," Shadow Weaver glanced between Angela and Adora. Catra had straightened against the wall and was watching, "She seems to be poor at *conveying* things. Goes back a while. Did you tell *anyone* why I couldn't come back?"

"Ungrateful. I ensured your continued attendance at university . I will not be spoken to like some common *churl* . I took pity on you because you have *potential* . You were *drunk* , Adora. You started a fight on *my* premises. You abused my daughter, who tried to defuse the situation. Angela, I *demand* you do something about this. I will *ensure* my staff corroborate my version of events. And maybe you will *learn* from this experience."

There it was. The control. The deflection. Adora had no doubt that Shadow Weaver would say *something* , insinuate *something* to the staff at the *Fright Zone* . Her gaze flitted to Catra who looked suddenly *miserable* . But it wasn't enough. Adora sighed as Angela shuffled in her chair and shook her head as her boss spoke, "Adora, I understand your frustrations but this places me into a difficult

position. You are the *front* of our business. And..well, if it gets about that you are not in control, that your judgement is impaired, it could impact the business."

For the first time in a long time, Adora suddenly *relaxed* . She knew exactly what was happening. It was an eerie sense of de ja vu. That feeling of being isolated, alone, vulnerable. With no safety net. Except this time she had *experience.*

"So, you're firing me?" her voice was calm. She saw Angela wince faintly, "For a *first offence* , based on the word of someone who *lies* habitually?"

"How dare you!"…

Adora stepped forward and Huntara tensed, her eyes uncertain. But Shadow Weaver seemed suddenly fearful. She took a step back, "You told everyone I made it big, didn't you? While I sat, with no friends, no family. And when I came back, you were all to happy to help. But..why? And now *this* ? What is *this* ? Why are you *doing* this? You want me to be like *her?* "

She pointed at Catra who hissed and stood up, "What the hell?"

Adora turned on her, "For a *co-manager* you've been quiet as *hell* Catra. Normally you don't shut up. But then again the *only* person you listened to, ever, was *her* . Never *me* . With Hordak. With your studies. With *anything.* Was this your idea? Another way to just kick me in the ribs? To..to break my heart *again* "?

Catra blinked and her mouth opened and shut. Huntara stepped forward and laid a hand on Adora's arm, "Easy , see, this aint helping"…

Shadow Weaver's voice was honeyed and full of concern suddenly, "See, Angela. She' s hysterical. She..needs a *break* clearly. I am not doing this out of *malice* but *concern* . I am worried you are working your staff too hard. Imagine if the Unions were involved"…

Adora rolled her eyes, "Find a point and *stick to it* ," she snarled. Then she glared at Angela, "And you... I expected *better* ," Her bravado felt about ready to flee. So she puffed up her chest and tilted her chin back, "I'll go clear out my locker . You owe me four weeks pay. And I'll let Glimmer know I'll vacate as soon as."

Angela blinked in surprise, "Adora, that's not necessary, it's just... I mean, I was going to suggest that."..

She didn't wait for an answer . She turned on her heel and walked out, quickly . She heard Angela calling her name but ignored it. She stalked down the stairs, past a confused Bow who'd arrived early then on to the lockers. She wrenched the door open and hauled out her meagre clothes and items and stuffed them into the sports bag she kept there.

Her vision was tunneled. She *may* have overreacted. But, in her head, she was just done putting up with bullshit. People's games. People's *agendas* . She had no idea why Shadow Weaver was there, why Catra had pulled this stunt. She was impatient with Angela's attitude, with the weakness of it all. And she wanted *out* before she could be let down again. Not *again* .

Adora stalked out the back entrance into the alleyway behind the bar. The cool air hit her and she sagged against the opposite wall. The reality hit her as the rage faded.

She'd basically had a *massive* tantrum in the same room as her boss and two *bar owners* . Ignoring the fact that they were *prior acquaintances* they were still legitimate business owners in a town where the network was frighteningly small in her line of work. Which meant she'd likely not just burned her bridges, but also planted depth charges on the pontoons and set up several air strikes on any nearby bridging-adjacent apparatus.

Behind her, she heard the door click open and a heavy hand rested on her shoulder, "Hey Dr. you ok?

Adora chuckled and glanced at Huntara, "I think I trumped Shadow Weaver's flair for dramatics."…

Huntara shrugged and flashed a crooked grin, "I think you rattled everyone. I've never seen you go ham like that. It's not just this whole handsy guy thing, is it? There's something deeper."

Adora nodded and leaned against the wall, head braced against her forearm, "Old history. Basically, friendship went bad when my life went to hell and had to rebuild. Catra the other co-owner? Yeah, lotta unfinished business. Thought I had closure, thought I could move on, or was moving on. I don't know. It still *hurts*. It shouldn't. I'm *stronger* than that."

"Stay rigid and you'll break." Huntara chided. Adora glanced at her.

"That's what she said." She watched as the purple skinned woman chortled and slapped her shoulder.

"Attagirl. Keep the humour. Trust me, it'll help you through things. But, as I was *saying*, don't be too stoic. You know the harder you push, the more you're likely to crack. Like a punch, you don't just flail, or slam a knuckle in. There's technique involved. Same with emotions."

Adora frowned, "So, dealing with my issues is like punching someone?"

"Yeah, sort of. Sounded better in my head."

"Ugh, doesn't matter. I'm fired, need to get my resumes out. Maybe see if Perfuma needs a barista."

"Don't be too hasty. Those two left pretty much after you did and you know what Angela's first words were after they went out the door?"

"What?"

“ *Dammer is going to murder me...* ‘- and let me tell you she looked mortified. Ireckon let her stew , youll have *something* . May not be door work for a bit, but think you can wrangle something. You called out that preening cow, and her lackey.”..

Adora flinched and sighed, “She’ s.she’ s not a lackey. Shadow Weaver is *intense* . And..controlling. Inever really saw it at University, but Catra would do damn near *anything* that woman asked her to. Dropped plans, rescheduled classes, the works. Spoke shit about her, yeah, but she wanted *something* from the woman.”

“W ow, girl with mom issues..how original,”deadpanned Huntara, then winced as she realised what she’d said, “Sorry , Dr , didnt mean about you.”

Adora sighed and shrugged, “I have some, yes..but Catra..Im angry at her. So angry. But Icant be angry forever . Especially if she’s just taken her mom’ s word. Cant expect anything dif ferent from her. Ijust wish”…

Huntara nodded and patted her shoulder, “Y eah kid. Lifell throw people like that at you. They..can let you down. Best thing is to know you tried your damndest, alright?”

Adora nodded and straightened, “Thanks Huntara. Guess this leaves you a bit high and dry?”

“Eh, Seahawk’ s on call,”they both fell silent and stared into the middle distance.

“W ell, that’s revenge enough.”

“T urnoutll be abysmal.”

“His shanties *carry* really well. Scarily well.”

“Y ou want to clear a city block in ten minutes, there’s your solution,” mused Huntara, “Eh, keeps it quiet.”

"You'll be bored."

"Not bothered. Angela needs to see *consequences*. Great lady, but damn she needs to think sometimes. Sticking Seahawk on door duty and watch the punters just *run*."

Adora shrugged, bored by the topic, "Well, gonna head home. Woo, surprise rest time! Yeah!"

Huntara suddenly swept her into a bear hug, "Just.don't do anything dumb, Dora."

She managed a wheezing reply and a nod before the big woman released her, then shouldered her bag and left the alleyway. She'd gone a couple of streets from the bar before a hand grasped her arm and turned her around. Adora hissed in response and took a step back. She fixed a glare on her pursuer - Shadow Weaver.

"Adora. I would like a moment. Coffee?"

She stared at the woman and blinked, suddenly stunned. Her features schooled themselves into a mask of incredulity, "And why in the *hell* would I do that? So you can then make up *another* story?"

Shadow Weaver cocked her head as if genuinely puzzled, "Adora, I am only looking out for you. It was better that I went to Angela, rather than escalating to some sort of… *professional body*. And in doing so I have drawn your own attention to the frankly lacklustre and *amateur* business she is running. She has shown *no* loyalty, no decent character."

Adora continued to stare, "So.what, this was some grand *experiment*?"

Shadow Weaver nodded and reached out to cup Adora's face. She flinched back and shook her head. The older woman retracted her hand with a sigh, "I only want the *best* for you, Adora. I see it with so many students, their failings, their lost potential. I know you could do

great things, but you *wasted* your talent on some meaningless pursuit. We both know your passions lie elsewhere."

This was *weird* . Adora could count the number of in depth conversations she'd ever had with this woman on two hands and still have fingers to spare, "What the hell do you know?"

"You loved *The Fright Zone* . It was your *home* . It could be again."

That came out of nowhere, "You're recruiting me?"

"Of course. I need someone I can *rely* on there. Someone with *more* potential, with actual thoughts and ambitions."

Adora stared at the woman and slowly smiled, "You want me to come in as, what? A bouncer? A bar girl? To mop the toilets?"

"No, Adora. I want you to *run* it. This has presented me with an opportunity that I did not envisage when I helped Catra purchase that place. But she lacks vision. You... you could build an *empire* ."

A cold feeling settled into Adora's gut, "Why *did* you help her get it then?"

"I had always hoped she would aspire. But, no. She was only ever interested in a dive bar. In *music* . Or her paltry *causes* . Nothing greater. I believed giving her some responsibility would help. Allow me to continue her education. To keep an eye on her. You know her, she requires *guidance* . But now, now I can see a return on that investment."..

Adora shook her head, "You are one... messed up woman," Shadow Weaver seemed genuinely surprised. So was Adora. Two outbursts in a day? Two utterly honest takes? Well, three if you counted the Lonnie conversation. Four, with Scorpia's chat, too, but that barely constituted a conversation. Today had been *heavy* .

"Excuse me?"

"I may be unemployed, hard up, at my limit. But you *miscalculated*. For someone with a fancy education and all that brainpower, you really are just… *awful* with people. That place. It's a *leash* for Catra, isn't it? And now you want to use it to get *me?* I barely *know* you."

"I gave you a chance again! And this is how you repay me?"

Adora held up her hands and backed away, "You. You need *help*."

Around them, passers by were pausing to watch the altercation. A few people seemed to be fishing their phones out. Shadow Weaver raised a hand then froze and took in her surroundings. She inhaled, then folded her hands in front of her, "Consider my offer, Adora. You are *emotional* right now. You will see it is the better option. I would hate for things to *escalate."*

Adora gave her a once over and pursed her lips, "Bye bye," and with that she stalked away, leaving the woman in the red dress behind her.

The apartment was empty when she got in. It gave her a chance to unwind and consider, spending an hour or so on the couch just thinking. She made a simple meal, some noodles and stir fry. Out of a packet. In the microwave. The chance of her igniting something in the flat was too high if she used the hob.

She finished her meal as the sun began to set and moved to her room. After a moment's consideration, she hauled out a few suitcases from her closest. But then her phone began to buzz. She answered and before she could get a word in edgeways, Glimmer's voice cut through.

"Adora, don't you dare start packing."

She blinked, then looked at the phone, then brought it back to her ear, "Uhhh, well, your mom"…

"*…is an idiot. I have told her this. REPEATEDLY. And said that if she kicks you out then I stop taking the reins. And Bow leaves too."*

"You got Bow to…but he loves it there!"

"It's a quiet afternoon. Apparently Seahawk is out front and, well, you know what that does to the line. So we had a chance to talk it over. And he's on board. Best friend squad first."

"Has Seahawk started reciting to passers by?"

"*Yeah, not sure how we tie in 'Avencha!' into our bars branding soooo…anyway…, please don't pack."*

"How'd you know I was going to?"…

"Mom. Huntara told me what happened, I called her and…well she confessed you'd said that and…yeah she asked me to ask you not to."

Adora shrugged, then realised Glimmer couldn't see her, "Yeah, also tell her that Shadow Weaver tried to poach me the *minute* I was out the door."

"Wait, WHAT? And… …did you? Did you?"…

"Take up the job offer from the random woman who I barely know, who is the step-mom of the girl who actively hates me, who just tried to get me *fired*? Nah, I passed."

"That is…messed up. So, um, are you…have you quit?"

"Angela fired me, I think."

"You think? She was...she wasn't going to...It's why she wants me to stop you. You still have a job, just... maybe not front of house for a while?"

Adora sighed and sat on her heels. She placed the phone on the bed and switched to speaker, "Look, Glim...I get it. She had a point. But, yknow, not the best way to handle things? She could've told me to come back later. She could've said she'd deal with it, sent them away. And, frankly...I didn't feel backed up there. I'm not sure I want to go back."

There was silence on the other end of the line. When Glimmer spoke, she was quieter than normal, "*I guess I can understand that...it's just, well"...*

"No, Glim. Don't try to guilt me. This isn't about *you*. It's about someone letting me down. And me putting myself in the position...I messed up, trying to fix something. But I don't think I was trying to fix it. And your mom, well. Shit choices, right? Let me...let me cool off and we'll see."

She heard Glimmer cough, then respond, "*Sure thing, Adora. I'll ask Bow to be quiet when he gets in later. I'll be back about ten, if you want to talk?*"

"Thanks Glimmer. I'm just going to sleep, ok? It's been a heavy day. Like you would not *believe*."

They exchanged a few more words, then hung up. Adora surveyed her bags, then sighed and shoved them to the side of the room. Plumeria was sounding kind of nice right now. But currently, she needed sleep. She stripped off her blazer, tight dress pants and her shirt. That left her in a sports bra and boy shorts.

Adora flexed and rolled her neck, then fell onto her bed. She stared at the ceiling, then leaned over to her bedside table and plugged her phone in. The day had been a rollercoaster, but some positives had come out of it. If nothing else, she felt less like a doormat now -

applying some of that front-of-house no nonsense attitude to other conversations seemed to have gone well.

Aside from the *tantrum* . But, with any luck, she'd not have to engage with Shadow Weaver or Catra again for a while. Her mind did mull over the whole *escalation* threat but dismissed it - the woman could try. But going there required things like *statements* or *CCTV* footage. And even then it was a messy process. Shadow Weaver was used to an academic environment, where her words carried weight. Trying to blacklist her across however many bars in the city? A little more of a challenge. And then she could always just *leave* . Everyone seemed to think she had form there. Why not confirm it.

Adora sighed and draped an arm over her face. Within moments, she was out like a light.

Chapter 7

Chapter Summary

Adora makes some DECISIONS. A case of confused intent.

A new ally to smooth things over, or just cause some chaos.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Twelve solid hours of sleep was a *shock* . Adora had to actually crack her eyelids open and found the morning light to be *not good* . She let out a groan of protest and buried herself under the comforter and pillows. She felt rested but groggy. It was clear that too much sleep left her feeling like she had a *hangover* .

A tentative knock at the door stirred her and she peeked an eye between a gap in the covers, "Go away ," she managed.

The sound of Glimmer frustrated *ugh!* Came through the door, "I hope you haven't packed Adora. We said nothing rash."

"Not dboss omeeee," she mumbled.

"What was that? Oh you did so not"…

"*Hmm* , what did we say about *pressure* ?" Bow's gentle voice cut through the start of Glimmer's rant. How the heck was he still awake? Adora grouched, then sat up, still wrapped in her duvet. She glared at the door, "Cmin"…

There was a hushed conversation on the other side of the door, then it creaked open. Her friends peered in and gave tentative grins, "Heeeeeey , so, how are we feeling?" tested Bow .

Adora shrugged, which just caused the duvet to shift faintly. Glimmer frowned and nodded, "Ok. So, thinking it's a Saturday hot chocolate and movie morning?"

Adora nodded mutely. She did not do well with post adrenaline crashes. Well, post exercise endorphins and adrenaline were always good. Post emotional-exhaustion? Yeah that was *not* a fun cooldown. She stood and shuffled out of the room and towards the communal couched, where she then faceplanted onto it. It shifted as she felt Bow sit near her feet. Glimmer shoved her and lifted her head to lay it in her lap. They sat like that in silence for a while as Adora properly came too. Glimmer carded her hair gently whilst Bow navigated through some of the shows available on the TV. He stood and headed for the kitchen area and Adora heard the gurgle of the electric kettle and the clunk of the fridge.

He returned shortly bearing chocolatey-mana which helped somewhat with the perspective issues. She sighed and sat up, the duvet falling from her shoulders, leaving her in her tank top and boy shorts. Glimmer glanced at her with a concerned frown, "So. What now?"

Adora shook her head slowly, "Not sure... I think I need to have a break from Brightmoon, though. Even if... if I'm not fired, I *am* angry. And, well... I think I need to think about how to respond."

Bow frowned, "What do you mean? Sounds... legal," Glimmer looked concerned as well. Adora ploughed on.

"I got carried away, put myself in a position that... wasn't great. That's on me, like I said. But I will *not* be spoken to like some… child. Sorry Glim, not even by your mom. I won't be used in some weird as hell game that Shadow Weaver is playing. And I don't like how your mom basically *let* her play it."

Glimmer looked conflicted - this was all very familiar to her; her mom tended to be just as reactive with her. But then, it was different if it was *her* complaining about it rather than Adora. She looked like she

wanted to defend her mom, but a slight shake of the head from Bow made her bite her tongue. Adora noticed and shrugged, but smiled. Bow heaved a sighed and leaned back on the couch.

"Alright, great. Those are *goals* . But what are you gonna *do* Adora?"

"First of f..find some other income. *J ust* temporarily, Glimmer. Until I work this out. We're all temps under Angela *anyway..* Second..no idea. But I'm thinking...union."

Glimmer winced, "I mean..that seems ex..treme."..

Adora cocked her head at her, "I know you're set to be the boss at some point, Glim, but it won't be sunshine and roses. What happens when you're in the chair and someone screws up?"

Glimmer blinked, "Uh, *what?*"

"If you were there, now , and this came up..what would you do?"

Her friend blinked and opened her mouth. Then she closed it and licked her lips, then chewed her cheek. She looked away, then glanced back at Adora and cringed, "I..don't know . I *want t* o say I'd stand up for you but..but I know that, well..it' s a business."

Adora sighed but nodded, "I wanted you to say that too..but I'm big enough to know it's not that simple. But there's another side to this, Glim...what happens if *Shadow Weaver* is on the other side of that desk? Or you do what your mom did? Does Mermista have to rely on the fact we're friends to hope you'll be cool? Or if you're in a bad mood, do we all have to work overtime?"

"Hey I'd never.." she glared at Adora, but the blonde held her gaze. Glimmer twitched. Bow held his breath. Then Adora made a gesture that encompassed the *whole* of Glimmer.

"See? What if you were my boss *now* ? Cowing me with anger , emotional arguments? Where' s my *out* Glimmer? Can I guilt you

right back? You're *Bow's* boss. Does he get extra shifts? What happens if you two fight?"

"Hey! We can totally split work and home!"

Adora shook her head and pointed to herself, "This right here… home and work, right now. We're nearly arguing Glim. It isn't just a shirt you take off. I go to the gym, I beat myself up. I'm not booksmart, I *barely* cope with squishy emotions. You shout at me at work, I can't turn that off when we walk in here," She inhaled, "We live together. When does it become *weird*? What happens when you get so *angry* that you overstep and we hope we can patch it up? This whole thing, everything. It just got me thinking."

Glimmer looked like she wanted to argue, but there was also a creeping realisation in her eyes - that her future was a *lot* more complex than running a bar with her friends. Bow exhaled suddenly and they both looked at him. He was staring into the middle distance, "Yeah. yeah what happens if. if you have to *fire* someone, Glim? We all talk about being emotionally open but. yeah."

Adora shrugged, "I don't know how Angela manages. But she isn't *our friend* / She's your *mom* Glimmer. And I love her , I really do. But this just shows I'm too close for the moment. So, I'm. gonna take a break from the bar, get some distance. I won't move out, that was me being *dramatic* , yeah."

Glimmer giggled and sighed. She looked drawn all of a sudden. Worried. Adora reached out and pulled her into a hug. They sat still for a moment before Bow made a *dawww* noise and joined them. Glimmer sniffled, "It's. so heavy , Adora."

"I know . I'm ruining Saturday chocolate and movie morning"…

"No...no, it's needed. But was it just my mom?"

Adora leaned back as the trio split from the hug, "No. I just realised I have a *lot* of stuff I've not actually dealt with. Plus, Catra's mom is

weird . Like *super weird* . Like *super weird with an obsession* weird."

Her friends nodded, "So, that' s something else? Is Catra involved? Think she"…

Adora shook her head, hard. Something about Catra that day had dislodged in Adora's chest. Some sort of block. A seal against anything stronger than *missing* her. All of her old emotions were there now, just below the surface. It had been the way Catra had tried to be the smallest person in that room. The mild slips of honest reactions through the heavily guarded facade.

Catra had only been like that when she'd first met her . Had only been that afraid when they were stuck somewhere totally unknown, surrounded by too many strangers. Or when her *mom* was nearby. Adora had thought it was irritation at first. But now she knew what it was.

Fear .

"She. there' s *something* there. But I think, maybe. maybe I didn't try hard enough."

"That' s dumb Adora, you were"…

"Not *THEN* . But maybe *now* . Or at least when I did get back. I don't know, but there's something else. Something I didn't really see before. And, well. I don't know , it's a *lot* to unpack and, well, *not exactly my thing."* Luckily, she knew a girl who had this stuff *covered* . Two birds, one stone, perhaps? She placed her empty mug back on the coffee table and smiled at her friends, "I'm gonna head out for a bit. Clear my head. Think a bit, ok?"

They nodded at her and suddenly exchanged a glance, "Um. how long for?"

Adora gave them both a deadpan stare, "Seriously?"

Glimmer pouted, "I'm kinda down Adora and"…

"NOPE! NO! No. I do not need *Seahawk* level detail on your impending *ADVENTURE!"*

Bow grinned and made a *squee* noise and Glimmer glared at Adora, "Well now you've killed the mood," Adora just winked and gathered her duvet up.

"Yeah, right. Bow's gonna to be pillaging your booty any second now"…

Glimmer shrieked and covered her ears, "ADORA!" Bow fell off the sofa, cackling.

Forty minutes later Adora was pushing the door of Perfuma's coffee shop open. Immediately, the perky blonde girl was in front of her, beaming, "HEY Adora! So, um, the usual?"

She blinked and smiled, "Hey Puma, yeah that'd be great. Oh and"…

"GREAT! I'll be right there, take a seat. Sorry, bit hectic today"…

She wasn't wrong. A young, black haired girl with a bored expression was behind the counter, serving and prepping. There was a queue, Adora noticed. And a few of the people in it were *glaring* at her.

Ah.

She smiled and scooted behind the line of people and made a beeline for a more secluded seat. Some more staff were clearing tables and heading for the register. She recognised a few, but it still seemed a bit undermanned. Which was maybe *good* for her

purposes. Perfuma returned with her drink and set it down. Adora tried to grab her attention, but the girl had bustled off to shepard more customers and errant staff. She sighed and settled down for a wait - not like she wanted to go back to the apartment any time soon. Not without some serious noise cancelling headphones. She'd just been leaving the place when she'd heard *someone* yell *DENTU* and had slammed the door hard. She wondered if that had been on purpose. And it had kind of sounded like Glimmer.

She checked her phone and saw a missed call from Angela, but no voice mail. A couple of texts from Huntara, just checking in. And one from Lonnie.

L: R ok? We had a weird eve. U weren't at the bar - some sailor dude?

Adora chuckled and texted back:

A: Yeah, bad vibes at work. A mutual friend and her co-boss paid a visit

L: Shit! Sry, what was it abut?..

A: Last week. Me. Shouting.

L: Fr sake. Queen witch? Sry , if id nown wuldve said at coffee!

A: No sweat. Not paranoid to think this is sum master plan

L: Wht hpnd?

A: Sort fired, sorta not. Walked out. Too much BS.

Considering Lonnie and her had only *just* reconnected, it felt a bit strange to share. But start somewhere, right?

L: Huh. Fol explains why Scorp is snitty 2day

A: Snitty . Who says SNITTY

L: Me, bitch.

A: Hey, I resemble that remark

L: YASS. Neway, S came out with us, no C... texting a storm. Then left early. Looked PSSED.

A: Scorpia never looks pissed... u mock me?

L: Nuh uh. Str8up. W ent out for a coffee 2day, before afternoon shift. She not happy. Not talking

A: Scorpia never stops talking... sorry, repeating

L: Truth tho. Sum thin gon rong.

Adora frowned at her phone then looked up as Perfuma bustled past. She put the text conversation to one side and waved at the girl. The line seemed to have died down a bit, "Hey, uh... got a moment Perfuma?"

"What, oh, sure Adora. Frosta' s got this now i think. Bit crazy, yknow, Saturday rush. For coffee."

"Is that a thing? I mean, bars I get... coffee shops, not so much?"

"Oh same sort of principle, supply, demand, fulfilling a spiritual and basic need of the soul." Perfuma beamed at her, "You wanted to talk?"

Adora was sure she heard *something* in the question. But she was probably imagining it. Her friend was probably a bit stressed, "Yeah, I have something I wanted to ask you."

Perfuma blinked, "Yes?"

"And the timing isn't great, I know..."

"Yes?"

t's a bit awkward, and, well, I feel a bit like..."

"*Yes?*

"We've known each other for, what, a good few months now, and I wouldn't want to take advantage of that...us being so close and..."

Perfuma was leaning towards her, scarily close, "And...?"

Adora blinked, "...and I wanted to know if you have a job, if you could see me...maybe working here?"

Perfuma blinked. Several times. Her smile seemed a bit glassy all of a sudden and Adora's *exceedingly slow* situational awareness honked its horn in the back of her brain. She swallowed and tried for a smile, then stood up abruptly. Perfuma blinked, "Um..."

"I'm sorry, Perfuma, that was really really rude of me and, well, inappropriate and, of course, not at all in line with what you expect from me as a person, or someone who respects you and likes you and admires you and..."

Perfuma reached out and grabbed Adora's arm, "You admire me?" she said quietly, with a smile. Adora smiled back and sat down.

"Um, yes. You're...you run your own shop. You are *always* so positive. And kind! And you know *everyone*. Not because you want to gossip but...because you want to help."

Perfuma tilted her head slightly and watched Adora. Her smile was sad for a moment, "But you don't *like* me like that do you?"

Adora considered for a moment, then reached out and took Perfuma's hand and squeezed it, "I like you too much to lie, Fuma. I am...in a weird place. Have been for a long time. I think, who I am now has a *lot* of stuff to work through. And you'd...You'd be great for me, I'd be so *so* lucky. But I have someone I care about who I

need...need to work out of my system. And Icant be good for anyone until Ido."

She offered a sad smile of her own and swallowed as the barista placed her other hand atop hers, "Thank you...for being honest. I think Ive maybe rubbed of f on you a bit, Adora. That was...self aware. Youre partly wrong - Id be lucky to have you too. But looking at you, Iknow...Ithink Ive seen it and"...Perfuma looked away and shrugged, "Maybe Im jealous."

Adora blinked, "Jealous of...what?"

Her friend looked back with a wistful gaze, "Y ou come in here, so determined. So focused. But when you sit down and look out the window you seem to be somewhere else. Thinking of *something* else. Ive seen you smile at me, at others. But you *never* smile like that at anyone. When youre by yourself and you think no one' s watching."

Adora blinked but couldnt really come up with a response. t sounded cheesy as anything. Like some sort of budget romantic movie cliche. But she did come here to contemplate, to think about things. t never really *helped* but it had been a coping mechanism between her hellish scheduling. She couldnt even remember what shed been *remembering* but she had a sneaking suspicion. So, Adora just nodded.

"Im sorry , Perfuma. Iguess that wasnt what you wanted to hear?"

"W ell, i would have liked a three course meal and then to not walk for a week, yes,"Adora had taken a sip of her drink and nearly spat it across the room. Perfuma giggled, "That was worth it."

Adora hacked briefly and stared at the girl, "Y ou are going to make some girl *really* lucky, yknow that?"

"Only if they can keep up."

Adora was quietly analysing her options, but her horndog brain was overridden by her moral brain - one night stand was a big no-no here. Trying to avoid incinerating more bridges, "Anyway , this was… awkward and I can go, sorry Perfuma. How much do I owe you?"

The grip on her hand was surprisingly strong and Adora arched an eyebrow at the girl who drew a deep breath, then met her gaze, "You need a job?"

"Uh I mean…won't this," she gestured between them, "Make it a bit weird?"

"I think I can manage rejection, especially when it's for a good reason. Also, friendship first, crush second. And also, you could change your mind. Best to keep you where I can see you. *Kidding* . Mostly," Adora wasn't sure what to do with *aggressive* Perfuma. Deflection, perhaps? The lesbian version of chaff? What was that? More lesbians? The barista's giggle brought her back, "I do like flustered Adora. I'll tone it down. So, why are you looking? I may need references."

"For the job or…" Adora couldn't help but flirt a *little* . Perfuma snorted.

"Careful. And for the work."

"Well, had an altercation with my boss. I suppose…well in the interest of being upfront, seeing as I'm doing this whole *bearing my soul* thing"…

She gave a brief update but kept it relatively light on the personal details - basically that someone had reported her and Angela had been rather vague. Perfuma shrugged, "Did you get your rep involved?"

"Uh, not a union member…" murmured Adora, "Was going to ask if *you* knew anyone as my follow up, actually"…

Perfuma nodded and smiled, "Of course. I run the shop, but I've made sure permanent staff are registered with their union. And have got the temps involved too. Got to keep myself covered too!"

Adora blinked. What was with all these women being so switched on? Or at least being in a position to be choosing to be *in charge* in some way. She coughed and fiddled with her empty mug, "Yeah, so that's the story. I'm not, technically, fired, but it's a grey area. And I don't want to talk to my boss until I've got an opinion from a rep. But I also want to have some part time stuff, as, well. I need to keep the money going!"

"Unfortunately true. I was considering going back to Plumeria to set up a co-operative there. Thaymor can be a bit *too* driven by money," murmured Perfuma. Adora chuckled.

"A couple of weeks ago, I'd have probably joined you." she trailed off and shrugged. There was a brief flash of a bittersweet smile on Perfuma's face but it faded.

"Eh another life, or later maybe. So, it sounds like you need something. And, well, yes a job here? You can see it's a bit, well, crazy. Can you start tomorrow?" Adora blinked and nodded rapidly, "Good. Frosta will be in and we can both run you through things. And as part of that, it makes it a bit easier to introduce you to the local service union representative. They're a bit enthusiastic, but they are very very keen on ensuring representation and balanced approaches."

Adora continued to toy with the mug and watched as Perfuma excused herself to head behind the bar. She returned shortly with a business card in her hand and a pamphlet. She sat back down next to Adora and pointed out the key contacts and elements of Unionising or at least becoming a representative. It was all a bit much, initially, but when she felt Perfuma squeeze her arm and flash her a reassuring smile, she relaxed somewhat.

t’ s important. t’ s not that bosses are bad, but think of it like speeding laws..not everyone will drive fast, but you need guidance for some people who dont realise why going too fast is bad.”

t was still a somewhat alien thought to Adora. She’d been to student union meetings, where everyone was either so high as to barely talk or so militant she was expecting them to storm City hall and emancipate the computers. But she didn’t want to go back and get either brow beaten by Angela, or find herself in a compromised position. She felt guilty thinking that way about Angela and, frankly, wouldn’t have considered it if not for that meeting.

She blew out a breath and nodded, then pocketed the card and pamphlet, “Thanks fuma. Im gonna go for a walk, have a think. t’ s a big step. W ell, right now everything feels like a big step.”

Perfuma shrugged, “People change jobs. Lives shift. Things change. ts not the end of the world, just a change of perspective.”

Adora smiled, “That’ s a nice way of putting it. I guess I’ve always seen change as bad, yknow? A fight.”

Perfuma nodded, “But it can also be a chance to not fight. T o accept and move on.”

“Eh, try that line with bailiffs. Doesn’t go over well,” She was finding it easier to look back, to recollect. To make *jokes* . t hurt, still. But like a dull ache. Amazing, really , considering yesterday it had been a spike in her chest. But now it was less. t just *was* .

She bade Perfuma farwell and considered the afternoon salvaged. And she had potential *options* , even if that felt a little bit sleazy to think about on one level. She checked her phone again and frowned. There’d been a few more messages from Lonnie.

L :You k Dora? Gone quiet.

L :K we just called in 2 work, not our shift, think 2 do w/u?

The next message was a good half hour later . Adora realised she'd been in the coffee shop for a good couple of hours.

L: Shit's on sum sort of mission. Wants 2 no what happened

L: Holee shit!

L: SHIT SHIT SHIT!

L: Scorpia just QUIT!

L: This is effed up.

She tried calling Lonnie but got her voicemail - clearly *something* was going down. She tried a couple more times, but got nothing. She hissed, unsure why she was suddenly frustrated, worried. They were her friends, *kind of* . But she'd now seen Shadow Weaver in action and knew that whatever had happened was probably on the scale of *freaky* to *ok I 'm backing away now.* Considering Scorpia had quit that meant it was to the latter end of the scale.

She stared at her phone, mind reeling. She fished out the card Perfuma had given her and studied the number, then dialed. She was going to *anyway* but something else was compelling her now as well. She blinked when a voice that could only be described as *sleek* answered.

" *Hello? Who is this and how may I service you?*

"Uhhh..hi. My name's, um.. Adora and Perfuma gave me your contact details so..".

"*Oh silly me, answered the work phone. Sorry honey , Let me get my* amateur *calling going. Let's take it from the top... Hello, which bitch of a manger are we fucking up today?*

Adora couldn't help but snort and grin, "Uh, no one.yet.".

"OOOO, anticipation! I 'm getting all interested, mystery girl. So, you clearly aren't a member yet, seeing as this is an intro from my favourite cream of coffee. Tell you what, it's my off day, in as much as we reps get off days. I..RONI C I know oW rking rights for stiffs and I get stiff from working right.. I. f I 'm doing it right of course."

Adora could feel herself going beetroot. She wasn't sure if she was offended, turned on, embarrassed or some combination of the above, "So, uh, is that code for wanting to meet up?"

" *Honey, you had me at MEAT. I know a little diner on the south side. Quiet, informal. T ek a friend so they know where you are. I don't bite unless you ask, or your some abusive employer who I can go to town on, but always best to make sure we play it safe. See you there in twenty honey. I prefer the personal touch."*

The diner had been *something* . Retro, with a jukebox, all-day breakfast and an eclectic clientele. Truckers rubbed shoulders with people in suits and residents from the shadier part of Thaymor. Ties to corsets to flatcaps. Adora had felt both over *and* underdressed in her sweatpants and hoodie.

She had texted the Union rep as she entered and saw an arm flailing at her from a corner booth. Despite the mix of people, the place wasn't crowded. She paused as she caught sight of her contact and mentally readjusted her expectations, then slid into the booth. The figure opposite her sported long blond hair that bordered on white, with a buzzshave on one side. A tailored jacket with no sleeves overlaid a black shirt and tie. They wore a pair of black, long-sleeved gloves and thigh high boots, with matching leather skirt. The figure extended a hand.

"Double T rouble, TD for short. I prefer my full name for certain situations, professional or no. Adora? Nice to meet you."

Adora took the proffered hand and shook. TD's grip was firm, confident and short. No lingering touch or forceful attitude. The language was suggestive, but clearly they weren't in the business of being too aggressive, "Um, thanks for , well... making time?"

TD shrugged, "It's what I'm here for . Usually this sort of thing is an involved process. Paperwork like you wouldn't *believe* . Or used to be. Businesses fight like cats in a sack to stop employees getting organised. But nothing stopping a single enquiry at least. Glad you took the plunge, honey. You'll find a *lot* of the service people in town are part of our Union."

"Oh? I mean, I haven't heard of it, much"…

"You wouldn't have. It's not *seemly* to stand up for the little people. And I don't mean the mushroom gang from Baltor . Anyway, The Alliance is all about ensuring proper contract compliance and flagging abuse of trust. Cards on the table, we aren't free, there's membership and we do end up having fairly regular engagement with the bars and licensing authorities. We are a recognised body… but mine is a little more *obvious* , of course."

"So, uh... you do what? Tell bosses to stop being... bad?"

"Oh *no* sweetie. They never really listen... not until we support you guys with strikes, or litigious activity. We can help with negotiation, which is when they *do* listen. I assume we're going for *that* option first, of course?"

"Um, I may have quit... or not... I'm not sure."

TD folded their hands on the table and gave a half smile, "Let's start again... this is a consultation now , sister, because damn to you need it. Do you *have* a contract?"

"Um..yes?" Adora wracked her brains then blinked and opened up her email app on her phone. She scrolled through until she found an old email from Angela, with an attached PDF. She slid the phone over to DD who picked it up and scrolled down the document.

"Ok honey..tell me *everything*."

And she did.

The afternoon progressed well. She was there for another couple of hours as DD explained a few things about her rights, her points of approach and whether or not it would be advisable to challenge at all. Most Union intervention came in at gross breach of contract or abusive behaviour. This seemed minor by comparison, at least to Adora. But DD had shut that down.

"No..you got this right. People never want to be bad, or at least don't, as a rule. *think* they're bad. They may act the part, and I should know, honey. But it's behaviours that slip that gets things to bad places. This contract it's not *bad* but it's *vague as hell*. As an intern I produced better legal contracts than this. When i still worked in the City, I would have chewed this up and spat it in your pretty boss's face, then made her pay me for the privilege."

Adora blinked at that, "Ooooo..kay. And..you know Perfuma *how*?! With all.. That? Corporate versus Fuma..."

"Oh she' s a sweetie. She's one of the good ones. A fine example of someone always *trying* to be better. Puts me to *shame*. Almost sickening, isn't it? Anyway, my advice, and it is *just* advice..sign up as a member. I'll waive the fees for the first couple of months because you seem a decent sort, Adora. And it means we have potential Union involvement with *Brightmoon*"...

Adora smiled, "Um, thanks. I think..well..what next..then?"

"I'd be happy to come with you, act as an intermediary with *Angela*. Point out the appalling lapse of judgement this contract is. And

maybe you convince your friends to hop in too."

"Um, I think I can do that,"

"Ok, no pressure. I know , it doesn't sit well with everyone. I wish we could trust each other and all that, but I've had too many relationships to believe that's even possible. And just a sidebar… Union membership *isn't* to cover poor behaviour from members. Abuse of trust goes *both* ways. We are an avenue of complaint as well, but a bit more egalitarian. Organised workers taking advantage of others is not what we want either. No punching down. I won't stand for it."

Adora nodded vigorously, "No down punching, got it."

"Unless they ask for it, but even then, wouldn't recommend. Oh, how's the *Fight Zone* these days?"

She blinked, "From, what, my incident?"

"That, and your connection. I know you didn't mention *everything* . There's something personal there, isn't there?"

Adora flushed slightly, "It's nothing major."

"If it impacts how you're going to talk to Angela, yes it is. You used to work there?"

"Ages ago."

"Yeah, figured. Personal connection?"

"Yeah."

"Hmmm. Not as serious as it could be then. Not conflict of interest."

"Beyond what the new boss of the place tried to do after dropping me in it?"

"Yeah, that's a thing to mention, as well as the crappy contract. Anyhoo, just make sure you're on top of that ikky personal stuff. And maybe avoid going there? It's another place we've struggled to penetrate. Old management hated us, new one just doesn't think we exist."…

Adora nodded. They spoke for a little longer, then shook hands and parted ways. Adora promised to loop Di in when she set up a meeting with Angela and Di fired over their appointment blocks so she knew when to match it all up.

By the time they were done late afternoon had drawn in and Adora was heading back to the apartment. She checked her phone again but realised Lonnie hadn't called her back. That worried her a bit. She had a creeping sense of deja vu, of being ghosted all over again. But she pushed the thought down. She had to have *some* faith in people. Baby steps.

In the apartment she found a note stuck to the fridge, written in huge, glittery ink. It simply said *Gone on date - don't wait up*. A pair of smiley faces had been drawn underneath.

Another bowl of heated pasta, another quiet evening in. Adora busied herself with finishing some of her coursework, firing it off to tutors, as well as hauling her washing into the machine. Before long she was ready to sink into bed. Once more she found herself staring up at the ceiling. Her eyes began to drift and her eyelids drooped.

The sudden buzz of her phone jolted her awake and she sat bolt upright, a curse half formed on her lips. She hooked the offending item from its charing dock and looked at the number. She didn't recognise it. It was late, so potentially a spam call. But the number looked local. It definitely wasn't Lonnie. Or Glimmer. Or Bow. Or even Angela. She thumbed the answer button.

"Hello?"
There was silence for a moment, then a faint sniffle. Then a familiar, scratchy voice came over the line.

“Hey Aurora…”

Chapter End Notes

What a TWIST!

Two more chapters to go. Please, as ever, let me know if you spot any mistakes, edits or flow issues. Appreciate all the feedback and thoughts so far!

Chapter 8

Chapter Summary

Reunited.

You've heard of moving fast, how about breaking the sound barrier?

Things are worked through. Who knew talking could help. Turns out Shadow Weaver isn't completely stable.

Minor triggers for: Gaslighting, verbal abuse, mentions of bullying, implications of violence

Adora blinked, not quite sure what to make of it. The past 24 hours had been a blur - confrontation, reconciliation, *more* confrontation, sleep, *girl crushes* , potential new job, crazy new ally and now...?

She wasn't sure what to do, what to make of it. Part of her , the part of her that seemed to just be constantly *angry* , that seemed to be a present and persistent pool of bile in her chest, wanted to scream down the phone. It wanted to hang up and throw the thing against a wall. It wanted to punch *something* . For how unfair things were, how alone she had felt, how *attacked* she felt. But another part, the older, gentler part of Adora heard something in the breaths down that connection. The slight hitches, the swallowing, the shuffle of nervous fingers. Faint, but there. It remembered calls early in the morning after a disastrous date, or after a bad weekend with *the mother* .

"Are you there?"

That clinched it. The voice was small. Fearful. The bile gurgled away, replaced by a hollowness and watery eyes, "Catra..." breathed Adora, "What's... Are you ok?"

There's a laugh on the other end of the line that sounds *relieved* . t morphs into a sob and words spill out, " *I t.s.something.it.' s gone wrong. I thought I knew it, thought I had it all and then i saand then. I don't know I just.and everyone left and.I.. tried to as well but.but"…*

Adora blinked again. Catra was rambling. She *never* rambled. She was curt, acidic, *and acerbic* . Words were her knives. This unnerved her,, "Catra, are you ok?What' s happened?..

"Adora.I…I.'m sorry *. I 'm so. So ..So sorry . I "…*

She's a fool, she knows it, "Catra, where are you?

" *I 'm sorry.I..'m..I 'm..wha?*

" Where are you?Right now?

" *No, I 'm...i'm ok i just, maybe I .".*

"Catra, talk, now . WHERE?The girl at the other end of the phone rattles off a junction somewhere near the Fright Zone, "Stay there. Stay in a street light. Are you alone".poor word choice, she realises.

"Y ...yes," the word sounds so defeated. Adora nodded to herself, then stood. Phoned cradled between ear and shoulder she scooped on a set of joggers, then threaded her way into a thermal shirt from her drawer.

"Ok, textsomeone, anyone.even Glimmer if you want, if you have her number. Say where you are."

"Oh...uh...ok." the voice sounds quieter , disappointed.

"Stay there until Iget there."

"W ait, what? now she sounds shocked. Adora keeps the phone on.

"Stay there. Phone got charge? If it does, keep it on, just. Don't talk, just keep the line open, look like you're talking."

Saturday night, almost Sunday morning, Thaymor was quiet. Drunks stumbled through the main streets, but the residential districts were quiet. Adora moved fast. She wasn't quite sure why other than *Catra is in trouble*. It didn't need to be more than that. The bile threatened to rise again but she pushed it down. She couldn't hate. It took too much effort. And her heart wasn't in it, never really *had* been.

Phone clutched in one hand, she jogged. Occasionally, she pulled it to her ear to ask "You still there?"

"*Yeah...yeah I am,*" her voice sounded less watery, more solid. But somehow quieter, uncertain.

"Nearly there. Don't you dare move."

A corner and there she was. Adora paused across the street and stared. Catra stood under a street light, haloed. Her phone was clutched to the side of her head, her other arm crossed tightly in front of her, gripping her right forearm. Her back was to Adora and she could see her old friend's tail as it flicked back and forth, agitated. A small suitcase sat next to the girl.

Adora approached as if in a dream. Her foots seemed loud in the quiet of the street. No cars, no pedestrians. Nothing.

Catra's ear flicked and she tensed, "Adora...I hear"…

Adora hung up. Catra swallowed and turned. Adora could see her ready to fight, ready for some late-night stalker. But her eyes shifted from narrowed, ready to strike tension to sudden nervy fear.

They stared at each other, separated by a scant few feet of sidewalk. Catra swallowed and opened her mouth. But Adora moved first. She surged forward and pulled the smaller girl to her, pressing her lithe frame against her own in a crushing hug. She felt Catra stiffen and

heard her shuddered breath. And then catra's arms were around her, fingers clawing, bluntly, against her back, as if trying to burrow into Adora. She held Catra, felt the girl push her face into her shoulder, heard the muffled whimpers and sniffles.

"Hey…hey. I got you."

"S..sorry ...sorry.."

Adora smoothed down the hair on the back of her friend's head. *Her friend* . Her fingers smoothed over the flattened ears, gently soothing and reassuring. Her heart felt suddenly lighter, as if a lead weight had been severed. She didn't know what might come next, but she didn't want that weight back. Not in *that* way. She wanted the moment to stretch, to last until the last stars burned out and darkness enveloped them in silence and peace.

She was afraid, suddenly, when Catra pulled back slightly. The feline girl's hands slipped from Adora's back and gripped the front of her hoodie, as if afraid Adora would vanish, would flee. Adora moved her own hands to grip Catra's upper arms.

"Hey , I'm here. Come on…I'll take you to mine."

Catra flinched and looked at her, eyes searching, as if confused, "What..I..mean..I don't need.."

Adora arched an eyebrow, "W e can discuss pride…Pain… whatever. But…but I don't want you in a hotel, or on some floor or on a bench.."

Catra seemed to bristle at that, but it was weaker, reflexive, "I can look"…

Adora leaned in close and Catra's voice stuttered as mismatched eyes met grey-blue, "I *know* Catra. But I want to talk. I want to make sure you're ok. And *no* me just seeing you under a streetlight *doesn't*

count . Iam *so close* .and Idont want to let go again. Idont want to do..Whatever this is *out here* ."

She swallowed, willing herself to not shake. She felt the fear creep into her voice. Catra kept looking into her eyes and then nodded, slowly, "Ok"…

Adora let go, but one of her hands slipped down and slid into Catra's. Despite all of her old friend' s protestations she felt the cat-girl's fingers tighten around hers. They walked over to the lamp and Catra struggled with the suitcase. Adora smiled and hefted it with one hand. Catra huffed and arched an eyebrow, but smiled slightly.

They walked in silence, the contact of their clutched hands enough for now. Catra stared at the sidewalk, Adora lead the way. The streets grew quieter and the streetlights began to flicker of f as evening gave way to dark night and technically morning. At her apartment building Adora put the suitcase down and fumbled for her keys, preferring that to relinquishing hold of Catra' s hand. They moved through the foyer, then ascended the stairs. After more fumbling with keys, Adora pushed their way into the apartment proper.

The door to Bow and Glimmer's room cracked a tad and a drowsy looking Bow peered out. The faint sounds of snoring Glimmer emerged. Behind her, Adora heard Catra stifle a snort. The noise made Bow blink in surprise. Adora just shook her head and Bow stared at her, then nodded. The door clicked shut.

She led Catra across the open plan living space to her own door, down a side corridor. Catra seemed to be faintly on autopilot as Adora steered her onto the bed, then set the suitcase to one side, near her own unpacked bags. She saw Catra frown at them quizzically , a strange flash of dread flowing across the tired and tear streaked features. Adora cross the floor and crouched in front of Catra, both her hands at Catra's jaw , thumbs stroking gently across cheeks covered in downy fur.

"Hey , eyes on me," Catra's eyes slid to hers, exhaustion clear in them as the pupils widened. She heard the girl's breath quicken faintly, "I had a bit of a…T antrum. You might remember," she flashed a half smirk and shrugged. Catra shook as a wobbly chuckle emerged, but it too shifted to a sniffle. Adora shook her head gently, "Not going anywhere. Not unless you *want* me to. And only when you're awake tomorrow , ok?"

Catra nodded unsteadily and Adora laid her down on the bed, then turned to head for the door. A hand gripped her wrist suddenly and she turned. Catra lay, arm outstretched, hair now a barrier across her face. Her voice was still quiet, "Don't…don't go. I don't want to wake up."

Adora swallowed and felt her heart crack again. In a *good* way this time. She moved slowly and nudged Catra across the bed, then climbed in, "C'mon you, under the covers. Just like that time you drank that Zamboni special."

A wet chuckle came from the cat-girl, "That was *your* idea, idiot."

"Who's the fool? The fool, or the fool who follows her?"

"Dork,"

"Ass."

Under the covers, Adora considered her clothing. Catra prodded her, "You'll cook."

"Uh, you know how much of a bad idea that is…".

Gold-blue eyes looked at her between gaps in messed up hair, "Well, if you get so hot that you set yourself on fire…not gonna argue *that* point," Catra's words sounded woozy , slurred, a sign of impending sleep. Adora swallowed.

"Totally. Same. Yep. Uh. Lose the sweater, you'll... Broil? Is that a cooking term?"

Catra giggled then moved in a complicated way. A sweater flew across the room and flopped against the back of Adora's desk chair. Adora felt her face flush, but she swallowed her embarrassment and stripped off her joggers, then her hoodie. Boy shorts and a sports bra would have to suffice, along with the duvet, as some sort of modesty shield.

With a cough, she made to turn over, then felt Catra grip her arm and yank her. The girl rolled onto her side and pulled Adora close as she curled up, knees to chest. Adora felt Catra's tail coil around her leg and tighten.

"Guess I'm the big spoon," murmured Adora. There was no answer, save the gentle, rhythmic breathing of deep sleep from her friend. *What happened* she wondered before a wave of exhaustion hit, the price of her emotional expenditure. Her eyes fluttered closed.

Sunday was for lie ins. Normally. It was also normally for being grumpy, brooding and generally bemoaning things.

That might have to get rainchecked.

Namely because most Sundays didn't involve opening eyes to meet a pair of mismatched ones. And a face set in a strange mix of defiance and fear. Adora blinked and felt a goofy smile spread across her face, "You're here," her voice cracked.

Catra's expression flickered and stopped looking defensive and irritated. It became more vulnerable as her eyebrows arched and her

eyes watered. She just managed a short set of rapid nods. Adora realised har arm was draped over her friend's shoulder and suddenly pulled her close.

t was like a dam broke. Catra *broke* and sobbed again. And this time, so did Adora. She'd been on a *mission* the night before but now they were *alone* . They were *secure* . They clung to each other and let the pain just drain out, like drowning girls against driftwood.

Catra was the first to speak, "Gonna need to change your sheets. I made a mess," Adora blinked as she saw the half grin on her friend's face, marred by the watery eyes.

"I'll have to try harder before it becomes a *real* issue," answered Adora. Then she blushed. Her eyes nearly rolled back into her sockets as she tried to look anywhere except Catra's surprised face. Then the cat girl laughed. Her squeaky , snorting *genuine* laugh. Adora sighed happily as Catra's face buried itself against her shoulder and they giggled together.

"I missed this," murmured Catra, "I missed you. *So* much. so so much."

She pulled back and looked into Adora's eyes. The blond got the feeling there was *something* more there, as if Catra was trying to convey *something* . She felt her breath hitch and was suddenly *very* conscious of their proximity . But she didn't move. Instead she reached up and ran her hand through Catra's hair.

"You have no idea, Catra. t just it..."

The cat-girl's expression seemed to crumple and she looked away , "what can I do?" she scrunched her eyes up, "You ou needed me. And I *didn't know."*

Adora pulled her face around and shook her head, "And you *needed me.* No. You've said sorry . *Enough* . You're here. You came. You *asked* . I have a feeling I know. I know something of *why* all this got

the way it did. But can we talk? Because…because I don't want to go back to that. I don't want you to *look* like that. I don't want you to *go* . I just want to make that very *very* clear."

Catra blinked and looked very confused, almost disbelieving, "But… I…you were in so much pain? I know . I"..

"Heartbreak does that," Adora wondered if she was answering Catra's unspoken question or if they were just going turnwise around each other. Words weren't her strong suit, unless back with anger or frustration. Not normally.

She looked to one side and frowned, then felt a clawed finger tip turn her chin back to face the cat-girl. Catra had a determined expression on her face, then arched an eyebrow, "Use your words, Adora."

Maybe it was time to try words motivated by more than alcohol and anger and hurt. Maybe it was time to try words pushed by faith rather than fear. To not kick the can down the road anymore. She knew she'd done it at University , keen to preserve a friendship over what *might* have been. Memories of a bar. Of two girls. Of being joined at the hip for nights out, for ups and downs, for pranks and moments of woe.

She hadn't quite acknowledged it at the time, thought it was something that'd pass. And then Mara's illness had happened. And then *Shadow Weaver* had happened. Adora inhaled and smiled at Catra.

"I think…I think I like you a bit more than I should. For a friend."

Catra looked pensive, "Are…are we friends? After"…

"I want to be."

"Oh,"

"I'd like to be more."

Catra flushed suddenly and blinked, "Ok, who are you and what did you do with Adora?"

The blond grinned, "What?"

"That's that's more direct and *cocky* than you've ever been in in this sort of situation,"

Adora arched an eyebrow, "And what is this situation?"

Catra blinked, "You are you are…"

"You're cute when you're flustered,"

"I am *not* cute. I am I am very highly strung right now , considering and.. And do we need to t…"

Adora cupped Catra's jaw and stared into her eyes, "I said we needed to talk. If you want to talk and and don't want more then…"

Catra rolled her eyes, then grabbed Adora's head and pulled her across the mattress into a kiss. Their lips clashed and teeth clacked for a moment. They pulled apart, giggled, then lunged together again. Adora rolled and Catra was above her, the blond's head cradled in hands with claws sheathed. A tentative tongue probed and lips opened to allow their exploration. They writhed gently against one another, tongues twining sinuously alongside one another before Adora pulled back and gently traced her tongue over Catra's lower lip. She smiled as the blue and gold eyes fluttered closed for a moment and Catra purred.

"I have been waiting a long time for this," murmured Adora, "So… interested in being more then?"

Catra gave her a mock glare, undercut by some shadow of uncertainty, "Yeah I mean, worse options…"

The blond pouted, "A ringing endorsement." Her brain flashed, "Ah, do you you don't mean…"

Catra looked away and sighed, then closed her eyes, "No..no not Scorpia. That..that' s something we should talk about. And, well… a..a lot. Ithink, maybe, well.."Catra shrunk back, "This was a bad idea, Ijust wanted, Ionly wanted to..to say sorry and.."

Adora lunged forwards and grabbed Catra's wrists, then pulled her back into a fierce hug, "Ok, Iknow i said a lot about being *gone if you wanted* to and all that but *no* . No. No. *NO.* You dont get to rock my world and fuck off."

The cat-girl stiffened then chuckled qietly , "Rock you world?"

"Y es. So, shut up for a moment and calm the fuck down. We arent going to be *flighty* about this."

"Flighty?Who says *flighty* ?Y ou sound like Lonnie."

"Girl has good vocab. Now , are you going to bolt or do Ineed to, I dont know , tie you to the bed?"

Catra sqirmed and looked up at Adora, "Promises promises,"

t didnt qite have the intended ef fect as they both flushed at the same time. Conversation became secondary for a moment as they became occupied with hand roaming across bodies at once familiar and long lost. their kiss lasted longer this time, with occasional gasps for air. They broke after a few minutes and stared at each other. Catra nodded slowly, "Ok..ok..not going anywhere."

"Good."

They managed to struggle upright, hair dishevelled, eyes blown with barely suppressed longing. Adora wanted nothing more than to just lie there. Catra seemed in agreement. But they *had* to clear things. Or else this tentative *something* could founder, could fail. Adora swallowed.

"dont want to wake up."

Catra nodded slowly, "It's it. It's not a dream."

"Let's let's talk. I have a spare toothbrush if you need one?"

Catra shook her head and gestured vaguely at the bag. Adora nodded dumbly. They crashed together for another kiss and Catra straddled Adora's lap, arms draped over her shoulders. Adora planted her hands on Catra's hips and groaned as she felt the cat girl grind against her, "Not. Now. or I won't be able to stop."

Catra broke the kiss and leaned into Adora's ear, "Who wants to stop?"

A rap on the door froze them both and Glimmer barged her way in, "Hey Adora, I swear I had the best sleep *ever* , i tell you when Bow does the.". .

She paused one hand raised in an airy gesture and blinked. Catra leaned backwards slowly, still only wearing her ripped jeans and bra and grinned, "Heyyyy Sparkles."

Glimmer frowned and opened her mouth, then closed it. Then opened it again. She gave a thin smile to Catra, then looked at Adora, "Um. a word? Know , *apartment* members only?"

Catra rolled her eyes and made to move but frowned down at Adora's grip on her hips. The blond turned her head to look at Catra, "You. Don't move," her head turned to Glimmer , "Catra and I need to talk. Priority. *Then* we can talk."

Glimmer gawped, "But. she. and" she flapped her hands in a broad gesture that encompassed *all this* - which seemed to be Catra and Adora, "This isn't *talking* ."

Adora nodded, "I know . But it's helping with a *lot* . Anyway, how was your *adventcha* ?"

Glimmer went from pink to deep crimson. The blush began from her chest and rose. Adora smiled sweetly and Glimmer let out a seething sigh, "We are going. To. Talk."

"Yeah. We are," she closed her eyes for a moment, "Glim, trust me. Please. Being intense isn't going to help. There's a *lot* right now… which you know." she arched an eyebrow and gave Glimmer a meaningful look.

Glimmer growled but it was half-hearted. She glared at Catra and pointed a finger at her, "If you *hurt* her"…

Catra fixed Glimmer with a glare of her own but shuddered and fell forward to wrap her arms around Adora's neck, "Never… *never* again."

That stumped Glimmer. Her hand dropped, "Uh. um. Oh. ok. *BOW! Bow* we need to um. go out. Get coffee, Or things. YES! Things."

Bow's reply was muffled but he didn't *sound* surprised. Adora suspected Glimmer had been sent here precisely *because* of her reaction. A test of sorts. Bow would've been too diplomatic. Glimmer was an A-bomb. And Catra seemed to have passed. So had Adora. The pair watched Glimmer scurry out of the bedroom door. Then Bow leaned in, waggled his eye brows and gave a thumbs up, then vanished as well. Catra stared at the open door, then at Adora, "Your friends are…"

"A bit much, I know…"

Catra studied her for a moment and gave a sad smile, "I think they suit you. You needed them when… When I wasn't there," Adora reached up and trailed her fingers along Catra's jaw, "I have to like them for that. Even if I wish…"

"Let's get some coffee. I don't think I can burn the apartment down with a kettle."

Catra snorted, "Well there was that one time…" she yelped as Adora spun her onto the mattress, then stood herself. She planted her hands on her hips and mock glared down at her friend… *girlfriend? No, too soon. But sounds good*.

She realised her mistake as she saw Catra's eyes go half lidded. Adora was still in just boy shorts and a bra, "AH! Behave. In depth emotional talk *first*. Emotionally invested sex *after*."

The brunette swallowed and stared at her, "S...sex?"

Adora blushed, "I mean… maybe? If, well.. Sorry I'm being forward and"…

Catra was upright and searching for her top, "No time dummy, coffee, then talk, then… yes, yes… that stuff if you just said. Quick."

The sudden movement dragged a yelp from Adora as she was pulled towards the bedroom door, "Catra, CLOTHES!"

The girl paused then looked at Adora, "H..uh. Y eah. Imean, youre rocking that look. Idont mind."

"Out. Go put the kettle on. Brush teeth. *Shoo* ."

Catra grinned, then spun and left the room. Adora didnt miss the extra sway to her hips, nor the swish of the tail. And the fact that Catra caught her looking with a tilt of her head made her blush just go from rosy to sunrise levels of colour.

She dressed quickly and dashed to the bathroom. Catra had the kettle on then dipped back into the bedroom to fish her toiletries out. She joined Adora in the bathroom and they brushed together . t was oddly domestic, a level of intimacy almost more important than the kisses theyd shared. They nudged each other playfully as they cleaned, giggling through foam. Back in the living area Catra rummaged through for mugs as Adora pulled out the coffee tin and sweetener. They moved around each other with the memory of months long past. People whod lived in each other 's orbit for so long they didnt realise how close theyd become. A normal they hadnt seen until it was gone. The absence had left pain and anger and confusion. For now it was still delicate, like glass. They both feared a word, a wrong move would shatter it.

Away from the bed a strange awkwardness settled and they sat on the sofa with a small distance between them. Adora coughed and licked her lips then shook her head. Catra frowned, then yelped as Adora grabbed her and hauled the cat girl onto her lap. Adora nodded, "Better ."

"Y oure awful familiar , *princess* ."

Adora arched an eyebrow, "Hey , it's my language. See body, move body. Body in wrong place, move body again."

Catra snorted and her tail swished, "Sure Iwont distract you here?

"Iwont be doing the talking. Sure you can focus there, kitty cat?" Her hand reached up and stroked the nape of Catra's neck, under her free-flowing mane of hair. The girl shuddered and sagged in Adora's arms, "I..if..you keep doing that, no talking..just.."..

Adora's fingers traced away and ghosted over Catra's shoulder, then she pulled her into a cuddle. Catra's head nestled into the nook of Adora's neck and shoulder. They sat like that for a while, just enjoying the *newness* of this feeling. Adora smiled and sighed, "Ok… so, what happened?"

Catra nodded slowly and her jaw set, "So, yeah..Y ou know..you know *why* Iwas such a doofus?"

"Shadow W eaver?"

"Y eah. I *should* have seen through it. But, well..you've met her . She told me you didnt want to see me. And then that she was angry with you for letting *me* down. You know Iwas always..always wanted her to just *give* me something, anything. And then, bam..There it was. But..but Iknow now . Just like with the bar." Catra' s sniffle was angry, as if she was trying to pull her emotions back inside. Adora tightened her grip slightly and pulled the girl closer.

"She wanted to keep you there?"

Catra nodded, "Why do you think I went to the same University my mom teaches at? Oh it all felt like *my* choice. But she could *help* . Find me tutors, smooth the way, cheaper accommodation... all that. And then... then *you* . It was... complicated. You were." Her voice dropped, "You were my freedom. Something she couldn't take away , or make me ignore. Or break. Or so I thought."

Adora felt the bile again. But it had a newer, more *honest* focus, "Is it bad I... want to end her?"

Catra chuckled, "I haven't got to the best bits yet. So, yeah, she said you made it big. But before that, before... your mom *went* , she'd always go on about how I held you back, how I needed to let you move on... I guess that didn't work so she tried on *me* . Saying how you were distracting *me* . That I needed to have more ambition. More focus. That it wasn't healthy... and that didn't really work either. It hurt, so bad, seeing her being so *disappointed* . But I couldn't give you up. I didn't know why but... I couldn't."

Adora turned Catra's face and gave her a gentle peck on the lips. Her smile was watery and Catra smiled back, "Yeah. I feel you. Stupid, stupid brain."

"Hey , you said it, not me."

Adora nodded and shrugged, "So, what next?"

"Um yeah... she told me you didn't want to talk, had given her express instructions. She said she'd tried to fight, tried to encourage her, but that you'd... bought your way back in. And then she seemed to find out about *Brightmoon* ... And that you had a stake in it."

Adora snorted, "what?"

"Hey , I mean. I was lost. Y ou vanished. no, I know , please.. Please don't look like that. please," Catra cringed faintly and Adora sighed and nodded.

"I can't help it. but. how d' you know? I mean?"..

"Scorpia. Lonnie.. Ye. I'm getting there."

"Ok,"

"So, yeah. anyway , I basically nearly broke before finals. I was so angry, Adora and. it. was with you. t was because of you, or what I thought you' done. And, yeah, I told *everyone* I could. I wanted to hurt you, maybe. maybe make you come back, begging." Adora flinched but Catra's fingers traced her cheek, "I can stop. I can"…

"Not going anywhere, told you. Catra this is going to suck, I know . But I want to get through it. I *need* to. And so do you."

"Y eah. yeah. So, uh, fast forward to, well, now. Or a week ago. That's when it all goes *wrong* . I. I. messed up. With Scorpia. With everyone."

"Y eah," breathed Adora, "you looked fairly *hands on* ."

Catra looked away and swallowed, "Y ou' re going to hate me"…

Adora shook her head, "Too much.can't. Maybe I'll be *annoyed* but let's stop repeating. If you keep saying you can leave, I'll start thinking you want to Catra."

The girl looked back at her and shuddered, "Part of me wants to run. Hide. So I don't see you hate me. Again."

Adora closed her eyes and nodded slowly, "I never *hated* you Catra. Never. I was in pain. I was angry . But I don't think I can ever *hate.* So.. what happened. Did you..did you sleep with?"

"No. NO. No I..I think I've got some shred of decency but..I . *nearly* ..nearly did."

Adora nodded, the bile shifted to jealousy for a moment, "Ok,"

After that night, after you left, Scorpia was so..so excited. We..we kissed. And the worst bit, I felt I *owed* her. And i felt..I felt nothing. But still just danced along with it. Then you came by the next day and..and for a moment i thought I'd *won* . There you were, come crawling back and I could say *no* and move on and you'd..you'd have lost me," she ran her hands over her face and heaved a heavy sigh, "And then you started *talking* Adora. And it felt..true? I guess? That was the first crack, y'know?"

Adora nodded slowly, "Yeah, I suppose."

"And then well, the bar .. Well I wasn't focusing. And Shadow Weaver, she didn't care about the place, it was just supposed to *keep* me

around. I know that now . But then she heard about the fight and that you'd been there and, well...she went ballistic."

"So, the visit?"

"Yeah, Lonnie and Kyle...you know about them , right? And Rojelio?"

"Yeah...it's kind of cute?"

"You have no idea. They're just...So normal. And *kind* , Adora. They were there, all of them when I...when I fell apart."

Adora hung her head, "Because I wasn't there."

Catra tilted Adora's head up with a finger tip. Her voice was raspy and she smiled, "I think you had a damn good reason."

"But your mom...?"

"Went a bit weird, yeah. I missed you and she doubled down, driving that wedge. Went crazy once in public. And nailed it when you did come back. Epic level gaslighting," Catra's voice was a hiss now, low and bitter, "She upped the affection as *soon* as you got back."

Adora shuddered, "Sounds...awful."

"Yeah...Not at the time. Go figure. So, yeah, Lonnie and her BFs

are all suddenly pro you that week. Like because he's seen you up close and mentions you don't look like a carefree millionaire. Lonnie because, y'know, she's actually observant and starts wondering why a wealthy up and comer minds the door of the club she supposedly owns."

Adora snorted, "Yeah, I just love being on the factory floor,"

"Hey it's you. You used to live for bar work"…

Adora shrugged, "Eh, I just think I look super cool spinning cocktails."

"No. You look like you're a second away from breaking *everything*."

"One time, Catra. ONE. Time."

"The only time we let you near the mixers"…

"Ugh, *continue*."

"So, yeah…anyway, they're being observant and actually taking *notice* of things and…and I can't let that happen," Adora frowned at that. Catra pushed a hand over her eyes roughly, "Because, *dummy*, my carefully constructed rationale for going *forward* was based on you being a jerk."

Adora chuckled in spite of herself, "When did you get so self aware,"

"About fourteen hours ago."

That brought out a wince, "Ok, that's a fair turnabout,"

Catra shrugged but Adora can see the pain in her eyes, "It takes a shock I think. And...and I knew, really. I *knew*. But I was hurting, Adora. It felt like you'd left me. I didn't hear from you, none of us did. And yeah... So, anyway. I went on a date with Scorpia. Just felt like I should move on. Or that's what I said. Doubled down. And we went out. And it was...nice? I guess?"

Adora nodded stiffly. Was there a point to this? Part of her wondered if this was another game, whether this was all so Catra could get close to whisper in her ear, to say *And Scorpia's the actual one*. She held herself rigid until her right hand was enveloped by another and a thumb traced itself across her knuckles. Adora managed to swallow, but stared straight ahead. Catra watched her carefully and Adora managed an, "That sounds...like it's leading somewhere."

Catra moved until she was in Adora's eyeline, "It was *nice*. It wasn't *great*. It was *friends* trying to do something that wasn't real."

Adora let out a breath she hadn't been holding and Catra turned to straddle her once again, knees moving to either side of Adora's hips. She leaned her head against the blond's, foreheads pressed together. Adora managed another half grin, "That's good news, y'know. Not, y'know, *complicated* or awkward or...is that why Scorpia nearly attacked me?"

Catra closed her eyes and sighed, but didn't move away, "Yeah. I

was.of f Iguess?And then.Iets just say Im a bit *focused* when Im irritated."

Adora's grin got goofier, "Y ou talked about me."

"Shut *up* . Ididnt *talk* . I *bitched* ."

"Y ou liiiike me. You tried to date and all you could think about was *meeeee* ,"giggled Adora, "Oh come on, let me have this!"

"Iam tempted to re-evaluate my life choices,"growled Catra, but there was no heat there. She grinned and closed her eyes, "Anyway , onto me being a bitch. So, Scorpia end up counselling me, whilst also still.holding out hope?She stews and we tek.but Im really *not* into it?Itry , really.but yeah, nope."

"Never could. Remember when you tried to learn to code?"

"DONT remind me."

"Y eah, Ididnt know you could melt a laptop just by breaking a calculator ap."

"Isaid do...never mind. So, yeah. Scorpia apparently saw you and took that as a moment of opportunity...Unfortunately, by that point my mom had decided that the best way to win was by destroying you. *Somehow* ."

"The accusation?"

Catra bit her lip. "I went with it. We spoke about it midweek? And then she came up with the plan"…

"Hardly complex."

Catra shook her head, "She's not as clever as she thinks."

Adora mused for a moment. She pondered about being angry but cant really feel it. Not now . Because she remembers what Catra looked like in the office, "You didnt want to do it?"

Catra shook her head, "I think things were starting to make sense. And the complaint felt *wrong* . I mean *wrong* . Remember Hordak?" Adora nodded, "And the money? When you got twitchy about the cash?"…

"Yeah?"

"I ratted him out."

Adora blinked, "What?"

"It was it was me. I got him locked away . I got the place closed down. And then my mom slapped me in the street for losing my job"…

"I. I heard."

"Yeah, so...that happened. So, yknow, I do *have* a moral core. I know what *wrong* feels like, even when... when I have a broken heart. Back to my point. We go, we get you in trouble and you actually do your bit better than Shadow Weaver expected. Full on meltdown...Except it doesn't pan out like she wants it to. You're supposed to run, leave town or something. Angela's supposed to fire you. But she doesn't. She tries to *not* fire you. And then she kicked Shadow Weaver and me out and threatened us."

Adora blinked, her chest squeezed tight by Catra's admission of her own heartbreak, and then by Angela's actions, "She what?"

"Said that if we went near you or any of her staff she'd sue. And Shadow Weaver...well she knows Angela. Hell, I know Angela. Girl has *stacks* of cash. And that's when I realised *mom* is just spinning."

Adora frowned, "What?"

"She's not thought it through. She's reacting."

"Huh. She tried to hire me, yknow?"

Catra reared back and stared at Adora, "She did? I mean...she said you *wanted* to work there, that she was considering your offer...I didn't believe."

Adora shook her head, "Nah, she offered, I told her to go away because she is, if you don't mind me saying, *uber weird*."

Catra shook her head and closed her eyes, "Such an idiot. *My* idiot," she seemed to relish the words, then paused and her eyes fluttered open, "Oh, um...yeah, sorry," her hand moved from Adora's to rub the back of her neck. Adora smiled slowly.

"I do like the sound of that. See, you do like me."

"Idiot."

"Your idiot."

Catra purred and then shook herself, "Ok..so, best bit. She goes off, I..head to *Fright Zone* . i guess that's when she tried her headhunter trick. Why, I..don't know ."

"Last ditch attempt to break you. Or try to get me under her thumb?"

"Y eah..she' s had a weird *thing* for you for a while. Should I..be jealous?"

Adora blinked and shuddered, "Not the mood, Catra, why don't you?"

"Thank gods I'm not blood related to that woman."

"Hmm, you could pull the mask of f, maybe?"..

"Not the time for kinky stuf f," Catra leaned down and nipped Adora' s ear, "W e have to work *towards* that,"

"I am very goal oriented,"

"Good to know . Now shush. So, I go back and I have an *intervention* waiting for me. Lonnie is super pissed at me. Scorpia is..is just.. Have you seen Scorpia angry?"

"Uh..no?"

"W ell i have. And I *never* want to see it again. And..and." Catra teared up again. Adora pulled her back in, "Shadow W eaver came back and started talking and..And Scorpia just left. Called me a bad friend and.. Left. Admittedly she said I..used her..which I had. That I had no respect, no *honesty* . That I was just trying to hurt people."…

Adora sighed and pulled Catra closer, "W ell..well fix it. She' s hurt. She had her expectations broken but..you can make it up to her ."

"HOW?" snif fled Catra. Adora smiled gently.

"You're making it up to me. Just don't try to sleep with her? Mixed messages."

Catra choked out a laugh, "Oh. Okay. Yeah, silly me. But. I don't know *how*."

"Talking. And Scorpia is *kind*. Always has been. I think she'll see you. What you're going through. But talking will help. Like now."

Catra pouted, "Yeah but this feels like yanking a razorblade out through my"…

"NOPE! Don't finish that sentence. I didn't realise I was such a chore!

Catra shoved her and shook her head, "Not done, yet. And I'm out of order, it's just a *lot* and it *just* happened so I need to talk about it before I shut down and try to pretend it's *cool*. ANYWAY, so, before Scorpia left... Shadow Weaver came back and called a *team meeting*. She has fuck all to do with the bar. Then says *that*. Anyway, Scorpia's just steaming. Lonnie's steaming behind the bar. *Kyle's* steaming. Rest of the staff have been called in. And then she does this announcement that she's taking a *more active role* and starts talking about rules. And everyone's looking at me wondering *what* the *fuck*. And then she talks about *you*."

Catra's voice is strangely bitter, but distant, like an echo of sadness, "You got jealous?"

Catra nodded, "Yeah, I basically said *what the fuck*. And then Shadow Weaver went on about how we needed new management. And then she told me to sack Lonnie. Lonnie didn't hear, but she… she told me to pick *someone*. To show I *meant business*. And to do it there in front of the rest of the team."

"But you *own* the place! It's *yours*"?

Catra sighed and hung her head, "T urns out Im not so great with *contracts.* Some political activist Im gonna be, huh? So, yeah, turns out Im basically an on-paper part owner , as mom stumped up the cash. Im a nominal manager at *her* discretion. So, she can toss me out whenever. And Ipanic, so Ilsacked Lonnie. Literally told her to clear her locker out, for *not controlling* things, for allowing the fight, for *fraternising* with.with you."

Adora frowned, "Then what? Are your contracts *that broad* that you can do that?"

Catra shrugged, "No contracts, seasonal, temp, all that."

Adora's mind was starting to chug, very slowly. She wasnt sure why , "Ok, anyway , what nek?"

Catra snorted, "That' s when everyone else stood up, gave me the finger and walked out. Thats when Scorpia called me a bad friend."

"They.wow ."

"Yyyeah. And then Shadow W eaver just.lost it. T old me to run the place solo, that Iwasnt gonna get pay , that Iwas.well, you can guess."

Adora whistled, "So.what?"

"Isaid no and then she said she knew Iwas weak.and that you were so much stronger, had more character, surviving a parents death with nothing to show for it, that Ishould have been as strong… and that's when Irealised. Just needed her to, yknow , confirm."

Catra's voice was quiet now , still guilty. Adora hugged her, "So you walked out?"

"I tried. She tried to stop me," Adora swallowed and her breathing became shallow. Her gaze immediately flicked to Catra's arms, then her visible skin. Catra chuckled morosely. "She does the mental stuff *far* better. Threatened me with police, with courts, with...with everything. I just had to be *good* and she'd be *proud*."

"I *am* going to end her," Adora felt Catra cup her face.

"But I left. Said I'd check stocks... Then threw my stuff in a bag, what I could carry. I have... had... have a place above the bar."

"So...so we sort this out," Adora nodded to herself. The rage was back and it wanted *blood*.

"She's...she's too"...

"She's a fucking middle rank lecturer in a shitty subject, with control issues and a bar with no staff. What is she gonna do to me, Catra?"

Catra swallowed, "She could do it to...to me?"...

Adora's gaze went stony, "No. Fucking *no*. No more. She broke us. Just to keep you close. She tried to get her claws into me for *whatever reason*, probably to make you angry, unstable, to get another hook in you. No more. I...I wish I'd known it was this bad back then. I'm sorry Catra, I should be apologising here"...

Lips met hers and Catra held her, then pulled back, "Not your fight dummy... Not back then"...

"My fight *now*," something *dinged* in her brain and she grinned, "And I am not going to fight *fair*."

They sat for a while, just basking. Catra seems lighter, relieved. She had clearly expected Adora to go ballistic, to judge, to shout. But Adora can't really find fault. She can understand. She hadn't exactly reached out until recently herself, after all. And when you drilled down, their reasons were the same.

Love. Too soon, perhaps, to name it...but it was there. Always had been, growing in the dark. Adora closed her eyes and let the word slosh in her head. It felt right. She felt like they'd gotten most of it out now. She spoke briefly about her mother, about her passing. Retread what she'd told Lonnie and Catra listened, silent, save for the odd sniffle and the movement of a hand. They spoke a bit about their more recent pain, which was longing and Adora's vague plan for the coffee shop. She mentioned Perfuma which got a low growl from Catra. Adora felt the girl's tail tighten around her waist and heard a murmured *mine* under her breath. She didn't mention Mermista. Not yet. Then they just stared into each other's eyes, as if afraid the moment would snap and they'd awake, separate, different beds. Still broken.

Adora made a decision.

Catra frowned and then squealed as Adora stood, hoisting her up. Her hands gripped Catra under her thighs and the cat girl panted for a moment, then grinned. Her tail swished back and forth, "What… what are you?"

"I think we've done the emotionally draining talk," murmured Adora, "We can talk strategy...but I think...I think that comes later in the, uh, planning...Agenda...thingie."

Catra draped her arms over Adora's shoulders and leaned close, clearly enjoying how effortlessly Adora was holding her up, "So, remind me...what's next?"

They barely made it to the bedroom.

Chapter 9

Chapter Summary

An ending, once and for all.

Reconciliation, friendships renewed and mended. We go into the last fight, the lines drawn.

And something worth fighting for.

OK. This is a BIG chapter. I was tempted to split it in two, but it kinda flows well for me... let me know what you think!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Bow and Glimmer returned a couple of hours later, their presence announced by loud rattling of keys and theatrical foot-stamps. Adora and Catra glanced up from the stools in the kitchen and Adora gave a little wave, then returned to her conversation with Catra. Their hands were linked across the island in the kitchen, only breaking apart for one to brush the other's hair from their eyes, or for Adora to make some grand gesticulation.

Both girls were flushed and had the sort of grins on their faces that meant *one* thing. Glimmer blinked and glanced at Bow, "D.do *we* look like that?"

One of Catra's ears swivelled and she cackled, then leaned her head back to smirk at Glimmer, "Y eah, like every time I've seen you two."

Bow stifled a snort but Glimmer frowned and stalked over the stools. She drew one out and planted herself on it, "Ok.so, what' s…

what's going on now? You guys have one good night... And that's it?"

Adora smirked, "More like a *very* good morning."

"AGH!" Glimmer planted her hands over her ears. Bow shook his head and moved into the kitchen to make a coffee.

"So, you guys talked it all out?"

Catra dipped her head, suddenly aware she didn't *really* know these people all that well. Adora gave her an encouraging smile and glanced at Bow, "Yeah, mostly. Some... some things to work out, but the big issues, yeah. Handled."

"What little issues might *those* be then?" snarked Glimmer. Adora realised she was trying to gain an upper hand and could recognise her room-mate's trade mark defensiveness. Bow was quiet as he pottered around the kitchen. Adora sighed.

"First of f... arrange a meeting with *your* mom. Second, take down Shadow Weaver. And third, Catra's gonna need to crash here for a few days."

Bow turned and arched an eyebrow and Glimmer raised both of hers, "Uh, Adora... that's kinda a *big thing*. You can't just... just"…

Adora met her stare evenly, "I know. Which is why I'm raising it now. Because Catra's been... evicted by her"…

"Hey, babe... I can talk for myself." Catra was still a *little* waspish, but she squeezed Adora's hand. The blond searched her eyes for a moment, blue and gold lost in slate-grey-blue for the barest of moments. Adora nodded and gave a faint smile. Catra sniffed and jutted her chin forwards, "So, yeah. Short story, my mom's a vicious obsessive with *issues*. And, uh... because... because I didn't, like, back her on the latest crazy shit she's pulled, I may not have a home right now."

Glimmer folded her arms and huffed, "Ok, that's...that's a good reason, *if* I believed it. But...but you *sabotaged* Adora! You set her up, to fail! And taking down *your mom*? Why...so you can get that bar of yours all to yourself?"

Catra bristled but felt Adora squeeze her hand. The blond took a mug of coffee from Bow with a faint smile and tilted her head to regard Catra. The feline girl inhaled slowly and looked back at Glimmer, "What's your *point* sparkles?"

The pink-haired girl pursed her lips then looked at Adora, then back to Catra, "My *point* is: what do you *get* out of this? You've had an agenda against Adora for weeks. You come out of no where, you make her miserable, you help your mom rip her down...after not speaking to her for *months*. What...."

Adora placed her mug down and frowned, "Hey, that's enough Glim. Catra and I have been over this..."

"Yeah, but if you're the *mark* she's feeding you a line," Bow rolled his eyes and Catra snorted.

"Seriously? Did...did you just quote Hustle at me? Sparkles, if I was conning someone, then I'd be doing it to all of you. What, I'd spill the beans under you *intensive interrogation*."

Adora smirked, "Careful, she might get the handcuffs. I know they have at least three pairs."

Catra blinked then blushed and looked away from Glimmer suddenly, then coughed. She composed herself and risked a look at the pink haired girl. She was also flushed but seemed to be marshalling herself. Catra saw her shoot a glare at Adora, who just snorted in response. Catra's gaze tracked to the blond and she couldn't help but smile.

When you've burned through your anger, had your world view shaken and *admitted* your view was wrong, it could leave you

drained. But it allowed you to look at things with fresher eyes. Things were still raw. Still a bit tender. But Adora was.she was *Adora* . Focused. Intense. From her point of view , things were clearer - there'd been a misunderstanding, it was *done* . And she'd work through the insecurities because Catra needed her.

That moment of clarity hit her. Because she knew Adora needed *her* as well. It was evident in the way she'd looked at her in the bar . Outside of Brightmoon. In Angela' s office. There was still scar tissue there. But Catra was going to be *damned* if she lost any more time with this woman. A woman who had every right to resent her. To hold a grudge. But had instead dragged her here, no expectations beyond, maybe, a chance to talk.

Catra realised Glimmer had asked her a question. Adora quirked an eyebrow. She seemed to be encouraging this in some way. Which meant it was probably *ok.*

"Hmm?" said Catra.

"Well?"

"Well what?"

"Ugh! WHAT do you get out of all this?"

Catra blinked, as if confused by the question. She raised a hand and pointed a finger across the kitchen island at Adora, " *Her* ."

Glimmer blinked. Then looked at Adora, who was grinning like an idiot. Then at Bow who had his fist pressed into his mouth, his eyes wide with tears in them. She let out a sigh, then grinned at Catra, "GOOD. Right answer , furball. Glad I didn't have to take you to pound-town."

Silence fell. Adora blinked then snorted so hard she spat coffee out and hacked a cough as she doubled over laughing. Bow covered his face with his hand and heaved silent laughs. Catra stared at her then

qirked a grin, "Uh..that phrase. Idont think it means what you think it means."

Glimmer blanked for a moment and then blanched, "Oh, ugh, well, um, not that..no. Nope. NOPE!Not going there"…

Catra deadpanned, "Afraid were not at that stage of our relationship, Sparkles. But, Im sure, if Adora and i talk more, well… *I 'm liberal* about a lotta things..give me tiiiiime."Adora heaved a breath and shot a mock glare across the island.

"Catra, NO."

Catra smirked and cocked her head, "Blame her!She wants to take me to!"

"SO LUNCH ANYONE!"announced Bow , his grin genuine. Glimmer sagged and shook her head.

"Idont dare ask. Im probably going to mention some sort of.."..

"Y eah, dont finish that sentence Sparkles..so..we cool?"

Glimmer looked at her, then nodded, "Y eah. This..this is a messed up situation buuuut..Adora' s like a labrador. Idont like you, shell do the sad eye thing."

"Oh *god* it's so goofty isnt it?Shes done that since college."

"Y eah!And she thinks it *works* ."

Adora watched the pair banter and looked at Bow, "Im sure Ilike the fact they get on, if Im honest."

Bow shrugged, "Eh, Im just glad we arent witnessing some sort of kung fu flip out."

"Y eah..small mercies."

"So, uh…plans?"

"Lunch? Thinking maybe takeout? Don't want to go outside today… Feel I've earned an actual day of f…and then we've *all* got things to discuss."

Bow nodded, "Kinda what I was leaning to. You going through with this Union thing?"

Adora nodded, "Gotta offer the option. *Brightmoon* isn't a big issue… but the *Fright Zone*? Yeah, we need to fix that place. It's gonna close again and it's…it's too important to let it go down that way."

"Not investing too much in a totemic representation of your relationship then?" Bow sipped his coffee and Adora leaned her head back, "What?"

"That was the most pretentious sentence you've ever said."

"Eh, I dabble in psychology. And is it?"

"Maybe…But also, Catra's got a lot tied up in the place. If it goes down, it needs to be in a controlled way. Not because a crazy lady decided she was a de facto sole leader. Because I bet you anything she'll have made it so Catra's liable."

Bow nodded slowly, "Cool."

The quartet settled down and exchanged some more light conversation. Takeout was decided upon, the team going for a sushi option because, in Catra's words, *fish is life*. Glimmer shifted her focus to Adora.

"So. Plan?"

Adora chewed her lip for a moment, "Today…today I just want to relax. I think I… *we* need it. Oh, food, film, bed?"

Bow chimed in, "Not with *my* girl I hope!"

Catra leaned across the island and gripped Adora's hand, then glared at the other couple, "Yeah, no, prefer my own ticket to po-"

"Can we *please* move on from that!" begged Glimmer, "Um, so, what about my mom? She's.. she still wants to talk, Adora."

The blond nodded, "Ok, I'll call her tomorrow, setup a meeting. But I need to do my own things first, ok?" Glimmer nodded rapidly, "And it's not the end of the world, Glim. Just.. better contracts, security/ insurance! Why is that a *bad* thing, huh?"

Glimmer sighed and shuffled, "I guess it isn't. But what if th staff like.. gang up and"…

Catra cackled again, her hugh pitched giggle jarring the serious tone, "It isn't, like, a dictatorship, Sparkles.. They aren't gonna built barricades in the break room and start waving flags."

"Oh yeah, what about *your* bar then?"

Catra paused, then shrugged, "Gotta make it *my* bar. And then… yeah. I don't want to run a place where people.. where people are afraid of me. Lived enough of a life like that." her voice trailed off at the end. Adora stood, walked around the island and hugged her. Catra swivelled and curled up in the taller girl's arms, whilst Adora rested her chin atop Catra's head. One of the girl's ears flickered as Adora blew on it gently.

After eating they spent the next couple of hours just relaxing, draped over sofas. Conversation was easy and seemed to skirt the more difficult topics. AS afternoon drifted towards evening, they decided an earlier night might be on the cards and retired to their respective rooms. Catra watched as Adora fired off a few more messages. She seemed so assured, so confident. Then she glanced at Catra and semed to waver for a moment. With a breath the blond sat next to her on the bed and searched the feline's eyes, "You sure.. you, uh.. you don't want me on the couch? I mean, we've.. I.. know we've"…

Catra crossed her legs and leaned back on the mattress. She jutted her chest forward slightly and her tail whipped from side to side, "What, lost interest already?" her voice was coy , but she swallowed at the end in spite of herself.

The blond inhaled and turned to face the cat-girl. She reached out and cupped a hand to Catra's face, "I'm..I'm not great at this Catra. We're *here* . But we..we seem to be just blazing ahead and I don't want this to..I can't have it just being about..physical"…

Catra rolled her eyes and stood. Adora paled and seemed to freeze, then flushed as Catra walked in front of her and pushed her flat onto the bed. The feline then crawled up her and straddled the blond. But instead of stroking and touching, she sat upright and crossed her arms, "See, I stopped myself. But I'm going to make this *clear* for you Adora. You know I don't like repeating myself"…

Adora smirked suddenly, "What? My name was on loop earlier"…

Catra fumed and swatted at the girl, then grinned, "Shut *up* idiot. My point is..as I said..I..fucked up. And I haven't *seen* you. And I nearly didn't get to see you , "she gestured at the bags, "What if you'd left town? Or I had..if..I'd just not"…

Adora reached up and pulled the girl down atop her, then enveloped her in her arms, "Ok..ok. W e're ok. I just don't want us to be so fast"…

"Why not?" Catra' s voice was muffled against her shoulder. Adora opened her mouth, then shut it again. She tried again, then frowned.

"Huh..Um, well, because..because you..rush in and. Um. Y ou might..make mistakes?" It sounded relatively weak to her .

The feline pulled back, face neutral, "Y ou think this is a mistake?"

Adora pursed her lips and frowned, "Not what I said. I said moving fast could mean we *make* mistakes. Overstep. Don't take

notice...but..but part of me doesnt care, yknow?..Because we do know each other, bar that stupid, wasted bit last year."

Catra searched her face and nodded slowly, then cupped Adora's face with her hands, "I will go at whatever pace...Whatever you need. And..and please be patient with me, when i get..too… yknow what I mean, right?"

Adora smiled softly, "Yeah, I do. But...we're still sleeping in the same bed. I really *really* don't want to not have you nearby."

In response, Catra purred and nuzzled closer. She rolled off Adora and pulled in against her side. Their legs tangle together and Catra's tail rested just above Adora's knee, "Yeah, same. Remember in our apartment, we used to just fall asleep in each other's beds after shift, 'cos we couldn't stop talking?"

"Heh..how'd we miss the signs?"

"What was it Scorp said? Gals being pals?"

Adora laughed, more a bark of a laugh, "Yeah..now she's one to talk."..she trailed off. Catra had gone quiet, "Tomorrow?"

The catgirl looked up and nodded quietly, "Yeah..I think...I think I need to fix *that* too."

Adora swallowed, "I, uh..if..you do, yknow..I guess I understand. She's great. Really nice. And she cares and"…

Catra grabbed her face again, "You're making me repeat myself, Adora. I will get mad,"Adora flushed and nodded, then Catra pulled her in for a kiss that made Adora's brain forget math for a moment. They parted with a gasp, eyes wide. Catra swallowed, "Uh..too much?"

Adora shook her head and went back in. They were gentle, slow, tentative. When they broke apart next, the pair settled and relaxed,

falling into a shared pattern of breathing and calm, until the sun set and all fell to silence.

There were worse ways to end a day. But not many better ways.

Monday was a *busy* day. First, Adora messaged Lonnie with a request, using her as a marshalling point. She finished her missive with a simple request:

A: Be kind

L: It was messed up, Dor….

A: Just listen to her. Be kind.

L: K. Will see what I can do.

Next on the agenda was brunch with [redacted]. They'd cleared their schedule, an indicator of how keen the rep was to make headway with the two biggest bars in the city. Adora and Catra headed to the same diner Adora had met [redacted] the first time.

They found the Rep in the same booth, nursing a large thermos of coffee. The green-skin wore thick sunglasses and an expression of acute misery.

"Ladies. A pleasure to see you again Adora. And who's this feisty little kitten. OHHHH *Fight Zone* girl… And look at you two, belles of the ball! Sure you need representation, kitten, you look happy enough to throw it all in here," they winked and Catra blinked, faintly blindsided. She glanced at Adora.

"Uh...hi...nice to meet you."

"Don't mind the glasses. I made the mistake of deciding I could keep up with this lizard from the Swamps. You know, they make their own moonshine down there from *bark*? Also, other things, but hey ho, don't dwell. Suffice to say, darlings, that stuff strips paint and braincells. NEVER doing that again. Until I do. Or the lizard is *hot*. Had abs for *days*."

Adora couldn't help but shake her head, "You up for helping or do we need to just...reschedule."

"I never miss my cue, blondie. Neither rain, nor sleet, nor the hangover from Prime's sculpted ass can stop me. Just makes it *interesting*. So...I take it now you've brought this delightful creature with you that things have changed, hmmm?"

Adora nodded slowly, "Yeah...with *Brightmoon* only a little bit...but with the *Fright Zone*, it's more complicated."

"Namely because short, dark and sexy here is one of the *management* hmm? Oh don't mind me, kitten. I have a *thing* for authority figures." They slid the sunglasses down their nose and winked, "I like putting them in their place."

Catra shivered slightly and Adora clicked her fingers between them, "Hey. Don't push it. Appreciate the help, but please don't hit on my girlfriend."

Silence descended and Adora replayed that last sentence in her head. They rested their head on a clawed hand, "Don't hit on your girlfriend *when you're here* or just not at all, 'cos if she's receptive, well...free country"...

Catra's hand shot out and gripped Adora's. She turned to regard her, "Um...you mean that? Not...not just...Words?"...

Adora nodded stiffly, "Yeah...yeah I do."

"What happened to moving fast?"

"Fuck it."

Catra grinned, then looked at ID and shook her head, "We're exclusive."

A waitress wandered over and ID ordered a couple of coffees for the girls, then looked at the pair and grinned, "*Good*. Ground rules - always a good opener in any negotiation. Now we've got the nature of your relationship established, that'll be one less avenue for Angela and…Your co-manager to use against you."

Adora and Catra blinked, faintly confused, "So you…uh…weren't trying?" murmured Catra.

ID looked up, "Honey, I *never* try. I *do*. Of course, should this," they waved at the pair, "Change, hit me up. All the same to me, darling. But, and I'll be honest, I don't think you want what I'm selling. Not when you have what she can give you on *tap*."

Their face softened and Adora felt a pang of something. Not pity, precisely. But something akin to sadness. And she couldn't quite pin down why. She brushed it off and nodded, "Thanks, uh…That's helpful. So, how do we, well…do this?"

ID leaned back and rubbed their temples, "Conversation. Set terms. Manage expectations. It's *rarely* a done thing first time round. Have you got a day in mind? It might involve… *Lawyers*. Angela will likely not want to give too much up. Bigwigs rarely do. It's the *principle*."

"And if she doesn't?"

"Well, get your friends to sign up, then we declare the bar not supported by Union staff and boycott. Run a little campaign here, raise awareness there…but…hmm." ID regarded the pair and then gestured between them, "I'm being slow. You tried to get *her* in trouble and now you're…doing whatever it is you do. You could

damage *Brightmoon* quite well by doing this. you got a clear conscience kitty kat? Because i dont like my people being used in company games."

Their voice was harsher now and Catra blinked, "What, no! I... want the same for The *Fright Zone* . had too many shitty bosses, shitty attitudes... just shitty things. T rying to do one good thing and everyone thinks I'm an asshole!"

She made to stand but Adora held onto her and glared at ID , "trust her."

The rep folded their arms and cocked their head, "Ok. f that' s the case, then you need to be at the meeting with Angela. State for the record you intend to implement a pro-union policy at the *Fright Zone* . And then we run a release to that effect *this week* ."

Catra blinked, "Uh, well, um... it might not be that easy ."

"Oh? Backing out? Not so clear on your scheme?"

Catra glared, "No, asshole, my *mom* ."

"W ait, What?" ID looked very confused. Adora inhaled and rattled out a *very* abbreviated version of Catra's involvement with the *Fright Zone* . ID stared, then looked back at Catra, "She made you *fire* someone in front of an audience?" Catra nodded, "And you did it?" Catra winced, "But then you left? W ow.. that' s a level I've not seen in a while. Not a fun technique - seen some senior HR reps do that - made middle managers do the dirty work... thought they could pretend to be the good guys. Never works for long."

Adora squeezed Catra' s hand and focused back on ID , "So? How do we solve that?"

The rep took off their sunglasses, then opened the thermos. The smell of something that definitely *wasn't* coffee assailed them - sweet, sickly. Apple scented with a tinge of bitter alcohol, "Y eha thisll

kickstart the afternoon. Oh, hmm? Solve your issue? Easy." they grinned and leaned forward to whisper. Catra and Adora sat back and exchanged dubious glances.

"That's it?"

"Oh yes. Bit of theatre, bit of provocation, bit of *bad R* . Plus I do have a legal team I work with. It's the same principle we'll use with *Brightmoon* . And if, as you so eloquently put it, this Shadow W eaver doesn't *give a flying fuck* about the bar, she'll try to fold. Unless she's in at the deep end, then we'll... then it's court."

The trio spoke a while longer, with D fishing a few files from their bag, perched near the booth. It detailed Etherian legal rights for employees (Even freelance), as well as a few bylaws for Thaymor itself. D laid out a few avenues and then settled back. Adora traced her finger down one of the files, "So, uh... we just... run with this?"

"Honey , *I* run with this. You two are there to look pretty and serious while I bend Angela's head around the rules so hard she'll go cross eyed...".

Adora nodded, "Ok... just be sure you don't do more of that... sexual stuff around her. It can be... a bit gross."

D held up their hands, "Fair , that's fair. Apologies. I am *so used* to my clique. The humour doesn't translate without context and... well, without context, yes it's gross. I'm sorry ," they pouted, but the words seemed genuine, "Anyway , let me know when you've confirmed the meeting with Angela, line me up and I'll be there. And... yes, we sort out Brightmoon, with some provisions and *then* we deal with the *Fight Zone* . Kiten, mind firing me across a copy of the purchase agreement? And your own contract?"

Catra frowned, then nodded. She fished her phone out and started searching her emails and storage. She tapped the screen with a claw and sent the mail, "Why's that important?"

"Ohhh don't worry yourself about that. Not too much. Just covering all the avenues, honey. Gotta prepare for any ad libbing from the peanut gallery, y'know?"

"Nope, really don't,"

"Your loss. Now, if you'll both excuse me?"

And with that, the Union rep waltzed from the diner. All high heels, hot pants and leather jacket. Catra couldn't help but shake her head, "Wow."

"A day in and you're already eyeing up alternatives?" smirked Adora. Catra blinked and shook her head rapidly.

"*Nope*. Can you imagine? You'd be competing with *their* ego. I know you like to look at me, so I don't have to worry about breaking every mirror around the place."

Adora mused and nodded, "Guilty as charged. So... ready for the next big thing?"

Catra winced and nodded. Considering what they'd just discussed with Hordak, this next bit was fairly key. They stood, paid for their drinks, then left.

Perfuma's coffee shop was much more crowded than usual. That was due to the crush of bodies from *Brightmoon* and *The Fright Zone*. Or rather, the staff of both establishments. They'd formed two unofficial groups in the place and their presence seemed to be driving some of the other customers away.

Not that Perfuma was complaining - she was gleefully engaged with Seahawk, as he tried to describe a *perfect* cup of tea that Mermista wanted. Said girl was slouched in a chair nearby with a few other

members of the bar staff. Even Huntara was in attendance. Bow and Glimmer perched near the counter trying to reign in Seahawk's enthusiasm. A worthless endeavour, clearly.

The *Fright Zone* contingent were hunkered around Lonnie, with Scorpia off to one side. She looked miserable. The rest just seemed despondent. Some of the admin staff for the bar, the ones who ran the accounts and the hiring were also there. The *Fright Zone* didn't seem to outsource, unlike *Brightmoon*, so was a bit of a smaller enterprise with regard to its paper footprint.

The hubbub slowed as Adora and Catra entered. Catra's ears flattened and her tail swished from side to side. She averted her eyes and looked about to bolt. But Adora's hand found hers and lifted it. Adora brought Catra's fingers to her lips, "Not going anywhere. You got this," she untangled her hand and stepped behind the counter to help Perfuma - she was, after all, on the clock.

Across the room, Scorpia's face was unreadable. Catra took a breath and nodded to Adora, then stalked over to the *Fright Zone* group. She shuffled her feet and swallowed, then took them all in, "Uh...hi...um...before, before you guys say anything, rip me a new one, I need to just, y'know, get some shit out there."

Lonnie leaned back in her seat and arched an eyebrow. Next to her, Kyle perched on Rogelio's knee. The pair watched her impassively. Octavia and a couple of the other bar staff sat, waiting. Catra breathed in and swallowed, then squeezed her eyes shut. Her fists clenched next to her and she trembled for a moment. A claw settled on her shoulder and her eyes shot open to regard. Scorpia stared at her with concerned eyes. There was hurt there too. Catra swallowed a lump and opened her mouth. Then she shuddered a breath and threw her arms around Scorpia's waist. The big woman blinked in surprise and patted the cat-girl on the back, "Uh...ok, not expecting that. You're...um, you aren't...cos Adora's, like, *right there* and you guys seem to be, well, um, a *thing* now?"

Lonnie blinked, then looked at Adora then back at Catra, "Hell, girl, that's, what, hate to banging in a *day* . Shit."

Catra heaved a shuddering sob and pulled away from Scorpia. She ignored Lonnie, "I've been… I've been a *really* bad friend. And a *shit* boss."

Lonnie coughed, "Well… you were a bit *mean* …"

"Shut up Lonnie," murumurred Catra. But she turned and smiled at him softly, "Kidding, kidding… but yeah, I have got… some ground to make up. And… and I don't expect *any* of you to back me. Because what I did I did because I was a coward. And I let someone take advantage, *continued* to let them take advantage and that just… spilled onto you."

Scorpia nodded slowly, still frowning, "Your mom?"

"Yeah. Scorp, I don't expect you to forgive me. I was in a lot of pain because *she* lied to me. Tried to break me apart, tried to keep her hooks in. And those hooks are still there, I'm still *not* certain. And I *used* you to help me act on the fear. And that was… that was *gross* and *wrong* . You're just this ball of… good, y'know . And I don't deserve the kindness you gave, or the… the *love* ."

Scorpia's lip wobbled. Catra was about to speak again but the big woman scooped her up into a bear hug, "Oh Wildcat… I just… I just want you to *smile* . To be happy."

Catra sniffled and nodded, then took a deep breath when Scorpia released her, "I guess. But it still was *shitty* of me to do what I did. I like you Scorpia, I do. But…"

The big woman smiled sadly and nodded, "I kinda guessed, Wildcat. You don't try to get a rise outta someone unless they *mean* something to you. I was hoping you'd… you'd get over it, maybe."

Catra nodded quickly, "I know. And...and what I did was *bad*. I nearly lost her because of it. But, she's good people. And I made you all think she wasn't. Because I wanted to believe that. So, um, I know we can't be *friends* right now, I get that. You guys have a right to be angry. Especially you Lonnie."

The girl snorted and waved a hand, "Yeah public sacking. Way to get on my *good* side Catra."

"Yeah I know...which is why I have a plan...if you guys'll hear me out. Or...um... *Adora* has a plan. Two birds, one stone...and then, well...you can do what you guys want. You always *could* but I don't expect anything. So, y'know, I'm not trying to get anything outta this, other than scrapping that utter *harridan* that is my mom."

Lonnie leaned forwards, "I'm listening...".

Across the cafe, Adora leaned against the counter and watched Catra begin her reconciliation. It was good she was doing it now, not letting it fester over days or weeks. She knew the two of them still had things to work through. The newness would wear off and, maybe, there'd be issues. But that was what everyone dealt with - learning to live with each other and the pain. And to overcome that pain.

She was damn sure she'd *make* them both overcome it. And if, one day, they didn't feel that way anymore, she'd be able to step away knowing she'd given it her all. A voice in the back of her mind, her mother's voice: *You deserve love, too, Adora*. SOmehow the idea of them *not* working was alien to her.

"I see it now," Perfuma's voice broke through her reverie.

"Huh?"

"Your aura. I thought it was muted, darker...but it was just *incomplete*," Perfuma gave her a lopsided grin, "I never stood a chance, did I?

Adora chuckled and shook her head, "I don't think I did either. Just… trying to make up for lost time. I'm so angry it got *stolen*. By some… weird, I have no idea.." she exhaled sharply and Seahawk leaned in.

"A journey for vengeance is on the cards, perhaps? Are we to embark on *adv-*"

Mermista was suddenly there and her hand clapped across Seahawk's mouth. Her light brown skin was flushed with irritation and she flicked her black tresses over a shoulder as she drawled, "Don't say it. You'll set Bow off. Then *Glimmer* will kill someone."

Adroa tried to school her features. She could feel Glimmer staring at her, *daring* her to say something. She coughed, instead, then spoke, "Uh, about the whole vengeance thing. Not quite. I do have a plan *but*.. we kinda of need your help, guys. So… Perfuma here gave me this contact and, well.. we need to Unionise."

The rest of the *Brightmoon* staff stared at her. Mermista crinkled her nose, "Ewww .. that sounds.. kinda anarchistic, yknow?"

"What, arguing for fair pay is a *bad* thing?"

"Isn't it.. like.. ganging up?"

Adora fixed her with a flat look, "Say Angela fires you because she thinks you've skimmed the register. No proof, just up and gone. Then she tells the other bar owners. That's your rep *dusted*. Sorry, Glim, just using your mom as an example. What do you do? I know you have family to fall back on, but what about Cynthia? Or Justina? Or any others? Temp contracts that basically just say what our hourly pay is? Nothing about protections, cover if we get felt up or something worse in the bar?"

Mermista frowned at that then huffed, "*Fiiine*. We all heard what… went down. So, what, we all march on Angela's office?"

Adora smiled faintly, "No. part of *my* problem goes away because Catra's kinda retracted her objection? But it leaves the underlying issue of *trust* . So, well negotiate. All I need is for you guys to consider it. I'm gonna try to get some Union compliance in place, some protections. You don't *have* to sign up. but it'd help. Glim, I need a meeting, maybe Thursday? Gives ID a chance to meet everyone, tell them what's up?"

Glimmer nodded, her face set in a concerned grimace, "You're sure Adora?"

"Yes. My worry is. what if Angela has to sell? What happens then? This isn't about poor behaviours, not just that. no it's about stuff we can't see coming. I don't want to tie her hands, but we just want some security. What if the next owner's a Shadow Weaver? Or we have to change jobs and end up working for someone like that? We need to normalise this stuff. And the Alliance can help with that. Plus, well. you're gonna be a manager and you can help make sure the Alliance doesn't take the piss, right?"

"Well, I am a bit of a hard ass," grinned Glimmer . Seahawk frowned.

"That's not what Bow says." the aforementioned Bow was waving his hands in a *stop now* gesture behind Glimmer's head. Adora stepped in before things got worse.

"Ok, cool. So, guys, I'm gonna set up a talk, tomorrow , with ID and. well go from there, ok?"

Footsteps made her turn and she blinked as Scorpia paused in front of her. The big woman scratched behind her neck with her claw, then set her face in a stern expression. Or her best approximation of one. Her eyes were too kind, though. Scorpia had let her hair grow out a little into a short bob rather than her usual shaved sides and cropped top. It was a cute look.

"Hi Adora. So, um Catra's explained a few things and. well… Lonnie explained some other things and, well, so did you if we're

being 100% honest and you know me, I'm *always* looking to be straight as an *arrow* . And I wanted to *apologise* . For blocking you. For *confronting* you in the gym. That was *not cool* . I thought i was being a good friend but, well, I messed up big time. I let you down twice."

Adora smiled and patted Scorpia's arm, "Hey , we all make mistakes. We..we learn and we grow , right? *Y* ou were always encouraging us to *talk* our issues out, back in the *Fright Zone* . To not just get angry . We tried, but we failed one time. And that is *no ones* fault other than Shadow Weaver's."

Scorpia nodded and let out a breath, "Thanks Adora. I appreciate that. But, well, I'd be a bad friend if I didn't also say that, well...I was jealous. I am, kinda, still? Maybe?"

"If it' s any consolation..so was I"

The big woman flushed and swallowed, "Huh, we are a bit messed up, aren't we?"

"No kidding. I mean have you *looked* at yourself, Scorp? *Y* ou're a *catch* . Any other day, well..I'd be being a bit on the *keen* side, know what I mean?" she said that through the side of her mouth. Scorpia grinned and shook her head.

"Ok, I'll let that pass, but none of this to *any other girls* ok - won't have Catra being"…

Adora reached out and placed a hand on Scorpia's claw and fixed her gaze on the woman' s face, "W e've had a shite year . A hell of a year. This is new, it's painful. But I will not do *anything* to fuck it up. Or her. I..I have to be honest, Scorpia. She' s..she' s my world. Has been since Uni. I've felt empty without her . So, don't worry . And if I do fuck it up, I expect you there to kick my ass."

Scorpia swallowed and smiled, then hugged Adora tight, "I can't be mad at you. Or jealous! Gosh why do you make it so *hard* Adora?"

Scorpia spun her around and Adora caught the expression on Perfuma's face - a slightly confused and dazed look. When Scorpia deposited her on the ground Adora had to lean against the counter and inhale heavily. She looked up at Perfuma who seemed to be a bit dazed herself, "Uh...hey Scorpia, have I introduced you to Perfuma?"

The taller woman frowned at Adora then at the girl behind the counter, "Oh, uh...no. First time in here, just came 'cos Lonnie said and, well, it's real nice. Great ambience. You work here? Of course, what am i saying, you're, like, wearing the uniform and"...

Adora interrupted, "Well, Perfuma's been a great friend and, well... she's looking for staff, if you don't want to stick with the *Fight Zone*. And she's a *great* listener. Gave me some sound advice, y'know?"

Perfuma shot her a *what are you doing* look. Adora just grinned back. Scorpia tapped her chin and looked at Perfuma. Then she blushed, "Well, uh, I do need a new coffee place. Gotta, y'know, get good tea from somewhere and the big chains are just *the worst* with tea leaves."

"OH! Leaves? Not bags?" perfuma blinked, stirred from her deer-in-headlight look.

"Of course! More flavour that way! Gotta steep them properly, maybe add a bit of honey and, well"...

"Oh! Well, I can see you know your, um, your teas"...

"Are you kidding, grew up in Scorpion Hill - we invented chai! Plus all types of honeyed ginseng, cinamon...do you have a tea menu, I could, maybe, um..."

Adora stepped away as the pair and adjusted her jacket collar with a pop. Catra detached from the *Fight Zone* crew. She glanced over at Scorpia and frowned, "Uh...what...what did you do?"

The blond grinned widely, "I am a *genius*."

Catra grimaced, "You did not just give Scorpia a rebound girl."

"I gave Scorpia a rebound girl."

"That is the *worst idea ever.*"

"It is the *best* idea ever. Scorpia is straightforward. This way, she doesn't have to dwell and be irritated aaaaand..well..Perfuma is *very* decisive. Also, doesn't mess about. So, you can rest assured, Scorpia won't be bounced around. Unless she *wants* to be."…

Catra winced, "Eesh, you're as bad as Sparkles."…

"I *heard that!*"

The tension in the room faded and the two groups began to mingle. Adora worked, cleaning filters, making more coffees and generally trying to earn her pay. At her break she plopped into a booth and fired off a few messages to Bow to setup the briefing. Catra slotted herself into Adora's lap, as if afraid a lack of skin-to-skin meant Adora'd vanish. Eventually, after a few hours, the group broke apart. Glimmer and the *Brightmoon* crew moved to head to work. Before she left, she paused at the counter, where Adora continued to work whilst Catra leaned against it, watching with curiosity. She laid a hand on Adora's shoulder, "See you back home?" Catra noticed that the question was directed at *both* of them and she couldn't help but choke up a little.

Adora smiled and nodded. The *Night Owners* left shortly after and promised to regroup the following day. When the shop emptied, the pair moved to a table and sat in companionable silence. Adora glanced at her and tilted her head, "Hey."

"Hey yourself."

"So, i was thinking..would you like to go on a date?"

"Think you'll get lucky?"

"85% sure."

Catra smirked, "So confident. When?"

"Right now? We've done a coffee date, how about dinner?"

"Sounds... nice."

Catra kept herself occupied for another hour until Adora's shift ended. Smiling, they stood and left, hand in hand. Not a care in the world. As they left, they noticed that Scorpia and Perfuma were still engrossed in a conversation at the counter, the tanned blonde leaning forwards with a hand on Scorpia's outstretched claw. Catra rolled her eyes and Adora chuckled.

"Best. Idea. Ever."

"Dork."

The next couple of days were, to put it mildly, *stressful*. To the point that their little bubble was threatened with bursting. first the meeting, then... the rest.

First off, the meetings with HQ and the wider groups got *tense*. Years of cultural opposition to the very *idea* of unions, or grouping together made some temper run high. The main objection being that *"if I can't stand up for myself, why bother"*. Catra felt despondent and the sudden barrage of messages from her mother, alternating between wheedling and outright vitriolic sent her into a funk.

She was withdraw in the meetings, which they held in Perfuma's cafe. The silver lining was that Ilona was *incredibly* good on a public stage. They fielded complaints and queries like a fencer riposted against thrusts and swipes.

"Darlings, let me reframe your objection. You think this is all about how *hard* you work? How you *earn* things? And that unions will take that away, turn you into some sort of, what... idler? POSH POSH my naive nuggets. Fair work for fair reward, that's your goal, right? Well, surely you expect your bosses to honour that, right?"

That got a chorus of mild assent. Octavia seemed the most skeptical of the *Fight Owners*. But then again, she had a *bad* history and had done it with *no* support. One blind eye was testament to that, "Seems like you wanna force the bosses to just *give* us things. Even with Shadow weaver, seems weird. What, we screw Catra over too?"

Ilona smiled, "Honey, no. This will actually *protect* the darling kitty kat. I could bore you with jargon or Powerpoints, but I promised I would never torture anyone without their consent, so unless everyone here works out a safe word, I wont do that. No, what this does is it gives *everyone* a fair shake. No favouritism. Legal protection. Prevention of heavy-handedness and abrupt dismissal. But it also engages the employers in a set level of expectations from their *employees*. And gives you a layer of protection. Now you, you look like you'd chew up someone and throw them about. I *like* that. But can everyone do what you do? What if they have to work three jobs? They don't have time to grow your fantastic set of abs."

Octavia shrugged, "Why is that my problem?"

"OOOOh throw a person under a bus why dontcha? You'd let these guys take a hit so you'd be happy, hmmm?" Octavia shuffled her feet awkwardly and Ilona softened their tone, "I get it. I've *been* there. Number uno, ticket for one, all that. No, honey. This isn't Us vs Them. This is about *support* and giving you all something to base your relationship off, not the generosity of others. Stability. Why fight

every day if you don't need to, it's *exhausting*. And any boss that doesn't want you to have some support, who says they'll look after you? Remember, they have teams, they have lawyers, they have the means. What good are promises? Can you pay rent with good intentions?"

Octavia frowned, "Catra's been pretty good..."

"Yeah, but now you have a Hell-Bitch in charge. And what if the place goes under? Where's your guarantee on insurance? Remember, employee and employer? It's a *business* relationship. You do work, they pay you. It's not favours. You think suppliers would take that sort of language from a business? Guarantees? Promises? No. That's why they have contracts, penalty clauses. Don't think of yourself as someone being done a favour. You are a business of ONE. You provide services. You are paid for rendering them. Got it, flaunt it. Greatest trick capital pulled, making you feel grateful for providing your labour for a pittance."

Adora inhaled and settled back. They'd been stalking atop a table, commanding the room. Adora lounged to one side, half a smirk on her face. Catra had her knees to her chest, tail wrapped tightly around her legs. Adora had a hand on her shoulder, grounding her, "You want to go?"

"No. Just... not sure I can do this. I mean, it changes *everything*. Can I... can I even be friendly with... with people? What's the like?"...

"Shhh baby. Look, it's not like an iron door. Just means, well.. in work there's lines. Obligations. And it means *you're* cool too."

Catra nodded. But that wasn't the real issue. And they both knew it. She was *half* the problem.

The *Fright Zoners* and *Brightmooners* were fairly on board, but were *sold* when Adora ran through a piece on Thaymor employment law and commitments that employers had to offer. And also, a nice little piece on contract law, pertaining to permanent staff. And what *constituted*

contract staff. Health, pension, *holiday* . Not just shifts and favours, but actual lines in the sand. Even Glimmer looked interested. Adora zeroed in on her .

"Pinky, you're management, right? Good to have you here, you little spy," she winked at her , no venom in his words, "This is something your books may gloss over. Liabilities. Some companies try to pull the whole *everyone's contract* .well, you do that you'll end up alienating people. Because no matter how *keen* they are, you fail to guarantee working days to keep them off the books for tax reasons, you'll get a *rep* . And you'll spend more money on training than you would if you just *paid* these fuckers, ok?"

Glimmer nodded. The meeting rattled on. By the end, everyone seemed enthused, tentatively excited. Adora descended from the table and stood in front of Adora. She grinned, "Nicely done."

"Darling, this is *peanuts* . Give me a *challenge* . When are we seeing the Queen?"

"Glim got it moved to tomorrow. Angela' s out of town on another conference for her other interest"…

"OH! Great, means she'll be a bit of f balance. Shouldn't be too hard. And I promise, Pinky , we won't go hard. Your mom, *loathe* as I am to say it, seems ok from a management perspective. *Mostly* . I know people who know people and her heart is in the right place. But, girl, good intent is nothing if she gets hit by a bus."

Glimmer had joined them and grimaced, "That' s not .that' s… Ugh, fine, point taken."

"Hey she gets it! Miracles do happen. You ok, Kitten?" Adora' s face shifted to an arched expression, actual concern bleeding through. Catra glanced at them and shrugged, "Ah. the hell-bitch, right?"

"Still my mom"…

"Nah, honey . Hell bitch. Mom's dont gaslight. Girl, trust me. Ican see it in you, you want to go crawling back, hope that maybe, maybe, throwing this away," he gestured to Adora, "will buy you that love?"

Adora flinched and her hand began to move off Catra's shoulder. The feline girl caught it and held on for dear life. The blond swallowed and sqatted nekto her . Catra whispered, harshly, "No. This is not worth her version of *love* . She's.she' s my mom. She's just.."

"Something else now , right kten? What she thinks is best aint what's best, k? Y ou got this Adora?"

The blond nodded, "Y eah.and once we've done Angela.then we *deal* with Shadow Weaver."

"Oh yeah, I *L ike* that. Oh, kten.check your mail. Ithink itll help with those nerves. Had a friend go over your contract…Y ou really should read those, by the way. Nasty thing."

ID hefted their shoulder bag and departed with a sauntering wave. Catra frowned and fished out her phone while Adora held her. She flicked through her emails and found one from ID with an attached file detailed her contract. t had "ed pen" annotations all over it. Mostly qestion marks and exlamation marks. And then a brief summary. Catra snorted and then grinned. She turned to Adora.

"Oh.oh this is *good* ."

Adora read the mail and a slow smile spread across her face, "Bring on Thursday"…

"Hell. Y es."

The meeting with Angela was not nearly as fraught as Adora was expecting. But it was still *tense.* Adora arrived with DD, Catra and Glimmer and marched straight to the woman's office. It was strange being back in the bar after so long. To her credit, the woman's surprise last only *so* long.

"Adora, I thought we were to have a more…one to one meeting."

Adora reached across the table and extended a hand, "Not quite Angela, I did send an agenda for Glimmer to share with you."

"Well, I thought that was a *formality*."

DD frowned, "Sound a lot like trivialising an employees concerns there, Ms Queen."

Angela flicked her gaze to him, "And you are?"

"My apologies, Double Trouble, attorney, representative of the Alliance Union. We represent the majority of service works in the hospitality and retail sector of Thaymor and most of Etheria."

Angela twitched and looked at Adora, "Union? Is that what this is? I thought we were going to move beyond"…

Glimmer piped up, "Don't get bullish, mom."

"Glimmer! I did not raise you to be so"…

"Am I a manager or a *daughter* right now, mom? Do I get a say when I agree with you and told to get back in my lane when I don't? Do I forfeit my pay when I stop acting like a manager and we start talking or bickering?"

Angela paused and frowned, "No, not at all, it's just that, well"…

Adora leaned forwards, "We've three things to discuss, Angela. First, my suspension and the actions you took. Second, the staff's unionising and further engagement with management. And last, my continued employment as well as the prospective employment of the rest of the staff, should you decide to take *punitive* action for this."

Angela reared back, "I would *not* do that! I'm not"…

Catra smiled, "Shadow Weaver? It's ok, you can say it."

The tall woman seemed to be reeling a little. She managed to zero in on Catra and blinked, "Ms Weaver… and you're here because?"

Catra held up Adora's hand, "We resolved our issues. Also, to tell you that the prior complaint was a fabrication in an attempt to fracture things further that you *totally* bought like a pawn and lastly to announce that I intend to make the *Fright Zone* union compliant, with all staff to receive contracts reflecting that. And that we'll be announcing it publicly as part of a drive for employment rights in Thaymor overall."

Angela blinked and Adora smiled faintly, "Yeah, competition will look pretty progressive. And I've seen their contracts, in draft," That was a *bit* of a lie. I'd and Catra had gone over some initial ideas, "For bar work it's pretty good. Health, pension for permanent staff, guaranteed shift and holiday days."

"Adora, haven't we been flexible? We accommodate your needs and your learning and"…

Adora scoffed, "Great. And it's appreciated. But what about someone else you *don't* feel so close to, Angela? I'm sorry to be blunt… but if I didn't know you? Would you? What's the limit of that generosity? My contract is… very vague. Hours, pay scale, but nothing in there about my study days or flexibility. What if you and Glimmer just up and go? New management won't honour that. And then I'd be up ended."

TD coughed and interjected. Adora was "bad cop" here - the belligerent employee. They were to be the peacemaker, "Ms Queen. Adora is feeling somewhat vexed, as I'm sure you can understand. She doesn't know what her right to respond is - you suspended her based on a single complaint."

"She... she did admit," but Angela dry washed her hands as she spoke and immediately looked guilty.

"In a room with two hostile individuals and an *authority figure*."

"She's a grown woman!"

"So is your daughter, also an employee, and I just saw you talk down to her like a child," TD smirked and cocked their head to one side, "Ms Queen, I will not tell you how to run your business. I WILL tell you how it looks to your employees. Dismissing their concerns and hoping your benevolence will carry them through... honey that's a *crap* long term strategy. And I know you're a savvy businesswoman. Your other concerns have solid contracts, have recourse to HR, to firmly established relations between management. Why is this bar different? Because it's your daughter's *friends*?"

Angela cringed slightly and Glimmer glared, "You think this is... this is just fun, don't you?" Glimmer looked ready to stand, to rail at her mother. But *Catra* put her hand on the girl's arm, then looked to the tall woman.

"Ms Queen... I've seen where bad leadership goes. It leads to a whole bar staff walking out. It leads to bitterness. It leads to relationships *breaking*. Lack of respect... that's what you're risking now. For *what* thought? You're a clever woman, I know that and I'm... not that observant, y'know?"

She looked at Adora and squeezed her hand. Adora smiled back and looked at Angela, "This... whole thing has shown we need more surety. What if you aren't around, Angela, to mediate or pass judgement? Some certainty, some understanding. That this isn't

some party. That people can, maybe, think about this place as somewhere to have a career, not just a saturday job. Make this place somewhere they feel *secure* in."

ID stood and pulled some files from their case, "And beyond the emotional gamut, I have a few things that should appeal to your more *corporate* concerns. First one, returns on investment. You can see in the graphs form our surveyed companies that, well, it's a *hell* of a lot cheaper to keep people on board than retraining every few months - savings on wastage in the service sector *alone* - wasted drinks, food, all that from staff wasting it during training."

Angela looked dazed but flicked through the files. Her face shifted to a more businesslike focus and she nodded slowly, "That's certainly an avenue I hadn't applied *here*... Strange, i think about it elsewhere but...".

"A bar seems more like fun, right?" grinned ID, "Who cares if a glass smashes, someone spills their first mojito? But let me say, that shit adds up, not to mention the *stains*. OOF! Second file, cost of insurance claims *against* you for damages, versus coverage if employees are on a plan. They could sue you without proper contractual coverage," Angela's eyes widened, "And the third is class action suits for unfair dismissal or *bullying*... which covers a multitude of sins. Again, basic contracts, understanding prevents spurious allegations. Protects *you* as well."

Angela blinked and frowned, then looked at ID, "I get the feeling I'm being blackmailed but with things that could actually *help* me. What's your game?"

ID placed their hands against their chest and gasped, "My *game*? As if fighting for the little guy wasn't reward *enough*?"

Angela set her face in a deadpan expression, "Hardly."

"Oh ya got me, honey. Firstly, I'm saving my venom for someone who deserves it," Angela's gaze flickered across to Catra and she

seemed to soften a little, "And, well... imagine, two of the hottest bars in the city, publicly acknowledging and promoting employee care? Maybe not front page stuff, but showing they've got decent practices? Puts the pressure on others. You're public venues! Harder to raise the plight of warehouse staff, retailers and all that... out of sight out of mind. But you, Angela Queen, on a big speech blurb? Talking about understanding the vulnerability of the *common woman* Or man. Or, well, I don't care. Helps me a *lot*."

"And you're fine with being used like this Adora?"

The blond shrugged, "You shot me down with barely a question, Angela. Let me be shrieked at in this office. I don't do anything but react. At least I *know* what I'm getting into here. I've also got other options lined up. And I'm a paid up member of the Union. What we're asking is simply better contracts, clearly defined benefits and an understanding of where we stand. A guarantee for pay so we can live and plan, rather than just feeling at some... whim," she sighed, "I don't *blame* you Angela. But I need stability. For my own sanity. I can't work somewhere where I feel unsure of where I stand. Or if I do something that will get me fired tomorrow when it wouldn't have the day before."

Angela watched her, then flicked her gaze to Glimmer. She sagged and heaved a sigh, but was silent for a while. She fidgeted with the files and the paper on her desk, "I think I owe you an apology, Adora. It's something that's been in the back of my mind these past few days. I thought I had provided a safe space. A place where people felt comfortable, relaxed. I thought that... without all that bureaucracy I could provide something *directly*. That... that trust alone would be enough. But trust goes *both* ways. I had trusted you and wanted you to all trust me... but I failed that trust first."

Adora stayed silent and Glimmer adjusted herself, "Is that all, mom?"

"No, Glimmer... I wanted this to teach you... about leadership. About handling your friends as employees. But I properly buggered that up as well. Shielding you from the difficult conversations,

focusing you on the *business* side, forgetting that employees are *also* the business side. Hardly an exemplary education," she heaved a sigh, then looked at Dan. "I accede to your demands. What would you have of me."

The union rep blinked, then laughed and clapped his hands, "Carte blanche? Would a yacht do? Oh *honey* I'm messing. No, simple, really. Contract issue, let me step in and help your HR teams pull something together. Interim standardised contracts until those are complete to allow your people to work with a sense of security. And then my people and yours can work on some sort of press release, in conjunction with *The Fight Zone*."

They waffled along, back and forth, but by the end it all seemed relatively amicable. At the end, Angela stood and moved around the table. She offered Adora her hand.

"As I said, I owe you an apology. I believe this would fall under unfair suspension. Despite your protestations that you were at fault. I failed in my role as your manager. And as a *friend*, Adora. I will ensure your pay is backdated and you receive a comprehensive contract. Please let me know when you would like to discuss the specifics. I would love for you to stay and we can discuss in what capacity would be sufficient."

Adora took the hand and shook it, "Thank you, Angela. I've got another small side gig. But let's talk. I do like it here but, y'know how it is."

"Indeed I do, my dear. And once again, I am sorry. Your friend, Double Trouble, can even quote me on that in their official capacity."

As they left the bar, Catra cracked her knuckles and inhaled, "One down."

Adora nodded, "One more to go."

Catra had set up the meeting, basically a simple text asking to catch up at *The Fight Zone* . No meandering, no prevarication. D had simply said that I'm here, may as well do it now ," if anything they seemed more eager than Adora or Catra.

They walked to the bar in silence. They'd been over this a few times, reviewed the contracts, reviewed the purchase agreement, hell, practically analysed the very *paper* it was written on. The risk now was that their agreement with Angela had assumed that the *Fight Zone* would also be pro-union. That had been a gamble - if they couldn't pull this off then Angela could likely refuse to as well. She wasn't *likely* to but it would have consequences for their relationship with her - negotiating in bad faith, perhaps.

The bar itself looked very closed. Considering all the staff had, essentially, upped and left, that wasn't surprising. And Catra doubted that Shadow Weaver had "lowered" herself to menial things like stocking a bar or engaging with the *hoi polloi* .

They went to the front door and Catra tried her keys. They didn't work. D actually chuckled, "W ell that's *dumb* ."

Catra heaved a sighed and then knocked. There was the sound of rattling keys and sliding bolts. Then the door slid open. Shadow Weaver stepped back and strode to a table set up in the middle of the room. It had two chairs only . She sat down and crossed her legs, a smirk on her slightly scarred features, the domino mask highlighting the cold eyes that seemed to only now take note of Adora and D .

"Oh, Catra... Not brave enough to face the consequences alone? Or have you come to present Adora as the better option?"

Catra frowned and shook her head, "You are something else. Why'd you change the locks?"

"After you proved you were not...worthy, well, it seemed prudent. Didn't want you stealing anything."

"I *own* the bar!"

"Only partly, little one. The rest is *mine*. Adora, you see what I have to work with? So flighty, unreliable. Please tell me you're here to pick up things? I know...I know, it was wrong of me to go to Angela, but Catra was so wound up, how could I not look after her? You can see how upset she is. But now...with you in charge, we can make this a success! And Catra...well, Catra can have you around...and maybe learn something."

Double Trouble cocked their head to one side and exhaled, "DAMN. You didn't say she was *this* bad kitty kat? I was expecting thrown glasses or...well...Not this,"

"And you are?" there was a glass of wine on the table and Shadow Weaver brought it to her lips. Adora couldn't help but snort. That drew the woman's attention, "Something amuses you?"

"I mean...are you trying for a villain vibe? Cos that's what I'm getting? Are you about to reveal your grand scheme?" she crossed her arms and shook her head at the older woman, "In answer, no, not here to do...whatever weird thing you think I'd do. I'm here for *her*."

Catra reached out and grasped Adora's hand and smiled at her, then turned her glare to her mother. Or *foster* mother she reminded herself. Not Step mom. Not *mom*. Acquaintance was closer to the mark. Shadow Weaver sighed, "Catra...I tried to protect you from this. Mixing business and pleasure... ...and, really, this girl *vanished* and..."...

"If you're gonna go with that excuse, why do you want to *hire* her?"

"To inculcate a better attitude. Where I failed with you, maybe I can succeed with someone with *more* potential."

Catra inhaled but didn't flash. Adora spoke before her, "Lady, I work the door at a bar. I'm happy doing that, for now. Maybe I'll run a yoga studio some day. What, you're gonna groom me to, what? Do paperwork? Maybe temp at the uni? God no."

"Adora, I'm trying to help you both and"…

"Oh that's *my* cue!" DT stepped forward, "Fun as this is, it's like talking to a *wall*. You, Mrs Weaver, are not offering anything. We have yet to hear terms, benefits, *compensation*."

She flicked her gaze back to DT, "What has this got to do with you?" her voice dripped condescension.

"Honey it has *everything* to do with me. Double T rouble. And I'm here to serve your ass to hell and back. Your people are unionising. And they want to have a *word*."

The door behind them opened again and the *Fright Zone* staff entered. Shadow Weaver stiffened, "What is the meaning of this?"

"Oh just my theatrics, Mrs Weaver. See, I represent the Alliance Union. These people are now members. And we have a *litany* of complaints against management. Which, legally, we are allowed to backdate! Ain't law *amazing*? Oh I practice that too, sister. I *say* practice. I make it my *biiiiitch*."

Double T rouble fished some folders from their pack and slapped them down on the table. Catra stepped forward and smiled, "Hey Shadow Weaver, so, yeah, wanted to talk about a few things," her blood was up, but she kept her jitters down, "First of f - *making* me fire Lonnie."

Shadow Weaver turned her impassive stare on Catra, "You're the manager. The owner. Says it clear as day. All on *you* Catra."

"You're co manager"…

Shadow Weaver shrugged, "I never *made* you do anything. We all have choices Catra. You just went with the easy ones."

Adora had never wanted to hurt someone *so much* in her entire life. She could see Catra caught between the ingrained fear, the gaslit responses and her fury. But Double T rouble stepped in.

"So, you're claiming you *aren't* liable?"

Shadow Weaver smirked, "I partly own the place, but I'm hardly management, now am I? I merely wished to give my *daughter* an opportunity, to let her learn leadership. And she *failed* ."

Double T mused for a moment then glanced at the gathered employees, "Ah, so what you're saying is I should direct this class action lawsuit of these employees against your daughter?"

Shadow Weaver blinked, "What?"

"Oh, just the employees want to raise one, in violation of a number of employment guidelines and laws relating to their compensation, pay and waiving of their rights by this establishment."

Shadow Weaver blinked, "What are you babbling about, you insufferable cretin?"

Double T stepped back and placed a palm against their forehead, "Oh! I am *wounded* ," they straightened and fixed Shadow W eaver with an even stare, "Basically , she-bitch, you have screwed up. First, coercion. Under Thaymor employment law, encouraging an employee to act in a way that could be deemed unlawful *or* in a way that is contrary to established employment law is illegal. Compound that if said action pertains on whether this act was *against* a fellow employee. For those at the back, that includes management interactions *with* employees So, you," they aimed finger guns at

Shadow Weaver, "got *her*," aiming at Catra, "To fire *her*," aiming at Lonnie.

"Yes, why is a sacked employee here?"

"Permitted on premises to clear out their belonging and also appeal their statutory firing. Also, as a contract employee, they are entitled to a notice period unless they were involved in an illegal activity. Were they involved in a legal activity? We can get the police, take some statements?"

Shadow Weaver's gaze flicked around. She found no support. Instead she focused on Catra, "What is this farce?" Lonnie clicked their fingers in Shadow Weaver's face.

"Uh uh uh, eyes on me *sister*. SECOND, but related, violation of notice period. Third, fairly to adequately compensate, FOURTH, failure to provide physical contractual material to staff, *FIFTH*, tax evasion"…

Shadow Weaver jolted, "What?"

"You are an employee of Mystacor University. You draw a salary. That salary is taxed," Shadow Weaver glared, "BUT on all purchase documents of this bar, you are listed as an *anonymous* owner. Meaning this place is namely in *Catras* name. But she has a contract with said *anonymous* owner detailing a variety of expectations and obligations of a manger. And that makes *no sense* if she owns the place"…

Shadow Weaver gripped her glass tighter but didn't look away. Adora folded her arms. Catra was silent, her tail moving from side to side. Lonnie made a gesture, as if confused. Catra spoke up, "So if you're anonymous, you don't hold an *official* role… But you *have* done so and you've been drawing a salary. So, either you *are* management and thus have authority, in which case you are liable to said lawsuit *or* you don't and you're committing Tax evasion, fraud...."

Adora covered their mouth in mock surprise, "OH MY GOODNESS! And have you *declared* that? We stack that on top of all this, it amounts to an abuse of power mandate. And, well, there's a *lot* of media scrutiny on that right now. Seeing how Prime industries is being looked into for it's treatment of people like drones...how *would* the university react when they find out that one of their middle of the road lecturers was involved in employee abuse *and* tax evasion."

Shadow Weaver shook and then snarled at Catra, "How dare you drag this...this *filth* in here. These spurious accusations. When I get you alone I'll...".

Adore stepped forward and her knuckles hit the table, "Another word...and I'll fold you like fucking origami. And we'll call it self defence."

Shadow Weaver swallowed at Adora's baleful stare, then looked at Catra. The heterochromatic eyes fixed her in place. The girl wasn't backing down. Shadow Weaver inhaled, then spoke, calmer

"What do you *want*?"

Catra shrugged, "The bar. You gone. We're going pro union. I owe it to these guys. They did for me what you *never* did. But, for the sake of all that you *did* do, when you weren't fucking up..." she swallowed and caught Adora's encouraging gaze, "You sign over the rest of the ownership to *me*. We can even work out a repayment plan in *reasonable* instalments. You step away. You do *not* contact me or mine again. And in return, we don't action that lawsuit, drag you out of the shadows as a tax evading bully. You keep teaching, we play nice, don't talk and everyone's happy."

Shadow Weaver twitched, then looked at the files on the table, "I could drag you down with me, Catra. This is *your* bar. I could ruin you. I could ruin your Adora."

Catra snarled, "Look at you. I'm trying for nice and all you can do is try to...what, make me feel shit? Make me scared? Fuck you. I'm

done with this. I'll , email all that to the bar, to the papers, to whoever. Let's just do this then."

She pushed back from the table and stood. Adora smirked at Shadow Weaver and turned with her. The masked woman stared between them as I'll hooked their phone from a pocket. As did all the employees. Catra paused and turned, "Oh and we did record this conversation..y.know , just in case. W e might incriminate ourselves, what with Adora being overprotective. But you just admitted complicity and awareness of what you're doing..so, yeah, we can all go down together. By Shadow Weaver."

"W ...wait!" the woman held up a shaking hand. She stumbled to her feet and swallowed, "Alright..alright..Y ou..you win."

I'll grinned and flourished a piece of paper from their bag, "Oh good. I took the liberty of contacting the holding company of the bar 's license and the commercial office..just in case," they winked at Catra, "Sign here, here and *here* . I'll have a read...And that should show your acquiescence of intent. W ell contact you about finalising the arrangement. Please don't think about trying to outrun this. I'm *bi*/*on* .we know people."

Shadow Weaver hunched over the table and scrawled on the paper, then stalked towards the door. The employees parted until Catra coughed. The woman paused and turned. Catra smirked, "Keys?"

Shadow Weaver fished them out of a pocket hidden on her jacket *somewhere* . She handed them to Catra, but then gripped her hands. A small, genuine smile ghosted over her face, "I am..proud of you Catra. You have done what I raised you to do - to be strong,defiant to the end. You're *welcome* ."

And with that, she was gone. Catra stood there, keys in hand, shaking. She grit her teeth and flinched as arms wrapped around her. She turned her glare only to be met by kind blue eyes. She immediately relaxed. Adora smirked.

"She really loves getting the last word in, huh?"

"You have no idea babe." Then she looked at the group, "Guys… thank you. Now, who wants a *DRINK!?*"

The group cheered and Adora moved to the bar. She vaulted it and rooted around, then turned to the group, "Guys, your night of fun bar girl this evening. ID, what are you having?"

"Honey, I'll drink what *ever* you're serving."

Catra sidled up to th bar whilst Rogelio, Lonnie and Kyle shouted their orders out. Scorpia and Octavia high fived her as she moved through, with some of the others hugging her and congratulating her as they moved past. Someone flicked the music on and Adora worked like a demon, her motions showing she hadn't forgotten her old hustle.

She settled into a seat next to ID and eyed them, "Not flirting with my girl are you?"

"Eh, she's got *fantastic* abs. But never mix business and pleasure,.... Too much. What's life without risk? But, *no*. I'm no homewrecker."

"Decent of you."

"Boundaries, kitten. They're important. Work, life, everything. Protect us as much as anything. You need to *know* what you want and where you stand. Life's fucked up enough as it is."

"Amen. And, well, thank you. For this."

"Honey, I am but a humble middle-person. Thank *her*. [CAROUSEL]. She has a *lot* of tension to work off," Catra laughed and slapped the Union rep on the back, then looked at her *girlfriend*. The blond turned her way and grinned.

"So, what's the pretty lady having tonight?"

"You try that on all the girls at the bar?"

"Only the pretty cat ones," Adora smiled.

"And does it work?"

"I don't know... has it?"

"Get me a glass of white and we'll see,"

One large white was slid across the bar, as if pre-prepared. Catra arched an eyebrow. Adora shrugged and Catra leaned forward, "So... doing anything later?"

"You make a habit of asking out bar girls?"

Catra met Adora's blue eyes and smiled fondly, "Only one. Wish I'd done it sooner."

Adora blushed, "Well, we're here now. That's what matters," They leaned across the bar and kissed. Around them, the crew cheered and clapped. They pulled back and Adora blinked her face a glazed mask of bliss. Catra giggled.

"You ok there, Princess?"

"Yeah... yeah. Really good."

"So... you didn't answer my question. What are you doing later?"

Adora arched an eyebrow, "I'd you say you had an apartment here?" Catra nodded mutely. Adora's grin became arch, "How d'ya feel about your bar girls working late?"

"I'm... I'm sure I can work out an overtime plan."

"I'm all about putting in the hours."

Catra snorted and ID was barely keeping a straight face nek to them. They practically yelled, "GET A ROOM!" Catra leaned forward and whispered, "So you, uh... gonna fold me like *origami* later?"

Adora groaned and ran a hand over her face, "I *thought* it sounded cool!"

The cat-girl giggle her rasping giggle, "W orked for me."

They both blushed but grinned at each other. Adora glanced down and tutted, "Still not wearing shoes though."

"What, you gonna refuse me service in my own bar?"

Adora winked, "Not if you play your cards right, Catra."

With that, she moved down the bar to get top ups for the rest of the team. Catra watched her go. For the first time in a long while she didnt feel anxious. Afraid. *L ost* . She felt *home* . And she knew, from the way Adora practically floated down the bar, that she felt the same. t'd been traumatic, intense. But they'd broken ground on something *new* . Something *good.* .

She couldnt wait to see where it led them nek

Chapter End Notes

So... how'd you like THA T?

Good? Cathartic?

ts a LONG one, but Iwanted to round this of f. Imay do an epilogue - let me know what you reckon, whether Idid them justice! Or if you want MOAR!

Feed me, Seymour!

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